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SPEAK FOR YOURSELF

AN INTRODUCTION TO PUBLIC SPEAKING

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COMMUNICATE • CONNECT • LEAD

Dedication

To Gilbert Collins

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Speak for Yourself: An Introduction to Public Speaking

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This book is intended for educational use in public speaking and oral communication courses.

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Chapter 1

BECOMING A PUBLIC SPEAKER

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why public speaking is an important academic, professional, and civic skill.
2. Identify the major forms of human communication.
3. Describe the basic elements of the communication process.
4. Explain how noise, context, and purpose affect public speaking.
5. Recognize the importance of inclusive and audience-centered communication.
6. Identify the five canons of rhetoric and explain how they apply to public speaking today.

Whether at work, in the classroom, online, or with friends, the ability to speak clearly and confidently to an audience is empowering. Public speaking gives you the tools to express ideas, advocate for yourself and others, participate in important conversations, and build credibility in academic, professional, and civic life.

This book introduces the essential building blocks of public speaking. You will learn how to select a topic, analyze an audience, organize ideas, support claims with credible evidence, use language responsibly, manage speech anxiety, and deliver a message with purpose. When these skills are practiced, they can help you deliver compelling presentations in a variety of situations.

Public speaking is not only about standing in front of a room. Today, speakers communicate in classrooms, workplaces, community meetings, video conferences, podcasts, social media platforms, and digital learning environments. The tools have changed, but the central challenge remains the same: how do you create a message that is clear, ethical, audience-centered, and worth listening to?

SKILLS TO PAY THE BILLS

Public speaking is a valuable skill for anyone who wants to take an active role in the world. It is both a life skill and a professional skill. Employers consistently value people who can explain ideas clearly, listen carefully, work with others, solve problems, and communicate with confidence.

Public speaking also helps you become more adaptable. A strong speaker can introduce themselves in an interview, explain a project to a team, present research in a classroom, advocate for a cause, lead a meeting, respond to questions, and communicate under pressure. These skills are useful in nearly every career.

In a world shaped by rapid technological change, communication skills are becoming even more important. Artificial intelligence, automation, and digital tools can assist with writing, research, and design, but they do not replace the human ability to connect with an audience. Speakers still need judgment, credibility, presence, empathy, and purpose. A polished slide deck or AI-generated outline cannot rescue a speaker who does not understand their message or their audience.

Public speaking teaches you how to think before you speak. That alone is worth the price of admission.

CIVIC DUTY

Public speaking can help you grow personally and professionally, but it also prepares you to participate in public life. Civic participation is not limited to voting or running for office. People use public speaking when they attend city council meetings, speak at school board meetings, advocate for community needs, organize campaigns, participate in public comment, give testimony, raise awareness, or speak up when something needs to change.

Many people feel disconnected from politics and public institutions. Some feel their voices do not matter. Others are frustrated by polarization, misinformation, inequality, or the feeling that public conversations have become more about winning than understanding. These concerns are real, but they also make communication skills more necessary, not less.

A healthy public culture depends on people who can listen, think critically, disagree responsibly, support claims with evidence, and speak with both conviction and respect. Public speaking gives you a way to enter the conversation rather than simply watch it happen around you.

In this course, you will gain practice discussing topics that matter to you. You will learn how to use argument not as a weapon, but as a tool for constructive purpose. You will also develop the "rules of engagement" for public discourse: listen carefully, support your claims, respect your audience, respond to opposing views fairly, and speak with integrity.

Public speaking does not guarantee that everyone will agree with you. That is not the point. The goal is to become the kind of speaker who can contribute thoughtfully, responsibly, and persuasively to the conversations that shape your community.

BE AN INCLUSIVE SPEAKER

Audiences want to feel recognized and respected. They want to know that the speaker has considered their experiences, needs, and perspectives. Inclusive speaking means making communication choices that help more people feel seen, respected, and able to participate.

Inclusive speaking begins with audience awareness. No audience is made up of only one kind of person. Even when people share a classroom, workplace, major, neighborhood, or interest, they may differ in culture, race, ethnicity, gender identity, age, sexuality, religion, disability, language background, political perspective, socioeconomic status, citizenship status, family structure, and life experience.

A speaker does not need to know everything about every audience member. That would be impossible. But a thoughtful speaker avoids careless assumptions. For example, do not assume that everyone has the same family structure, economic background, religious beliefs, physical ability, gender identity, political views, or access to technology. Do not assume that a joke will land the same way for everyone. Do not assume that your personal experience is universal.

Inclusive language is one part of inclusive speaking. Use words that are accurate, respectful, and appropriate to the audience and occasion. Avoid language that stereotypes, excludes, demeans, or reduces people to a single characteristic. When referring to groups of people, use terms that are current and respectful. When possible, refer to people the way they refer to themselves.

Inclusive speaking does not mean avoiding every difficult topic. In fact, public speaking often requires us to discuss complicated, uncomfortable, or controversial issues. The goal is not to make every speech harmless or bland. The goal is to handle serious subjects with care, accuracy, and respect.

No matter how passionately you feel about a topic, admired speakers understand that audiences may include people with different experiences and beliefs. Respecting those differences does not weaken your message. It strengthens your credibility.

FORMS OF COMMUNICATION

Human communication can be understood through several major forms: dyadic communication, small group communication, mass communication, and public speaking.

DYADIC COMMUNICATION

Dyadic communication happens between two people. A conversation between friends, a job interview, a meeting with a professor, or a discussion with a classmate are all examples of dyadic communication. This type of communication usu-

ally allows for immediate feedback. Both people can ask questions, clarify meaning, respond to body language, and adjust the conversation as it unfolds.

SMALL GROUP COMMUNICATION

Small group communication involves a small number of people who can see and speak directly with one another. Study groups, project teams, workplace committees, production teams, and planning meetings are examples of small group communication. In small groups, people often share ideas, solve problems, make decisions, and divide responsibilities.

MASS COMMUNICATION

Mass communication occurs when a message is sent to a large audience, often through media or technology. Television, radio, podcasts, newspapers, websites, social media platforms, streaming video, and other digital channels can all be forms of mass communication. In mass communication, the audience is usually large, dispersed, and not directly present with the speaker or creator. Feedback may happen, but it is often delayed, limited, or filtered through comments, analytics, ratings, likes, shares, or responses.

PUBLIC SPEAKING

Public speaking occurs when a speaker delivers a purposeful message to an audience. The audience may be physically present in the room or present through a digital platform such as Zoom, a webinar, livestream, or recorded video. In public speaking, the speaker has a specific reason for speaking, and the audience gives the speaker attention for a period of time.

Public speaking is usually more planned and structured than casual conversation. Speakers organize their ideas, adapt to their audience, use supporting material, and make choices about delivery. Public speaking may inform, persuade, entertain, commemorate, inspire, or call people to action.

BASIC ELEMENTS OF COMMUNICATION

In any communication situation, including public speaking, several elements are involved: the source, receiver, message, channel, feedback, noise, context, and shared meaning.

The **source**, or sender, is the person who creates the message. In public speaking, the source is the speaker.

Encoding is the process of turning thoughts into words, images, sounds, gestures, or other symbols. When you decide how to explain an idea, choose your examples, design your slides, or practice your delivery, you are encoding your message.

The **receiver** is the person or group interpreting the message. In public speaking, the receivers are the audience members.

Decoding is the process of interpreting the message. Audience members decode meaning through their own experiences, knowledge, attitudes, beliefs, emotions, and expectations. This is one reason the same speech may affect different audience members in different ways.

The message is the content being communicated. It includes the speaker's words, structure, supporting material, examples, visuals, tone, gestures, facial expressions, and overall delivery.

The channel is the medium through which the message travels. In a face-to-face speech, the channel includes sound waves, body language, and visual cues in the physical space. In a digital presentation, the channel may include a webcam, microphone, internet connection, slides, chat box, or recording platform. Other channels include television, podcasts, livestreams, social media, and video-sharing platforms.

Feedback is the audience's response to the message. Feedback can be verbal or nonverbal. Audience members may nod, smile, look confused, laugh, take notes, ask questions, check their phones, or respond in a chat. Effective speakers pay attention to feedback and adjust when appropriate.

Noise is anything that interferes with the communication process. Noise can make it harder for the audience to receive, understand, or remember the message.

Physical noise includes distractions in the environment, such as construction sounds, a ringing phone, poor lighting, a broken microphone, or people talking nearby.

Physiological noise comes from the body, such as hunger, fatigue, illness, pain, or lack of sleep. Anyone who has tried to listen while hungry knows the stomach can become a persuasive little monster.

Psychological noise includes internal distractions such as anxiety, stress, daydreaming, defensiveness, or worrying about something unrelated to the speech.

Semantic noise occurs when language creates confusion. This can happen when a speaker uses unfamiliar vocabulary, jargon, slang, vague terms, or words that carry different meanings for different people. For example, using a complex technical term without defining it may cause the audience to lose the point.

Digital noise can occur in online or technology-mediated communication. Poor Wi-Fi, lagging audio, distracting notifications, bad lighting, unclear slides, frozen video, or competing tabs can all interfere with a message.

CONTEXT AND PURPOSE

Context is anything that influences the speaker, audience, occasion, setting, and message. A speech does not happen in a vacuum. The same words can have

different meanings depending on who says them, where they are said, when they are said, why they are said, and who is listening.

For example, a humorous story told at a wedding may be appropriate in that setting but inappropriate during a formal workplace presentation. A personal example that connects deeply with one audience may confuse another audience if the speaker does not provide enough background. A word, image, or reference may carry different meanings across cultures, generations, communities, or historical moments.

Context also includes the communication environment. Are you speaking in person or online? Is the audience required to be there or did they choose to attend? Is the topic sensitive? Is the audience informed or unfamiliar with the subject? Are they likely to agree, disagree, or feel undecided? A strong speaker considers these questions before deciding what to say and how to say it.

Purpose is the reason for the speech. Good speeches need a purpose. Otherwise, why do it?

Ask yourself: What do I want the audience to understand, feel, believe, or do as a result of this speech? Developing a clear purpose early in the process helps you make better choices about your topic, research, organization, language, and delivery.

SHARED MEANING

Shared meaning is the mutual understanding created between speaker and audience. At the most basic level, shared meaning means the audience understands the message. At a deeper level, shared meaning occurs when the speaker and audience connect around an idea, value, story, or purpose.

This does not mean every audience member will agree with the speaker. Agreement and understanding are not the same thing. A person can understand your message and still disagree with your conclusion. In public speaking, shared meaning means your message is clear enough for the audience to follow, evaluate, and respond to thoughtfully.

Keeping your speeches audience-centered will help you create shared meaning. Audience-centered speaking means keeping the needs, values, knowledge, attitudes, and expectations of your listeners in focus. It does not mean telling the audience only what they want to hear. It means building a message they can understand and take seriously.

THE CLASSICAL ROOTS OF PUBLIC SPEAKING

The art of effective persuasive speech, or rhetoric, has deep historical roots. In ancient Greece, public speaking was closely connected to civic life. In Athens, citizens gathered in public spaces to discuss issues, debate policies, and participate in democratic decision-making. Later, in the Roman Republic, citizens and leaders used public speaking in forums, courts, and political assemblies.

Rhetoric was not simply the art of sounding impressive. It was the study and practice of discovering what to say, organizing ideas, choosing effective language, remembering the message, and delivering it with skill.

The Roman statesman and orator Cicero helped define the process of preparing a speech through the five canons of rhetoric. These canons still influence public speaking, writing, communication, and performance today.

1. *Inventio,* or invention, refers to discovering and developing your ideas and arguments. In modern public speaking, invention includes brainstorming topics, researching evidence, identifying claims, and deciding what your speech is really about.

2. *Dispositio,* or arrangement, refers to organizing your ideas for maximum clarity and impact. Today, this includes creating introductions, main points, transitions, conclusions, and outlines.

3. *Elocutio,* or style, refers to the language choices a speaker uses to express ideas. Style includes word choice, sentence structure, imagery, tone, rhythm, and clarity.

4. *Memoria,* or memory, traditionally referred to memorizing speeches and storing useful examples, quotations, and arguments. Today, memory also includes preparation, rehearsal, familiarity with your material, and the ability to speak confidently without reading every word.

5. *Actio,* or delivery, refers to the physical and vocal presentation of the speech. Delivery includes voice, gestures, posture, eye contact, facial expression, movement, pronunciation, pacing, and presence.

The five canons remind us that public speaking is not one skill. It is a process. Strong speakers do not simply "wing it." They develop ideas, organize them, choose language carefully, rehearse, and deliver with purpose.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Public speaking is an essential skill for academic, professional, personal, and civic life. It helps people express ideas, build confidence, advocate for change, and participate in public conversations.

Effective speakers are audience-centered. They consider the needs, values, experiences, and expectations of their listeners. Inclusive speakers avoid careless assumptions and use language that respects the dignity of audience members.

Communication includes a source, receiver, message, channel, feedback, noise, context, purpose, and shared meaning. Speakers must understand how these elements work together in both in-person and digital environments.

Public speaking also has deep roots in the rhetorical traditions of ancient Greece and Rome. Cicero's five canons of rhetoric—invention, arrangement, style, memory, and delivery—continue to provide a useful framework for preparing and presenting speeches today.

KEY TERMS

Public speaking

Dyadic communication

Small group communication

Mass communication

Source

Receiver

Encoding

Decoding

Message

Channel

Feedback

Noise

Physical noise

Physiological noise

Psychological noise

Semantic noise

Digital noise

Context

Purpose

Shared meaning

Audience-centered speaking

Inclusive speaking

Rhetoric

Five canons of rhetoric

Invention

Arrangement

Style

Memory

Delivery

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is public speaking still important in a world where people communicate through texts, emails, videos, and social media?

2. What is the difference between speaking to impress an audience and speaking to connect with an audience?

3. What are some assumptions speakers should avoid making about their audiences?

4. How can a speaker discuss a controversial topic while still being respectful and ethical?

5. Which type of noise affects you most as a listener: physical, physiological, psychological, semantic, or digital? Why?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

Think of a time when you had to explain something to another person or group. This could be a class presentation, job interview, team meeting, family conversation, video call, or social media post.

Write a brief response to the following questions:

1. Who was your audience?

2. What was your purpose?

3. What channel did you use?

4. What kind of noise or distraction affected the communication?

5. How could you make the message clearer if you had to deliver it again?

Chapter 2

OVERVIEW OF A SPEECH

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Identify the major steps involved in preparing a speech.
2. Explain the difference between a general purpose, specific purpose, and thesis statement.
3. Develop main points that support a clear thesis.
4. Identify the basic parts of a speech: introduction, body, and conclusion.
5. Explain the difference between a working outline and a speaking outline.
6. Understand why rehearsal is necessary for confident speech delivery.

New speakers can greatly benefit from preparing and delivering their first short speech. An audience of just two people is enough to test the waters and begin building confidence. Public speaking is a skill, and like any skill, it improves through preparation, practice, feedback, and repetition.

This chapter provides an overview of the speech preparation process. Later chapters will explore each part of this process in greater detail. For now, think of this chapter as your map. You do not need to master everything at once. You simply need to understand the basic path from idea to delivery.

SELECT A TOPIC

The first step in creating a speech is finding something to speak about. Unless your topic is assigned, begin with your interests, passions, questions, experiences, and concerns. What do you care about? What do you know? What do you want to learn more about? What issues, hobbies, communities, technologies, problems, or stories matter to you?

Audiences usually respond better to speakers who seem genuinely interested in their topic. A forced topic often leads to a forced speech. However, your personal interest is only one part of the decision. A good topic must also be appropriate for the assignment, the occasion, the time limit, and the audience.

For example, you may be deeply interested in the history of horror movies, but that topic may still need to be narrowed. A five-minute speech cannot cover the entire history of horror cinema without turning into a frantic movie trailer with footnotes. A stronger version might focus on how sound design creates suspense in horror films or how horror movies reflect social fears during specific time periods.

A strong topic should be interesting to you, appropriate for the audience, narrow enough for the time limit, and capable of being supported with credible material.

ANALYZE THE AUDIENCE

Audiences have interests, experiences, values, beliefs, and expectations of their own. These factors influence how receptive they may be to your topic and message. Audience analysis means learning as much as you reasonably can about the people who will hear your speech.

Audience analysis may include considering demographic factors such as age range, cultural background, language background, major, occupation, gender, or shared group membership. It may also include psychological factors such as audience attitudes, beliefs, values, interests, and likely level of knowledge about the topic.

For a classroom speech, begin with what you know about your classmates. What do they have in common? What differences might shape how they respond to your topic? What examples would make sense to them? What terms would need to be defined? What assumptions should you avoid?

Good speakers do not simply ask, "What do I want to say?" They also ask, "What does this audience need in order to understand, care about, and evaluate my message

DETERMINE THE SPEECH PURPOSE

Once you have a topic, decide what you want to accomplish with that topic. For most speeches, your general purpose will fall into one of three categories: to inform, to persuade, or to mark a special occasion.

An informative speech provides the audience with new information, understanding, or insight. The goal is to explain, describe, demonstrate, or clarify. For example, a speaker might explain how electric vehicles work, describe the history of a cultural tradition, or demonstrate how to prepare for a job interview.

A persuasive speech attempts to influence the audience's beliefs, attitudes, values, or actions. The goal is to convince the audience to think differently, feel differently, or do something. For example, a speaker might argue that community colleges should receive more public funding, that college students should limit phone use before sleep, or that cities should create more shaded public spaces.

A special occasion speech marks an important event or moment. These speeches may celebrate, honor, mourn, inspire, entertain, or commemorate. Weddings, funerals, graduations, award ceremonies, retirements, birthdays, banquets, and dedications often involve special occasion speeches.

The general purpose gives your speech its broad direction. The specific purpose narrows that direction into a clear goal.

COMPOSE A THESIS STATEMENT

A specific purpose statement identifies exactly what you want your speech to accomplish. It is usually written from the speaker's point of view and begins with a phrase such as "To inform my audience" or "To persuade my audience."

A strong specific purpose statement should be clear, focused, and realistic for the time limit.

For example:

GENERAL PURPOSE: To inform

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three ways AI can assist students during the early stages of speech preparation.

This specific purpose is stronger than "To inform my audience about AI" because it is narrower. Artificial intelligence is too broad for a short speech. Focusing on three ways AI can assist with speech preparation gives the speaker a manageable direction.

COMPOSE A THESIS STATEMENT

Your thesis statement expresses the central idea of your speech in one sentence. It tells the audience what your speech is about. While the specific purpose explains what you want to accomplish, the thesis statement explains the main idea you want the audience to understand.

For example:

GENERAL PURPOSE: To inform

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three ways generative AI can assist students during the early stages of speech preparation.

THESIS STATEMENT: AI can help students brainstorm topics, organize early ideas, and practice audience questions, but it must be used responsibly and never as a replacement for original thinking.

This thesis gives the speech a clear direction. It also avoids treating AI as either magical or evil. Good speeches usually do not reduce complex topics into cartoon villain or superhero categories.

Here is another example:

GENERAL PURPOSE: To persuade

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To persuade my audience that students should verify AI-generated information before using it in academic speeches.

THESIS STATEMENT: Because generative AI can produce inaccurate facts, fake citations, and biased summaries, students should verify all AI-assisted research with credible sources before presenting it to an audience.

Notice that the persuasive thesis makes an argument. It does not simply announce the topic. A weak thesis says, "Today I will talk about AI." A stronger thesis makes a clear claim about AI.

DEVELOP THE MAIN POINTS

Once you have a clear thesis statement, develop the main points of your speech. Main points are the major ideas that support your thesis. In an informative speech, main points may explain different parts, types, causes, effects, steps, or examples of your topic. In a persuasive speech, main points usually function as arguments that support your claim.

Many classroom speeches work well with three main points, but three is not a magical number. The number of main points should fit the topic, time limit, and assignment. Too many main points can overwhelm the audience. Too few may leave the speech underdeveloped.

Using the AI example above, the main points might be:

1. Generative AI can help students brainstorm possible speech topics.
2. Generative AI can help students organize early ideas into possible main points.
3. Generative AI can help students practice by generating audience questions.

Each main point supports the thesis. Together, they create a clear structure for the speech.

GATHER SUPPORTING MATERIAL

Supporting material clarifies, explains, proves, or strengthens your main points. Supporting material may include examples, stories, statistics, definitions, testimony, analogies, research findings, personal experience, interviews, or visual material.

A speech is only as strong as its support. Claims without support are just opinions wearing a nice jacket.

For example, if you claim that students should verify AI-generated research, you need supporting material. You might include an example of an AI tool producing a fake citation, research about misinformation, expert testimony about source evaluation, or a demonstration showing how one AI-generated claim can be checked against a library database.

Supporting material should be credible, relevant, current, and clearly connected to your main points. Do not add evidence just to sound impressive. Evidence should help the audience understand or believe the point you are making.

SEPARATE THE SPEECH INTO MAJOR PARTS

Every speech has three major parts: introduction, body, and conclusion.

The introduction gets the audience's attention, introduces the topic, establishes the speaker's credibility, and previews the main points. A strong introduction helps the audience understand why the topic matters and why they should keep listening.

The body contains the main points and supporting material. This is where the speaker develops the central idea of the speech. The body should be organized clearly so the audience can follow the speaker's logic.

The conclusion signals that the speech is ending, reviews the main points, reinforces the thesis, and provides a sense of closure. A good conclusion does not simply stop. It lands.

Transitions help connect the major parts of the speech. They guide the audience from one idea to the next. Without transitions, a speech can feel like a pile of disconnected thoughts. With transitions, the audience can follow the path.

OUTLINE THE SPEECH

An outline is a framework for arranging your ideas. It helps you organize main points, supporting material, transitions, and source citations before you deliver the speech.

A working outline is a detailed version of your speech plan. It often includes full sentences, research, examples, transitions, and citations. This outline helps you develop and test the structure of your speech.

A speaking outline is a shorter version used during delivery. It usually contains key words, short phrases, source reminders, and delivery cues. The speaking outline should help you remember your ideas without tempting you to read the entire speech word for word.

Outlines follow principles of coordination and subordination. Coordinate points are ideas of equal importance and should be written in parallel form. Subordinate points support or explain the ideas above them.

For example:

I. Generative AI can help students brainstorm possible speech topics.

A. Students can ask AI to generate topic lists.

B. Students can ask AI to narrow a broad topic.

C. Students must still choose a topic that fits the assignment and au dience.

The main point is the larger idea. The subpoints explain and support it.

CONSIDER PRESENTATION AIDS

As you prepare your speech, consider whether presentation aids would help the audience understand your message. Presentation aids may include slides, images, charts, graphs, objects, audio, video, or demonstrations.

A presentation aid should support the speech, not replace the speaker. Slides should not become a wall of text. Images should not be decorative clutter. Charts should not be so confusing that the audience needs a minor in statistics and a flashlight.

Use presentation aids when they clarify, emphasize, simplify, or strengthen your message. If they do not help the audience, leave them out.

See Chapter 20 for a more detailed discussion of presentation aids.

PRACTICE DELIVERING THE SPEECH

Rehearsal is necessary for a successful speech. Practice helps you become more familiar with your ideas, improve your timing, strengthen your delivery, and reduce anxiety.

Do not confuse reading your outline silently with practicing your speech. Public speaking requires speaking out loud. Practice with your voice, body, gestures, notes, and presentation aids. Time yourself. Record yourself if possible. Practice in front of another person if you can.

For most classroom speeches, practice at least six times. That may seem like overkill, but repetition builds confidence. The goal is not to memorize every word. The goal is to become comfortable enough with your material that you can speak naturally and recover if something unexpected happens.

A speech is not finished when you finish writing it. A speech is finished when you can deliver it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Preparing a speech involves several steps: selecting a topic, analyzing the audience, determining the purpose, writing a thesis statement, developing main points, gathering supporting material, organizing the speech, outlining, considering presentation aids, and practicing delivery.

A general purpose identifies the broad goal of the speech: to inform, persuade, or mark a special occasion. A specific purpose narrows the goal into a clear statement of what the speaker wants to accomplish. A thesis statement expresses the central idea of the speech in one sentence.

Every speech has three major parts: introduction, body, and conclusion. A working outline helps the speaker develop the speech in detail, while a speaking outline helps the speaker deliver the speech clearly and naturally. Rehearsal is essential because public speaking is a performed skill, not just a written assignment.

KEY TERMS

Topic

Audience analysis

General purpose

Specific purpose

Informative speech

Persuasive speech

Special occasion speech

Thesis statement

Main points

Supporting material

Introduction

Body

Conclusion

Transition

Outline

Working outline

Speaking outline

Coordination

Subordination

Presentation aids

Rehearsal

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is it important to choose a topic that matters to both the speaker and the audience?

2. What is the difference between a general purpose, specific purpose, and thesis statement?

3. Why is “Today I will talk about social media” a weak thesis statement?

4. How can supporting material improve a speaker’s credibility?

5. Why is practicing out loud different from silently reading through an outline?

6. How could AI help a student prepare a speech without replacing the student’s original work?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

Choose one broad topic from the list below:

Artificial intelligence

Student stress

Social media

Food culture

College affordability

Horror movies

Fitness

Music

Climate change

Public transportation

Complete the following steps:

1. Narrow the broad topic into a speech topic that could fit a five-minute classroom speech.

2. Write a general purpose statement.

3. Write a specific purpose statement.

4. Write a thesis statement.

5. Create three possible main points.

6. Identify one type of supporting material you could use for each main point.

Example:

Broad topic: Artificial intelligence

Narrowed topic: AI as a speech preparation tool

General purpose: To inform

Specific purpose: To inform my audience about three ways AI can help students prepare speeches responsibly.

Thesis statement: AI can help students brainstorm topics, organize ideas, and practice audience questions, but students must verify information and preserve their own voice.

Chapter 3

MANAGING SPEECH ANXIETY

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why speech anxiety is normal and common.
2. Identify common causes of public speaking anxiety.
3. Recognize when anxiety may appear during the speech preparation process.
4. Apply strategies for reducing anxiety before and during a speech.
5. Use rehearsal, breathing, movement, and feedback to build confidence.
6. Reframe nervousness as energy that can support performance.

Feeling nervous before giving a speech is normal. In fact, a certain amount of nervousness can be useful. It means your body recognizes that the moment matters. Your heart rate may increase, your breathing may change, your hands may feel restless, and your mind may move faster than usual. These reactions are uncomfortable, but they are not proof that you are unprepared or incapable. They are signs that your body is preparing you to respond.

The goal is not to eliminate all nervousness. That would be unrealistic. Even experienced speakers, actors, teachers, performers, and professionals feel nervous before important moments. The difference is that experienced speakers learn how to manage that energy instead of letting it control them.

Speech anxiety becomes easier to handle when you understand what causes it, when it tends to appear, and what you can do to reduce it.

IDENTIFY WHAT MAKES YOU ANXIOUS

Speech anxiety can come from many sources. Some students are nervous because they have had a negative public speaking experience. Others worry about being judged, forgetting what they want to say, sounding awkward, or being the center of attention. Some students feel different from their audience because of their accent, appearance, background, identity, language experience, or level of confidence.

Anxiety often grows when the situation feels uncertain. You may wonder:

Will I forget my speech?

Will the audience judge me?

Will my voice shake?

Will I look nervous?

Will I say something wrong?

Will my slides work?

Will I be interesting?

Will people notice my mistakes?

These questions are common. The problem is that anxious thinking often turns uncertainty into a disaster movie. Public speaking anxiety tells you, “One

awkward pause and your life is over." That is not reality. That is your nervous system writing bad fiction.

The good news is that speech anxiety can be managed. Preparation, practice, breathing, movement, mindset, and experience can all help you feel more in control.

LACK OF POSITIVE EXPERIENCE

If you are new to public speaking or have had bad experiences in the past, anxiety is natural. Without a positive experience to draw from, the mind often fills in the blank with fear. A student who once froze during a presentation may expect the same thing to happen again. Another student may have been laughed at, corrected harshly, or embarrassed in front of others.

Avoiding public speaking may feel safer in the short term, but avoidance usually makes anxiety stronger over time. The more you avoid speaking, the more unfamiliar and threatening it feels. Experience matters. Small, successful speaking moments can slowly replace fear with confidence.

Confidence does not usually arrive before you practice. Confidence is often the result of practice.

FEELING DIFFERENT

Public speaking can make people more aware of their differences. A speaker may worry about an accent, speech pattern, body type, clothing, facial expression, disability, cultural background, gender expression, or personal style. These concerns can make a person feel exposed.

It is important to remember that difference does not mean weakness. Audiences do not need speakers to be identical. They need speakers to be clear, pre-

pared, respectful, and engaged. Your background and identity can also be part of your strength as a speaker. They may shape your examples, your perspective, your humor, your values, and your connection with the audience.

Many speakers assume the audience is judging every detail. In reality, most audience members are not studying you with the intensity of a detective looking for fingerprints. They are trying to follow your message. Help them do that.

BEING THE CENTER OF ATTENTION

Many people feel uncomfortable being watched. During a speech, audience behaviors such as side conversations, blank faces, checking phones, or whispering can make a speaker feel ignored or judged. A speaker may begin thinking, "They hate this," "I am boring," or "I messed up."

Sometimes those interpretations are wrong. A blank face may simply mean someone is concentrating. A person checking a phone may be dealing with something unrelated. Whispering may not be about you. Of course, audiences should listen respectfully, but speakers should be careful not to interpret every movement as a personal review.

When you are the center of attention, your self-consciousness can exaggerate your mistakes. A small pause may feel enormous to you but barely register with the audience. A slight shake in your hand may feel obvious to you but go unnoticed by listeners.

Most audiences are not hoping you fail. In a classroom setting, many of them are thinking, "Please let this person survive, because I am next."

ANXIETY IN DIGITAL AND RECORDED PRESENTATIONS

Public speaking no longer happens only in front of a live audience. Students may also give speeches on Zoom, record video presentations, upload speeches to

learning platforms, or present with cameras on. These situations can create new forms of anxiety.

Some speakers become more nervous when they see themselves on camera. Others worry about being recorded, replayed, paused, or judged later. Online presentations may also create anxiety because of technology: poor Wi-Fi, bad audio, frozen video, screen sharing problems, or distracting notifications.

Digital speaking requires preparation just like in-person speaking. Test your microphone, camera, lighting, slides, and internet connection. Practice looking at the camera, not only at your screen. Remove distractions from your background when possible. Close unnecessary tabs. Silence notifications. A little technical preparation can reduce a lot of anxiety.

PINPOINT THE ONSET OF NERVOUSNESS

People experience anxiety at different points in the speech-making process. Some feel anxious as soon as the assignment is announced. Others feel anxious during research, rehearsal, or the moments immediately before speaking. Identifying when anxiety appears can help you respond to it more effectively.

PRE-PREPARATION ANXIETY

Pre-preparation anxiety begins as soon as you learn that you must give a speech. This can lead to procrastination, avoidance, or panic before you have even selected a topic.

If this happens, begin with one small task. Do not try to solve the entire speech at once. Write down three possible topics. Open a blank outline. Review the assignment sheet. Ask a question. Schedule a practice time. Small actions reduce uncertainty. Uncertainty feeds anxiety; action gives anxiety less room to perform its little tap dance.

PREPARATION ANXIETY

Preparation anxiety appears while you are developing the speech. You may feel overwhelmed by the amount of work required. You may have trouble narrowing your topic, finding sources, organizing points, or deciding what matters most.

When this happens, break the task into smaller steps:

Choose a topic.

Write a specific purpose.

Write a thesis.

Find three credible sources.

Create three main points.

Draft the introduction.

Draft the conclusion.

Practice out loud.

A speech is built one step at a time. Trying to do everything at once makes the task feel impossible. Breaking it into smaller parts makes it manageable.

PRE-PERFORMANCE ANXIETY

Pre-performance anxiety appears when the speech begins to feel real. This often happens during rehearsal. You may realize that your timing is off, your ideas are not as clear as you thought, or your transitions need work. This can be frustrating, but it is also useful.

Rehearsal reveals problems while you still have time to fix them. That is the point. If your speech sounds rough during practice, good. You found the rough spots before the audience did.

Do not stop rehearsing because rehearsal makes you nervous. That is like refusing to study because the practice quiz exposed what you do not know. Use rehearsal as information, not as an insult.

PERFORMANCE ANXIETY

Performance anxiety usually peaks just before or during the beginning of the speech. This is when your body may feel the most activated. Your heart may race, your mouth may feel dry, and your thoughts may speed up.

The introduction is often the hardest part because you are adjusting to the audience's attention. Once speakers get through the opening and settle into the first main point, anxiety often decreases. This is why memorizing or deeply rehearsing the opening minute can help. If you know the beginning well, you give yourself a stable entry point.

The goal is to manage the first wave of anxiety long enough to find your rhythm.

STRATEGIES TO BOOST YOUR CONFIDENCE

Speech anxiety can be managed through preparation, mindset, breathing, movement, rehearsal, and feedback. No single strategy works for everyone, so experiment. The more tools you have, the more control you will feel.

PREPARE EARLY

Preparation is one of the strongest anxiety reducers. Waiting until the last minute increases uncertainty, and uncertainty increases anxiety. Begin preparing as soon as possible after receiving the assignment.

Early preparation gives you time to choose a stronger topic, locate better sources, organize your ideas, practice delivery, and solve problems before they become emergencies. A rushed speech usually feels rushed to the speaker and the audience.

Prepare early enough that you can sleep the night before your speech. Sleep is not optional. Your brain is not a phone; you cannot run it at 3 percent and expect premium performance.

PRACTICE OUT LOUD

Reading your outline silently is not rehearsal. Public speaking requires speaking. Practice out loud several times before the final presentation. Time yourself. Stand up if you will be standing. Use your notes if you will use notes. Practice with slides if you will use slides.

A useful goal is to practice your speech at least six times. The first few rehearsals may feel awkward. That is normal. Early practice is where the speech discovers all the ways it wants to betray you. Keep going. Each rehearsal helps you become more familiar with your content and more comfortable with your delivery.

The goal is not to memorize every word. The goal is to know your ideas well enough that you can explain them naturally.

RECORD YOURSELF

Recording yourself can feel uncomfortable, but it is one of the fastest ways to improve. A recording allows you to notice habits you may not feel while speaking. You might see that you look down too often, rush through transitions, avoid eye contact, speak too softly, or use filler words repeatedly.

When reviewing a recording, do not attack yourself. Watch like a coach, not like a bully. Identify one or two things to improve. Do not try to fix everything at once.

Ask:

Is my introduction clear?

Do I sound rushed?

Can I hear myself clearly?

Are my gestures distracting or useful?

Do I understand my own main points?

Where do I seem most confident?

Where do I seem least prepared?

Use the recording as feedback, not evidence that you should flee society and live among houseplants.

GET YOUR MIND RIGHT

Negative thoughts can increase speech anxiety. If you repeatedly tell yourself, "I am terrible at this," "Everyone will judge me," or "I am going to fail," your body will respond as if danger is guaranteed.

A more useful approach is to reframe the situation. Instead of thinking, "I have to perform perfectly," think, "I need to communicate one clear message." Instead of thinking, "Everyone is watching me," think, "I am here to help the audience understand something." Instead of thinking, "I am nervous," try, "My body is giving me energy."

This does not mean lying to yourself. It means choosing a more useful interpretation. Nervousness and excitement feel similar in the body. Both involve energy. A strong speaker learns to direct that energy toward the message.

USE CONTROLLED BREATHING

When people become anxious, their breathing often becomes shallow and fast. This can make the body feel even more tense. Controlled breathing helps calm the nervous system and gives the speaker a moment of control.

Try this:

Inhale slowly for four counts.

Pause briefly.

Exhale slowly for four counts.

Repeat for one to two minutes.

You can also try a longer exhale, such as inhaling for four counts and exhaling for six counts. The exact number matters less than slowing down and breathing with intention.

Before you speak, take one full breath. Do not rush your first word. The audience can wait half a second. They are not defusing a bomb.

RELAX THE BODY

Anxiety often creates tension in the body. Shoulders rise. Hands tighten. The jaw locks. The body prepares for threat, even though the threat is usually a classroom presentation and not a mountain lion with a grading rubric.

Before speaking, try gentle stretching. Roll your shoulders. Loosen your jaw. Stretch your neck. Shake out your hands. Stand with both feet grounded. Good posture can help you breathe more freely and appear more confident.

Exercise can also help release nervous energy. Some speakers benefit from a brisk walk before presenting. Others prefer calming movement, such as stretching, yoga, or slow breathing. Choose the kind of movement that gives you the energy you want to bring into the speech.

USE MOVEMENT TO MINIMIZE ANXIETY

Movement can help release nervous energy during a speech, but it should be controlled and purposeful. Do not pace back and forth without reason. Pacing can make you look trapped, and the audience may start watching your route instead of listening to your message.

Move when you transition to a new point, emphasize an idea, approach a visual aid, or engage a different part of the room. Then stop and plant your feet when delivering important information.

Movement should support the message. If your body is moving but your ideas are not, the audience will notice.

PRACTICE NATURAL GESTURES

Gestures can help release tension and make your speech more expressive. Natural gestures usually come from meaning. If you are describing something large, your hands may widen. If you are listing points, your fingers may count them. If you are contrasting two ideas, your hands may separate them in space.

Avoid gestures that distract from the message, such as jingling keys, playing with hair, gripping note cards, tapping the podium, or adjusting clothing repeatedly. These actions are usually signs of unmanaged nervous energy.

If your hands tremble, avoid holding thin papers or a stack of note cards that will make the trembling more visible. Use larger note cards, a tablet stand, a printed speaking outline, or place notes on a podium if available.

FOCUS ON THE MESSAGE, NOT YOURSELF

Anxiety grows when speakers focus only on how they are being perceived. "How do I look?" "Do they like me?" "Did they notice that mistake?" These questions pull attention away from the message.

Shift your focus outward. Ask:

What does my audience need to understand?

What is the next idea I need to communicate?

How can I make this point clearer?

What example will help them follow me?

The more you focus on serving the audience, the less trapped you are inside your own self-consciousness. Public speaking is not about proving you are perfect. It is about communicating something worthwhile.

LEARN FROM FEEDBACK

After a speech, feedback can help you improve. Feedback may come from your instructor, classmates, self-reflection, or a recording of your speech. Do not treat feedback as a personal attack. Treat it as information for the next attempt.

Good feedback should be specific, constructive, and focused on behavior rather than personality. “You are bad at speaking” is useless. “Your introduction was clear, but your second main point needed stronger evidence” is useful.

When giving feedback to others, avoid vague praise or vague criticism. Instead, name what worked and what could improve.

For example:

Your opening story caught my attention. I understood why the topic mattered. One area to improve is your pacing during the second main point. You started speaking quickly, and I had trouble following the statistic. If you slow down and pause after important numbers, the evidence will land more clearly.

That kind of feedback is specific, respectful, and useful.

BUILD CONFIDENCE THROUGH REPETITION

Confidence is built through repeated experience. The first speech may feel uncomfortable. The second may feel slightly less strange. Over time, speaking becomes more familiar. Familiar does not always mean easy, but it does become more manageable.

Each speech gives you evidence that you can survive the moment, learn from it, and improve. That evidence matters. Confidence is not a personality trait reserved for naturally outgoing people. It is a skill that can be developed.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Speech anxiety is normal and common. Nervousness can appear before preparation, during preparation, during rehearsal, or immediately before and during the speech itself. Understanding when anxiety appears can help speakers respond to it more effectively.

Common causes of speech anxiety include lack of positive experience, fear of being judged, feeling different from the audience, discomfort with attention, and uncertainty about performance. Digital and recorded presentations can also create anxiety because of technology, self-view, and the possibility of being replayed or evaluated later.

Speakers can manage anxiety by preparing early, practicing out loud, recording themselves, using controlled breathing, relaxing the body, using purposeful movement, practicing natural gestures, focusing on the message, and learning from feedback. The goal is not to eliminate nervousness completely. The goal is to channel nervous energy into focused, prepared, audience-centered communication.

KEY TERMS

Speech anxiety

Pre-preparation anxiety

Preparation anxiety

Pre-performance anxiety

Performance anxiety

Rehearsal

Controlled breathing

Fight-or-flight response

Relaxation response

Purposeful movement

Natural gestures

Feedback

Constructive criticism

Self-consciousness

Digital presentation anxiety

Audience-centered focus

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is nervousness before a speech normal rather than a sign of failure?

2. Which type of speech anxiety affects you most: pre-preparation, preparation, pre-performance, or performance anxiety?

3. How can preparation reduce uncertainty?

4. Why is practicing out loud more useful than silently reading through your notes?

5. How can movement help a speaker manage nervous energy?

6. What makes feedback helpful rather than discouraging?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

Create a personal speech anxiety plan.

Answer the following questions:

1. What part of public speaking makes you most nervous?

2. When does your anxiety usually appear: when the assignment is announced, while preparing, while rehearsing, right before speaking, or during the speech?

3. What physical signs of nervousness do you notice in your body?

4. What is one preparation strategy you will use before your next speech?

5. What is one breathing or relaxation strategy you will use before speaking?

6. What is one delivery habit you want to improve?

7. After your speech, what kind of feedback would help you improve for next time?

Then write a short confidence statement you can use before presenting. For example:

I do not need to be perfect. I need to be prepared, clear, and present. My job is to communicate one message at a time.

Chapter 4

ETHICAL PUBLIC SPEAKING

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why ethics matter in public speaking.
2. Define ethos and explain how speakers build trust with audiences.
3. Identify the responsibilities that come with free speech.
4. Recognize the difference between ethical persuasion and manipulation.
5. Avoid plagiarism by quoting, paraphrasing, summarizing, and citing sources responsibly.
6. Explain how artificial intelligence can be used ethically and unethically in speech preparation.
7. Understand the basic relationship between copyright, fair use, Creative Commons, and classroom presentations.

Great speakers have the ability to influence what people think, feel, believe, and do. That power comes with responsibility. Public speaking is not only about getting attention or winning agreement. It is also about earning trust.

Ethical public speaking means taking responsibility for your message. It requires honesty, preparation, respect for the audience, accurate use of evidence, and care with language. A speech can be entertaining, emotional, persuasive, and powerful while still being ethical. In fact, the most effective speakers are often effective because audiences trust them.

EARN YOUR AUDIENCE'S TRUST

Ethics is connected to the Greek word ethos, meaning character. Aristotle argued that audiences are more likely to trust speakers who demonstrate good character, practical wisdom, and goodwill toward the audience. In modern public speaking, ethos is often discussed as speaker credibility.

Speaker credibility is not only about credentials. Degrees, job titles, awards, and personal experience can help establish credibility, but they are not enough. Audiences also judge whether a speaker seems prepared, honest, fair, respectful, and genuinely concerned with the audience's needs.

Speakers can build credibility by doing the following:

1. Refer to relevant expertise or experience.
2. Use accurate and credible evidence.
3. Acknowledge the limits of what they know.
4. Find common ground with the audience.
5. Treat opposing views fairly.
6. Use language that respects the dignity of listeners.
7. Follow through on the values they claim to support.

Credibility is earned. It can also be lost quickly. A speaker who exaggerates evidence, misrepresents an opponent, mocks audience members, invents sources, or

hides important information may win attention in the moment but lose long-term trust.

RESPECT AUDIENCE VALUES

The way we speak reflects our ethical values. Values are judgments about what is important, right, wrong, fair, unfair, desirable, or harmful. Because audiences are diverse, audience members may not share the same values as the speaker or even with one another.

This is especially important when speaking about controversial topics. Issues involving politics, religion, identity, immigration, economics, public health, education, technology, gender, sexuality, war, policing, climate, or civil rights may connect to deeply held beliefs. A careless speaker may treat disagreement as stupidity or moral failure. An ethical speaker works harder than that.

Respecting audience values does not mean pretending to agree with everyone. It does not mean avoiding strong claims. It means recognizing that people often arrive at their beliefs through personal experience, family background, culture, education, faith, community, media, and history.

Before speaking on a sensitive issue, ask:

What values might audience members bring to this topic?

Where might they agree with me?

Where might they disagree?

What terms or examples could alienate them unnecessarily?

What evidence would they find credible?

How can I challenge them without insulting them?

Ethical speakers can argue forcefully while still treating listeners as human beings.

USE FREE SPEECH RIGHTS RESPONSIBLY

Free speech is one of the most important principles in democratic society. It protects the right to express ideas, criticize authority, debate policy, challenge institutions, create art, protest, and participate in public life.

However, having the right to say something does not automatically make it ethical, wise, accurate, or helpful. A statement may be legally protected and still be cruel, misleading, irresponsible, or destructive.

In a classroom speech, ethical standards are usually higher than the minimum legal standard. Students should avoid racist, sexist, homophobic, transphobic, ableist, religiously bigoted, or otherwise demeaning language. Speakers should also avoid personal attacks, harassment, intimidation, and careless claims that damage another person's reputation.

Certain forms of speech may also create legal consequences, including:

1. Speech that directly incites violence.

2. Defamatory speech that harms a person's reputation through false statements.

3. Speech that invades privacy by revealing private information without permission.

4. Threats, harassment, or targeted intimidation.

This book is not a law textbook, and classroom speakers are not expected to become attorneys. The larger point is simple: speak freely, but do not confuse freedom with carelessness. Responsible speakers understand that words can inform, inspire, challenge, heal, mislead, humiliate, or harm.

CONTRIBUTE TO POSITIVE PUBLIC DISCOURSE

Ethical public speaking should contribute to better public discourse. Public discourse refers to communication about issues that affect communities, institutions, and public life. These issues may include education, housing, health, technology, poverty, justice, environmental policy, labor, safety, and civil rights.

A speech contributes positively to public discourse when it helps audiences understand an issue more clearly, consider evidence more carefully, or imagine constructive possibilities. This does not mean every speech has to be polite in a bland or artificial way. Some issues require urgency, passion, anger, grief, or moral force. But ethical speakers use emotion to clarify and motivate, not to deceive or dehumanize.

Avoid invective rhetoric, which uses verbal attacks to belittle or unfairly discredit people. Avoid ad hominem attacks, which target the person instead of the argument. Ethical speakers focus on issues, evidence, consequences, values, and solutions.

A strong public argument should aim to move the conversation forward, not simply leave bodies on the rhetorical battlefield.

OBSERVE ETHICAL GROUND RULES

If your speech focuses on a sensitive issue, dignity and integrity should guide your choices.

Dignity means treating audience members and the people discussed in your speech as worthy of respect. Even when you disagree with someone, you should not reduce that person to a stereotype, insult, punchline, or enemy.

Integrity means refusing to compromise the truth for convenience, popularity, or personal gain. Speakers with integrity do not hide evidence that weakens their position, invent sources, distort quotations, or exaggerate statistics just because it helps the speech.

Ethical public speaking depends on four major principles: trustworthiness, respect, responsibility, and fairness.

TRUSTWORTHINESS

Trustworthiness combines honesty and dependability. Trustworthy speakers reveal their true purpose, represent evidence accurately, and avoid misleading the audience. They do not use fake sources, false statistics, deceptive images, or emotional manipulation to make weak arguments look strong.

RESPECT

Respect means addressing audience members as thinking human beings. Respectful speakers avoid personal attacks, stereotypes, mockery, and language meant to demean people because of identity, background, belief, or experience. Respect does not require agreement. It requires basic human regard.

RESPONSIBILITY

Responsibility means being accountable for what you say. Speakers are responsible for checking facts, citing sources, using emotional appeals appropriately, and considering the likely impact of their message. "I found it online" is not a defense. Neither is "AI told me." If you say it in your speech, you own it.

FAIRNESS

Fairness means making a genuine effort to understand and represent different sides of an issue. Fair speakers do not create straw man versions of opposing views. They acknowledge information the audience needs in order to make an informed judgment. Few serious issues are completely simple. Ethical speakers do not pretend complexity does not exist.

AVOID OFFENSIVE AND DEHUMANIZING SPEECH

To be an ethical speaker, avoid stereotypes, prejudice, and dehumanizing language. Stereotypes reduce people to oversimplified assumptions based on group identity. Prejudice involves negative attitudes toward people based on identity or perceived identity. Dehumanizing language describes people as less than human, as objects, animals, diseases, or threats to be eliminated.

Hate speech is offensive or threatening communication directed at people because of characteristics such as race, ethnicity, religion, gender identity, sexuality, disability, nationality, or other identity-based characteristics. Hate speech is unethical in public speaking because it attacks human dignity and damages the communication climate.

This does not mean speakers cannot discuss difficult issues involving identity, discrimination, violence, inequality, history, or social conflict. They can and often should. The ethical responsibility is to speak with accuracy, care, and respect.

AVOID PLAGIARISM

Citing sources is an essential part of ethical public speaking. Plagiarism is presenting another person's words, ideas, structure, research, or creative work as your own. It is unethical because it misleads the audience and takes credit for someone else's work.

Plagiarism can happen in several ways:

1. Copying and pasting material from a source without credit.
2. Reading someone else's writing as if it were your own.
3. Changing a few words from a source while keeping the original structure.
4. Using another person's ideas without acknowledgment.
5. Using statistics, examples, images, or charts without credit.
6. Reusing your own previous work without permission when the assignment requires new work.

7. Submitting AI-generated text as if you wrote it yourself.

Plagiarism may be intentional or accidental, but both create problems. The solution is simple: keep track of your sources, use your own words, and give credit when the material is not yours.

QUOTE, PARAPHRASE, AND SUMMARIZE

Speakers usually use source material in three ways: quoting, paraphrasing, and summarizing.

Quoting means using the exact words from a source. When you quote, repeat the words accurately and clearly identify the source. In a written outline, use quotation marks. In a speech, signal the quotation out loud by saying something like, "In her words…" or "He wrote…"

Paraphrasing means restating a source's idea in your own words and sentence structure. A paraphrase still requires a citation because the idea came from someone else.

Summarizing means briefly explaining the main idea of a larger source or section of a source. A summary also requires a citation.

Changing a few words is not paraphrasing. Rearranging the original sentence is not enough. True paraphrasing requires understanding the idea and expressing it in your own language.

USE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE ETHICALLY

Generative AI tools can assist with parts of the speech preparation process. They can help brainstorm possible topics, create practice questions, identify counterarguments, simplify complex explanations, or suggest ways to organize ideas.

Used responsibly, AI can be a helpful learning tool.

Used carelessly, AI can create serious ethical problems.

AI tools can produce inaccurate information, fake citations, biased summaries, and generic language. They can also make it easy for students to submit work they did not actually create. In public speaking, that matters because the audience is not only evaluating your words. They are evaluating your judgment, preparation, and credibility.

Ethical AI use depends on transparency, verification, and original thinking.

Use AI ethically by doing the following:

1. Follow your instructor's AI policy.

2. Use AI as a support tool, not a replacement for your thinking.

3. Verify all facts, examples, and sources through credible evidence.

4. Do not use AI-generated citations unless you personally confirm the sources exist and say what the AI claims.

5. Disclose meaningful AI assistance when required.

6. Do not let AI erase your personal voice, experience, or responsibility.

7. Never present AI-generated work as entirely your own if it shaped the content of your speech.

For example, it may be acceptable to use AI to generate practice questions for your speech. It may not be acceptable to use AI to write your speech and then present it as original work. The difference is not small. One helps you prepare. The other replaces your preparation.

An ethical AI disclosure might sound like this:

I used ChatGPT to brainstorm possible topic directions and generate practice audience questions. The final topic, research, outline, and speech content are my own.

Or:

I used an AI image generator to create the illustration on this slide. The image is used as a visual aid, not as factual evidence.

AI does not remove your responsibility. If false information appears in your speech, you are responsible for it. If a source is fake, you are responsible for it. If your speech sounds like it was written by a machine that just attended a leadership webinar, that is also on you.

FAIR USE, COPYRIGHT, AND ETHICAL SPEAKING

Copyright is legal protection given to creators of original works such as books, articles, photographs, music, films, artwork, charts, videos, and other creative materials. Copyright gives creators control over how their work is copied, distributed, displayed, performed, or adapted.

When you include copyrighted material in a speech, such as images, video clips, music, charts, or long quotations, you should consider whether you have permission or whether your use may fall under fair use.

Fair use allows limited use of copyrighted material without permission for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching, scholarship, or research. Classroom speeches often have more flexibility than commercial presentations, but fair use is not a magic shield. You should still use only what you need, credit the source, and avoid using copyrighted material in a way that replaces the original work or suggests ownership.

When using copyrighted material in a classroom speech:

1. Use only the amount needed.
2. Give credit to the creator or source.
3. Make sure the material supports your speech purpose.
4. Avoid using copyrighted material as decoration when it does not add meaning.
5. Be especially careful if the speech will be posted publicly online.

If your speech will be recorded, uploaded, shared publicly, or used outside the classroom, copyright concerns become more important. A video clip or song that seems harmless in class may create problems when posted online.

USE CREATIVE COMMONS MATERIALS RESPONSIBLY

Creative Commons licenses allow creators to share their work with the public while setting conditions for how others may use it. These licenses do not mean "free to steal." They mean "free to use under specific rules."

Common Creative Commons conditions include:

ATTRIBUTION:

You must give credit to the creator.

NONCOMMERCIAL:

You may use the work only for noncommercial purposes.

NODERIVATIVES:

You may use the work, but you may not modify or remix it.

SHAREALIKE:

If you adapt the work, you must share your new work under the same license.

Before using Creative Commons material, check the specific license. Give credit to the creator, include the title if available, identify the license, and provide a link when possible.

For classroom speeches, Creative Commons images, music, and videos can be useful, but they still require ethical use. Credit the creator. Respect the license. Do not pretend the work is yours.

ETHICS CHECKLIST FOR SPEAKERS

Before delivering your speech, ask yourself:

Have I represented my topic honestly?

Have I used credible and current evidence?

Have I cited information that is not my own?

Have I represented opposing views fairly?

Have I avoided stereotypes and dehumanizing language?

Have I used emotional appeals responsibly?

Have I checked quotations, statistics, images, and examples for accuracy?

Have I followed the assignment's AI policy?

Have I disclosed meaningful AI assistance if required?

Have I respected copyright and credited creative work?

Would I be comfortable explaining my research process to my audience?

If the answer to any of these questions is no, revise before you speak.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Ethical public speaking requires speakers to take responsibility for their messages. Because speakers can influence what audiences think, feel, believe, and do, they must use that influence carefully.

Speakers build trust through ethos, credibility, preparation, honesty, respect, responsibility, and fairness. Ethical speakers respect audience values, use free speech responsibly, contribute to constructive public discourse, avoid offensive and dehumanizing language, and represent evidence accurately.

Plagiarism is presenting another person's words, ideas, research, or creative work as your own. Speakers avoid plagiarism by quoting, paraphrasing, summarizing, and citing sources properly. In the 2026 communication environment, ethical speakers must also use artificial intelligence responsibly by verifying information, preserving original thinking, and disclosing meaningful AI assistance when required.

Copyright, fair use, and Creative Commons also matter in public speaking because speakers often use images, videos, music, charts, and other creative materials. Ethical speakers give credit, respect creators' rights, and use source material responsibly.

KEY TERMS

Ethics

Ethos

Speaker credibility

Audience values

Free speech

Public discourse

Invective rhetoric

Ad hominem attack

Dignity

Integrity

Trustworthiness

Respect

Responsibility

Fairness

Stereotype

Prejudice

Dehumanizing language

Hate speech

Plagiarism

Quotation

Paraphrase

Summary

Generative AI

AI disclosure

Copyright

Fair use

Public domain

Creative Commons

Attribution

NonCommercial

NoDerivatives

ShareAlike

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does public speaking require ethical responsibility?

2. What is the difference between legal speech and ethical speech?

3. How can a speaker strongly disagree with an audience while still respecting them?

4. Why is plagiarism especially damaging to speaker credibility?

5. What are appropriate and inappropriate ways to use AI while preparing a speech?

6. How can emotional appeals be used ethically?

7. Why should speakers be careful when using images, videos, music, or charts found online?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

ETHICAL SPEAKING SCENARIO

Choose one of the following scenarios and answer the questions below.

Scenario A: A student uses AI to create a full speech outline, then changes a few words and presents it as their own work.

Scenario B: A speaker uses a dramatic statistic from a social media post but does not check where the statistic came from.

Scenario C: A student gives a persuasive speech on a controversial topic and describes everyone who disagrees as “ignorant” and “heartless.”

Scenario D: A speaker uses several images from Google Images in their slides but does not credit the creators or sources.

Questions:

1. What is the ethical problem in this scenario?

2. Who could be harmed or misled?

3. What should the speaker have done differently?

4. How could the speaker revise the speech or preparation process to make it more ethical?

5. What principle is most relevant: trustworthiness, respect, responsibility, or fairness?

AI DISCLOSURE PRACTICE

Write a short disclosure statement for one ethical use of AI in speech preparation.

Example:

I used an AI tool to generate possible counterarguments and practice questions for my persuasive speech. I verified my research through library and government sources, and the final speech content is my own.

Chapter 5

LISTENERS AND SPEAKERS

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why listening is an active part of public speaking.
2. Identify common barriers to effective listening.
3. Explain the difference between selective, defensive, and empathetic listening.
4. Evaluate a speaker's evidence and reasoning responsibly.
5. Practice respectful listening during disagreement.
6. Provide constructive feedback that helps speakers improve.

Public speaking is not only about speaking. It is also about listening.

When you give a speech, you want the audience to listen carefully, consider your ideas, and respond with respect. When someone else is speaking, you have the same responsibility. A speech classroom depends on both sides of the communication process: speakers who prepare meaningful messages and listeners who give those messages fair attention.

Listening is sometimes mistaken for a passive activity. It is not. Effective listening requires effort. A good listener receives the message, interprets it, evaluates it, and responds appropriately. This means listening is not simply hearing sound. Hearing is physical. Listening is mental, emotional, and ethical.

Listening matters because speakers are affected by their audiences. A distracted, dismissive, or disrespectful audience can make speaking harder. An attentive and supportive audience can help speakers take risks, improve, and build confidence. In a public speaking course, you are not only learning how to speak. You are also learning how to become the kind of audience member every speaker deserves.

WE SELECTIVELY LISTEN

People do not listen to everything equally. Selective listening occurs when listeners pay attention to what interests them, confirms what they already believe, or feels personally relevant, while ignoring the rest.

Selective listening is natural, but it can create problems. If you only listen for what you already agree with, you may miss the speaker's actual point. If you only listen for mistakes, you may ignore the strengths of the message. If you only listen for information that affects you personally, you may miss why the topic matters to others.

Speakers should understand selective listening because audiences are always asking, even silently, "Why should I care?" A strong speaker gives the audience a reason to listen. This can be done through stories, examples, clear organization, repetition, audience-centered language, and meaningful visual aids.

Listeners should also work against selective listening by asking:

What is the speaker actually saying?

What is the main point?

What evidence is being offered?

What perspective is different from my own?

What can I learn, even if I disagree?

Good listening requires curiosity. Without curiosity, listening becomes waiting for your turn to talk.

LISTEN RESPONSIBLY

When you are speaking, you have power. You have the audience's attention. You choose the message, examples, evidence, and tone. But listeners also have power. They can use that power constructively or destructively.

Responsible listeners give speakers fair attention. They do not heckle, mock, interrupt, roll their eyes dramatically, side-talk, distract others, or use their phones in ways that signal disrespect. In a classroom setting, these behaviors do not just affect the instructor. They affect the speaker, who may already be managing anxiety.

Responsible listening does not mean agreeing with everything. It means giving the speaker enough respect to understand the message before judging it. If a speaker says something inaccurate, harmful, offensive, or poorly reasoned, listeners can and should respond appropriately. But the response should focus on the issue, evidence, and reasoning rather than personal attack.

Ethical listening requires both openness and judgment. You should be open enough to understand the message and critical enough to evaluate it.

FIND THE TRUTH THROUGH DIALOGUE

Public speaking should not be treated only as a contest where one side wins and the other loses. Some speeches are persuasive and argumentative, but even then, the larger goal should be understanding, truth-seeking, and responsible public dialogue.

Dialogue means sharing ideas in an atmosphere of respect. It requires speakers and listeners to recognize that no one person sees the entire picture. A speaker may have strong evidence and still miss part of the issue. A listener may disagree and still learn something valuable.

This does not mean all ideas are equally true or equally ethical. Some claims are better supported than others. Some arguments are more responsible than others. Some messages cause harm and deserve to be challenged. But challenge is strongest when it is informed by careful listening.

A good listener can say:

I understand your point, but I disagree with your evidence.

I see the value behind your argument, but I think you overlooked another perspective.

I agree with your concern, but I question your proposed solution.

I need clarification before I can evaluate your claim.

That kind of listening moves the conversation forward.

ANTICIPATE OBSTACLES TO LISTENING

Active listening is focused and purposeful. It requires attention, patience, and self-control. As you listen to speeches, try to identify the barriers that make listening difficult.

EXTERNAL DISTRACTIONS

External distractions are environmental factors that compete for your attention. These may include side conversations, hallway noise, construction, poor audio, uncomfortable seating, room temperature, or visual distractions.

To reduce external distractions, sit where you can see and hear the speaker. Put away unnecessary devices. Avoid side conversations. If you are presenting, consider the room setup, sound, lighting, and technology before you begin.

INTERNAL DISTRACTIONS

Internal distractions happen inside the listener. These may include hunger, fatigue, stress, anxiety, daydreaming, personal worries, or strong emotional reactions to the topic.

You may not be able to eliminate every internal distraction, but you can notice when your attention has drifted and bring it back. Listening is not about never losing focus. It is about returning to focus when you notice it slipping.

DIGITAL DISTRACTIONS

Digital distractions are now one of the biggest obstacles to listening. Phones, laptops, watches, notifications, messages, open tabs, and social media feeds compete constantly for attention.

Digital devices can be useful in a classroom, but they can also fracture attention. Checking one message can turn into checking five apps, three emails, a fantasy football score, and whether someone liked your story. Congratulations, you have left the speech without physically leaving the room.

When listening to a speech, use technology only if it helps you listen. Take notes if needed, but avoid multitasking. Multitasking usually means doing several things poorly at once.

AVOID ANTICIPATING AND DEFENSIVE LISTENING

Anticipating occurs when listeners stop listening because they are already planning what they want to say next. This happens often during discussion, debate, and peer feedback. Instead of fully hearing the speaker, the listener begins preparing a response.

Defensive listening occurs when listeners decide ahead of time that they dislike the speaker, topic, or viewpoint. A defensive listener may hear disagreement as a personal attack. They may reject the message before understanding it.

To avoid anticipating and defensive listening, practice holding an idea before judging it. You do not have to accept every argument. You do need to understand an argument before rejecting it.

A useful question is:

Can I explain the speaker's point in a way the speaker would recognize as fair?

If the answer is no, keep listening.

EVERYONE IS NOT LIKE YOU

One of the most important lessons in listening is that everyone is not like you. Audience members differ in background, culture, language, experience, education, values, politics, religion, identity, and communication style.

Do not judge a speaker only by accent, appearance, nervousness, clothing, vocal style, or delivery habits. Focus on the message. What is the speaker trying to communicate? What evidence are they using? What is the purpose? What can you learn from their perspective?

This does not mean delivery does not matter. Delivery affects how a message is received. But ethical listening requires that you do not dismiss a speaker simply because they do not sound, look, or speak like you.

EMPATHETIC LISTENING

Empathetic listening means trying to understand the speaker's experience, perspective, and emotional meaning. It does not require agreement. It requires attention and imagination.

Empathetic listening is especially important during personal speeches, cultural narratives, controversial topics, or speeches involving loss, identity, injustice, trauma, or deeply held values. In these moments, listeners should avoid treating the speaker's experience as an argument to defeat.

Empathetic listening asks:

What might this topic mean to the speaker?

What experience is shaping this message?

What emotion is connected to this story?

What should I understand before I respond?

A classroom with empathetic listeners becomes a safer place to take meaningful speaking risks.

EVALUATE EVIDENCE AND REASONING

Good listening is not the same as automatic agreement. As you listen, you should evaluate the speaker's evidence and reasoning.

Ask:

Is the evidence accurate?

Are the sources credible?

Are the sources current enough for the topic?

Does the evidence actually support the claim?

Is the speaker using examples fairly?

Are important perspectives being left out?

Is the reasoning logical?

Is the speaker relying on fallacies?

Are emotional appeals being used responsibly?

What alternative explanations should be considered?

This kind of listening makes you a stronger audience member and a stronger speaker. When you learn to evaluate other speeches, you also learn how to improve your own.

LISTEN FOR STRUCTURE

Effective listeners pay attention to organization. A well-organized speech is easier to follow, understand, and remember. As you listen, try to identify the speaker's introduction, thesis or central idea, main points, transitions, supporting material, and conclusion.

Ask:

Did the speaker clearly introduce the topic?

Could I identify the thesis or central idea?

Were the main points easy to follow?

Did the transitions help guide me?

Did the conclusion provide closure?

Listening for structure helps you give more useful feedback. Instead of saying, "It was good," you can say, "Your second main point was clear, but the transition into your conclusion felt sudden."

That is actual feedback. "It was good" is a participation trophy wearing a sentence costume.

GIVE CONSTRUCTIVE FEEDBACK

Feedback is one of the most important parts of a public speaking course. Speakers improve when they receive specific information about what worked and what needs revision.

Constructive feedback should be specific, respectful, and useful. It should focus on behavior, not personality. It should help the speaker understand what to keep doing and what to improve next time.

A simple feedback method is:

1. Name one specific strength.
2. Identify one specific area for improvement.
3. Suggest one specific next step.

For example:

Your opening story was strong because it immediately connected the topic to your personal experience. One area to improve is your oral citation. I heard the statistic, but I was not sure where it came from. Next time, name the source and date before giving the number.

This is better than vague praise or vague criticism. “Great job” is nice, but it does not teach much. “You seemed nervous” may be true, but it is not very useful by itself. Good feedback gives the speaker something they can actually do.

When giving feedback, avoid attacking the speaker’s identity, personality, voice, body, accent, or lived experience. Focus on choices the speaker can control: organization, clarity, evidence, vocal volume, pacing, eye contact, transitions, visual aids, and connection to the audience.

RECEIVE FEEDBACK RESPONSIBLY

Learning to receive feedback is just as important as learning to give it. It is natural to feel defensive when someone critiques your speech. Public speaking is personal. You may feel exposed. But feedback is not proof that you failed. It is information for growth.

When receiving feedback:

Listen without interrupting.

Ask clarifying questions.

Look for patterns across multiple comments.

Separate useful criticism from unhelpful criticism.

Decide what you will change next time.

Do not let one comment define your entire performance.

You do not have to accept every piece of feedback, but you should consider it honestly. Strong speakers learn how to use feedback without being crushed by it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Listening is an active and ethical part of public speaking. Effective listeners receive, interpret, evaluate, and respond to messages with attention and respect. In a speech classroom, listening helps create an environment where speakers can take risks and improve.

Selective listening, defensive listening, anticipating, external distractions, internal distractions, and digital distractions can all interfere with understanding. Responsible listeners work to manage these barriers.

Ethical listening requires openness, empathy, critical thinking, and respect. Listeners should focus on the message rather than judging the speaker unfairly. They should evaluate evidence and reasoning carefully while remaining open to perspectives different from their own.

Constructive feedback helps speakers improve when it is specific, respectful, and useful. Good feedback identifies strengths, names areas for improvement, and offers clear next steps.

KEY TERMS

Listening

Hearing

Selective listening

Responsible listening

Dialogue

Active listening

External distractions

Internal distractions

Digital distractions

Anticipating

Defensive listening

Empathetic listening

Evidence

Reasoning

Feedback

Constructive feedback

Audience responsibility

Speaker responsibility

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is listening an active process rather than a passive one?

2. What digital distractions make it harder for you to listen?

3. How can selective listening affect the way an audience receives a speech?

4. What is the difference between disagreeing with a speaker and listening defensively?

5. Why is empathetic listening important during personal or controversial speeches?

6. What makes feedback useful rather than vague or discouraging?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

LISTENING SELF-ASSESSMENT

After listening to a classmate's speech, answer the following questions:

1. What was the speaker's main idea?

2. What was one specific strength of the speech?

3. What was one moment when your attention drifted? What caused it?

4. What evidence or example was most memorable?

5. What is one question you would ask the speaker?

6. What is one specific suggestion that could help the speaker improve?

CONSTRUCTIVE FEEDBACK PRACTICE

Using the following format, write one piece of feedback for a speaker:

One specific strength:

One specific area for improvement:

One specific next step:

Example:

One specific strength: Your introduction was clear and immediately made the topic feel relevant.

One specific area for improvement: Your second main point needed a clearer source citation.

One specific next step: Before giving a statistic, name the source, date, and why the source is credible.

Chapter 6

ANALYZING THE AUDIENCE

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Define audience analysis and explain why it matters in public speaking.
2. Identify audience attitudes, beliefs, and values.
3. Explain how audience knowledge and interest affect speech preparation.
4. Adapt a speech to audience demographics without relying on stereotypes.
5. Develop speaker credibility by finding common ground with listeners.
6. Use surveys, interviews, and observation to gather audience information.
7. Assess the setting, occasion, and context before delivering a speech.

Audience analysis is the process of gathering and understanding information about your audience so you can prepare a speech that is meaningful, relevant, and appropriate for them. If public speaking is audience-centered, then audience analysis is where that work begins.

A speaker does not simply deliver information into the air and hope it lands. A speaker makes choices based on who is listening. The topic, examples, language, evidence, organization, visual aids, and delivery style should all be shaped by the audience and occasion.

Advertisers, politicians, teachers, performers, coaches, and business leaders all study audiences. They want to know what people care about, what motivates them, what concerns them, and what might move them to think or act differently. Public speakers do the same thing, but with an ethical goal: to communicate clearly, respectfully, and responsibly.

Keeping an audience-centered approach throughout the preparation process will help you create a presentation your audience is more likely to understand, remember, and care about.

WHO IS YOUR AUDIENCE?

Before you prepare a speech, ask: Who will be listening?

Understanding your audience is critical because people evaluate topics from their own point of view, not from the speaker's point of view. You may believe your topic is fascinating, urgent, or obvious, but your audience may not begin there. They may know very little about the subject. They may already agree with you. They may disagree strongly. They may feel indifferent. They may be curious but skeptical.

Audience analysis helps you avoid speaking only from your own assumptions.

For example, if you want to give a speech about reducing meat consumption, your approach should depend on the audience. A group of environmental science students may respond to climate data. A group of athletes may respond to health

and performance information. A group of people who value family food traditions may need a different approach entirely. The topic is the same, but the audience changes the strategy.

Audiences are not obstacles. They are the people you are trying to reach.

UNDERSTAND ATTITUDES, BELIEFS, AND VALUES

Attitudes, beliefs, and values shape how audiences respond to messages.

Attitudes are evaluations of people, ideas, objects, or events. An audience may have a positive, negative, or neutral attitude toward your topic. For example, some people may feel excited about artificial intelligence, while others may feel concerned, confused, or annoyed by it.

Beliefs are ideas people hold to be true or false. A person might believe that college is a good investment, that social media damages mental health, or that public transportation should be expanded. Beliefs may be based on evidence, personal experience, cultural background, media exposure, or misinformation.

Values are deeply held judgments about what is important, right, wrong, fair, desirable, or meaningful. Values often shape attitudes and beliefs. People may value freedom, safety, family, equality, tradition, responsibility, privacy, success, loyalty, creativity, faith, or community.

Values are often harder to change than attitudes because they are connected to identity and worldview. When a topic touches someone's values, the audience may respond more strongly.

This does not mean you should avoid meaningful topics. It means you should prepare carefully. A strong speaker understands not only what they want to say, but why the audience may accept, question, resist, or care about it.

GAUGE WHAT YOUR LISTENERS THINK OF THE TOPIC

One of the most important questions in audience analysis is: What does the audience already think or know about this topic?

If the topic is unfamiliar, begin with background information and clear definitions. Avoid jargon. Use examples. Explain why the topic matters before asking the audience to care about details.

If the audience already knows something about the topic, avoid spending too much time on basic information. Instead, offer new insights, updated evidence, a fresh perspective, or a more specific angle.

If the audience is indifferent, show relevance early. Indifferent audiences are not necessarily hostile. They may simply not understand why the topic should matter to them. Your job is to build a bridge between the topic and their interests, needs, values, or experiences.

If the audience is negatively disposed toward your topic, begin by establishing common ground. Do not open by attacking them. Start where agreement is possible, then introduce evidence carefully. A hostile or skeptical audience is more likely to listen when they feel respected rather than cornered.

If the audience is already favorable, you can reinforce their beliefs, deepen their understanding, or move them toward action. A supportive audience still needs evidence, structure, and clarity. Agreement does not excuse a lazy speech.

DEVELOP ETHOS EARLY ON

What an audience thinks of you affects how they respond to your message. Ethos refers to speaker credibility. Audiences are more likely to listen when they believe the speaker is prepared, honest, respectful, and knowledgeable.

You can develop ethos by showing that you understand the topic, care about the audience, and have prepared responsibly. This may involve briefly explaining your experience with the topic, citing credible sources, acknowledging complexity, and using language appropriate for the occasion.

People often connect with speakers who seem authentic and relatable. Finding common ground can help. Common ground may include shared experiences, values, goals, concerns, or questions.

However, being audience-centered does not mean pandering. Pandering means saying what the audience wants to hear just to gain approval. It weakens credibility

because it feels dishonest. Audience-centered speaking means adapting your message so the audience can understand and consider it seriously.

Good speakers do not pretend to be someone else. They find an honest connection between themselves, the topic, and the audience.

ADAPT TO AUDIENCE DEMOGRAPHICS

Demographics are statistical characteristics of a population. In public speaking, demographic analysis helps speakers consider audience characteristics that may influence how listeners understand or respond to a message.

Common demographic factors include:

Age

Cultural background

Language background

Education level

Occupation

Socioeconomic status

Religion

Political perspective

Gender identity

Sexual orientation

Disability

Family structure

Citizenship or immigration background

Access to technology

Demographic information can be useful, but it must be handled carefully. Demographics should guide questions, not create stereotypes. Knowing that an audience is mostly college students does not mean all of them think the same way. Knowing that an audience shares a cultural background does not mean every person has the same values, beliefs, or experiences.

Use demographics to ask better questions:

What examples will this audience understand?

What terms may need definition?

What assumptions should I avoid?

What experiences might be common in this group?

What differences might exist within this audience?

How can I speak respectfully to people who may not share my background?

Audience analysis should make you more thoughtful, not more simplistic.

AGE

Age can influence audience interests, experiences, responsibilities, and examples. A speech about retirement planning will likely land differently with college freshmen than with working adults near retirement. A speech about social media

may need different examples depending on whether the audience grew up with smartphones, adopted them later, or rarely uses them.

However, avoid assuming that all members of an age group think alike. Not every older adult fears technology. Not every young person understands every app. Generational patterns can be useful, but they are not destiny.

Use age to choose relevant examples, explain unfamiliar references, and avoid dated assumptions.

CULTURAL AND LANGUAGE BACKGROUND

Culture shapes communication. It can influence values, humor, storytelling, eye contact, gestures, silence, authority, time, conflict, and expectations for formality. Language background can also affect how audiences process a speech, especially when speakers use idioms, slang, jargon, or fast delivery.

When speaking to an audience with cultural or language differences from your own, be clear, respectful, and observant. Avoid assuming that your cultural norms are universal. Define terms. Use examples that do not require specialized cultural knowledge unless you explain them. Be careful with humor, sarcasm, and references that may not translate well.

This does not mean walking on eggshells. It means speaking with awareness. Good speakers do not treat culture as a costume or a checklist. They treat it as context.

SOCIOECONOMIC STATUS

Socioeconomic status can include income, education, occupation, neighborhood, access to resources, and social class. These factors can shape what audiences consider practical, affordable, urgent, or realistic.

For example, a speech recommending expensive wellness products may not connect with an audience worried about rent, tuition, or food costs. A speech about study abroad may need to consider financial access. A speech about technology may need to recognize that not everyone has the same devices, internet access, or schedule flexibility.

Audience-centered speakers avoid assuming that everyone has the same resources. They also avoid treating people with fewer resources as objects of pity. Respect means recognizing real conditions without reducing people to those conditions.

RELIGION

Do not assume your audience shares one religious background, or that members of the same religion agree on every issue. Religious belief can shape values, traditions, identity, family expectations, moral reasoning, holidays, food practices, clothing, and views on social issues.

If religion is relevant to your topic, discuss it accurately and respectfully. Avoid stereotypes. Avoid using one person or one example to represent an entire faith tradition. When possible, use credible sources and distinguish between individual belief, institutional teaching, cultural practice, and political interpretation.

POLITICAL PERSPECTIVE

Political topics can create strong reactions because they often connect to values, identity, family, media habits, and lived experience. Some audience members enjoy political debate. Others avoid it. Some may agree with your topic but dislike your approach. Others may disagree with your conclusion but respect your evidence.

When speaking about political or public issues, avoid reducing people to labels. Instead of assuming all conservatives, liberals, moderates, Democrats, Republicans, independents, or activists think the same way, focus on values, evidence, consequences, and policy choices.

A strong speaker can challenge an audience without insulting them. If your goal is persuasion, your first job is not to prove that your opponents are terrible people. Your first job is to give your audience a reason to keep listening.

GENDER, SEXUALITY, AND IDENTITY

Gender identity and sexual orientation may shape how audience members experience certain topics, especially those involving family, health, safety, language, law, media, relationships, education, or workplace policy.

Use inclusive language. Avoid assuming everyone is heterosexual, cisgender, married, single, or part of a traditional family structure. Avoid examples that make one identity seem normal and others seem unusual. When discussing identity-based topics, use accurate terms and avoid turning people into symbols or debate props.

If you are unsure about current terminology, research it through credible sources and listen to how communities describe themselves. Language changes because people change, culture changes, and public understanding changes. That is not a reason to panic. It is a reason to pay attention.

DISABILITY AND ACCESSIBILITY

Audience members may have visible or invisible disabilities. Some may experience hearing loss, vision impairment, mobility limitations, chronic pain, neurodivergence, anxiety, speech differences, or other conditions that affect how they receive a presentation.

Accessible speaking helps more people follow your message. Use clear organization, readable slides, strong contrast, captions when using video, and verbal explanations of important visuals. Avoid saying “as you can see” without explaining what is on the slide. Avoid mocking speech patterns, movement, attention differences, or assistive devices.

Accessibility is not an extra favor. It is part of good communication.

FOCUS ON VALUES

Labels can be useful, but values often tell you more about an audience. People with different political, religious, cultural, or generational identities may still share values such as safety, fairness, freedom, responsibility, family, opportunity, respect, dignity, community, health, or belonging.

Focusing on values can help you build common ground. For example, people may disagree about a specific education policy but agree that students deserve a fair chance to succeed. People may disagree about environmental regulations but agree that clean air and safe neighborhoods matter.

A speaker who understands shared values can frame a message more effectively. This does not mean watering down your argument. It means connecting your argument to something the audience already finds meaningful.

GET INFORMATION ABOUT YOUR AUDIENCE

You may not be a professional pollster, but you can still gather useful information about an audience. Depending on the situation, you may use observation, informal conversation, interviews, questionnaires, polls, or prior knowledge about the speaking occasion.

For a classroom speech, you might observe what topics classmates respond to during discussion. You might ask a few classmates what they know about your topic. You might create a short anonymous survey. You might ask your instructor about audience expectations for the assignment.

Audience information does not have to be perfect to be useful. Even a few responses can help you avoid assumptions and make smarter choices.

SURVEY YOUR AUDIENCE

A questionnaire or poll can help you learn about audience knowledge, attitudes, experiences, or interests. Keep surveys short and respectful. Ask only what you need to know for the speech.

CLOSED-ENDED QUESTIONS

Closed-ended questions provide limited response options. They are useful when you want clear, easy-to-count answers.

Example:

How familiar are you with generative AI tools?

Very familiar

Somewhat familiar

Not very familiar

Not familiar at all

SCALE QUESTIONS

Scale questions measure levels of agreement, importance, familiarity, or concern.

Example:

How concerned are you about misinformation online?

Very concerned

Somewhat concerned

Neutral

Not very concerned

Not concerned at all

OPEN-ENDED QUESTIONS

Open-ended questions allow audience members to explain their thoughts in their own words.

Example:

What is one concern you have about using AI in school?

Open-ended questions can reveal ideas you did not expect, but they take more time to interpret.

A good survey may include a mix of closed-ended, scale, and open-ended questions.

ASK ETHICAL SURVEY QUESTIONS

Audience research should be ethical. Do not ask questions that are unnecessarily personal, embarrassing, invasive, or irrelevant to your speech. If responses are anonymous, protect that anonymity. Do not pressure people to reveal sensitive information in front of others.

For example, instead of asking, “Have you ever been diagnosed with anxiety?” you might ask, “How common do you think speech anxiety is among college students?” The second question is less invasive and still useful for many speech topics.

Ask only what helps you prepare the speech. Curiosity is not a license to become nosy with a clipboard.

ASSESS THE SETTING AND CONTEXT

The setting and context can affect how your speech should be prepared and delivered. Before speaking, gather information about the room, technology, audience size, seating, time limit, and occasion.

Ask:

How large is the audience?

How large is the room?

Will I use a microphone?

Will I have slides or a screen?

Will the audience be seated close together or spread out?

Will I be speaking in person, online, or in a hybrid setting?

How much time do I have?

Who else is speaking?

What is the occasion?

Is the audience required to attend or choosing to attend?

Will there be questions afterward?

Are there accessibility needs I should consider?

Can I test the technology before speaking?

If possible, rehearse in the room where you will speak. If that is not possible, recreate the conditions as closely as you can. Practice standing if you will stand. Practice with slides if you will use slides. Practice with a microphone if one will be used. Walk through your transitions and visual aids.

Context matters. A speech delivered in a classroom, boardroom, city council meeting, wedding reception, livestream, or conference panel will not feel the same. Strong speakers adapt to the situation.

ADAPTING WITHOUT LOSING YOURSELF

Audience analysis does not mean becoming fake. It means making thoughtful choices so your message can reach the people in front of you.

You may adapt your examples, word choice, evidence, delivery style, or level of background information. But you should not abandon your values, distort your evidence, or pretend to believe something you do not believe just to gain approval.

The goal is to be clear, respectful, and strategic while remaining honest.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Audience analysis is the process of learning about an audience so you can prepare a speech that is relevant, clear, and appropriate. Audience-centered speakers consider what listeners know, believe, value, need, and expect.

Audiences may differ in attitudes, beliefs, values, demographics, cultural background, language, education, socioeconomic status, religion, politics, gender identity, sexuality, disability, and access to technology. These differences should guide thoughtful adaptation, not stereotyping.

Speakers can gather audience information through observation, conversation, interviews, questionnaires, and surveys. Surveys may include closed-ended questions, scale questions, and open-ended questions. Ethical audience research avoids invasive or unnecessary questions.

The speaking setting also matters. Audience size, room layout, technology, time limit, occasion, and delivery format all shape how a speech should be prepared and delivered. Strong speakers adapt to their audience and context while remaining honest and authentic.

KEY TERMS

Audience analysis

Audience-centered speaking

Attitudes

Beliefs

Values

Demographics

Target audience

Ethos

Common ground

Pandering

Cultural background

Language background

Socioeconomic status

Political perspective

Gender identity

Sexual orientation

Disability

Accessibility

Closed-ended questions

Scale questions

Open-ended questions

Setting

Context

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is audience analysis one of the most important parts of speech preparation?

2. What is the difference between adapting to an audience and pandering to an audience?

3. Why should speakers be careful when using demographic information?

4. How can shared values help a speaker connect with an audience?

5. What are some ethical concerns when surveying an audience?

6. How might a speaker adapt differently for an in-person, online, or hybrid presentation?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

AUDIENCE ANALYSIS PLAN

Choose a possible speech topic and answer the following questions:

1. Who is your audience?

2. What might they already know about your topic?

3. What attitudes might they have toward your topic?

4. What values might connect to this topic?

5. What assumptions should you avoid making about this audience?

6. What is one example, story, or statistic that might make the topic relevant to them?

7. What is one question you could ask the audience before preparing your speech?

SURVEY PRACTICE

Create three audience-analysis questions for your topic:

1. One closed-ended question.

2. One scale question.

3. One open-ended question.

Example topic: AI in college classrooms

Closed-ended question: Have you used an AI tool for schoolwork before?

Scale question: How concerned are you about AI being used dishonestly in college courses?

Open-ended question: What is one way AI could help or hurt student learning?

Chapter 7

SELECTING A TOPIC AND PURPOSE

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Identify strategies for selecting a speech topic.
2. Explain how audience, occasion, and assignment requirements shape topic choice.
3. Narrow a broad topic into a focused speech topic.
4. Distinguish between a general topic, narrowed topic, general purpose, specific purpose, and thesis statement.
5. Use brainstorming techniques to generate speech ideas.
6. Develop a thesis statement that is clear, relevant, and motivating.

One of the first and most challenging tasks in preparing a speech is selecting a topic and purpose. Even when a topic is assigned, you still need to adapt it to the audience, occasion, time limit, and assignment.

Topic selection matters because a speech begins long before you stand in front of the room. It begins with a choice: What is worth talking about? A strong topic gives you direction. A weak topic makes every other part of the speech harder. Research becomes harder. Organization becomes harder. Delivery becomes harder. Even your soul starts checking the clock.

A good speech topic should meet three basic standards:

1. It matters to you.
2. It matters to your audience.
3. It can be developed clearly within the time limit.

If a topic only matters to you, the audience may tune out. If it only matters to the audience, you may sound fake or disconnected. The strongest topics usually live in the overlap between your interests and the audience's needs.

DECIDE WHERE TO BEGIN

When students ask for help picking a topic, a useful first question is: What do you care about?

Begin with your interests, questions, experiences, communities, frustrations, hobbies, goals, or curiosities. What do you find yourself talking about when no one is forcing you? What issues make you angry? What problems do you want to understand? What stories shaped you? What skills do you have? What do you want to learn more about?

Most audiences would rather hear an enthusiastic speech about Kendrick Lamar, horror films, sneaker culture, gaming, food trucks, sleep habits, or artificial intelligence than a lifeless speech about a topic the speaker chose only because it sounded "academic."

Passion helps, but passion is not enough. You also need focus, evidence, and audience relevance. A speech based only on passion can turn into a rant. A speech based only on research can turn into a Wikipedia page with shoes. The goal is to combine interest with purpose.

CONSIDER THE AUDIENCE

A speech should be interesting to both the speaker and the audience. Audience analysis helps you decide whether a topic will connect with listeners and what angle will make it meaningful.

For example, a student might want to give a speech on falconry, the sport of hunting with trained birds of prey. That topic could be fascinating. However, if the speaker focuses only on the cost of owning a falcon or assumes the audience shares that hobby, many listeners may struggle to relate. A stronger approach might focus on the history of falconry, the relationship between humans and animals, or why falconry remains culturally significant in different parts of the world.

The topic itself is not the problem. The angle matters.

Ask:

What does my audience already know about this topic?

Why would they care?

What examples would help them connect?

What assumptions should I avoid?

What part of this topic is most relevant to this audience?

Good speakers do not simply bring a topic to the audience. They build a bridge between the topic and the audience.

BEEN THERE, HEARD THAT

Some topics are overused in public speaking classes. Students often return to topics such as smoking, drunk driving, capital punishment, marijuana legalization, abortion, gun control, social media, serial killers, and student debt. These topics are not automatically bad, but they are often too broad, too familiar, too emotionally charged, or too predictable.

An overdone topic can still work if you find a fresh angle.

Weak topic: Social media is bad for mental health.

Stronger topic: How "doomscrolling" affects sleep habits among college students.

Weak topic: Fast food is unhealthy.

Stronger topic: How menu design influences what customers order at fast-food restaurants.

Weak topic: AI is dangerous.

Stronger topic: Why students should verify AI-generated sources before using them in speeches.

Weak topic: Climate change is a problem.

Stronger topic: How urban heat islands affect low-income neighborhoods.

A fresh angle makes the topic more manageable and more interesting.

Some topics may also be restricted by your instructor because they are too broad, too repetitive, too difficult to handle responsibly in a short speech, or too likely to produce speeches based on emotion rather than evidence. If your course includes a banned topics list, use it as a challenge, not a punishment. The point is to push you toward something more specific, original, and researchable.

CHOOSE TOPICS YOU CAN HANDLE RESPONSIBLY

Controversial topics can produce strong speeches, but they require care. Topics involving religion, race, sexuality, gender identity, violence, trauma, immigration, war, policing, public health, abortion, suicide, or political extremism can affect audience members personally. That does not mean these subjects can never be discussed. It means speakers must handle them with accuracy, maturity, and respect.

Before selecting a sensitive topic, ask:

Can I discuss this topic without stereotyping or dehumanizing people?

Can I support my claims with credible evidence?

Can I represent opposing views fairly?

Can I stay within the time limit without oversimplifying the issue?

Am I prepared to speak responsibly if audience members have personal experience with this topic?

If the answer is no, choose a different angle or a different topic.

TRY BRAINSTORMING TO GENERATE IDEAS

Brainstorming helps you generate possible topics before judging them. Do not begin by looking for the perfect topic. Begin by creating options.

Three useful brainstorming strategies are word association, topic mapping, and category brainstorming.

WORD ASSOCIATION

Word association means writing down the first ideas that come to mind when you think of a broad subject. Start with one broad word or phrase, then list related ideas quickly.

For example:

Broad subject: Music

Associated ideas: concerts, streaming, lyrics, identity, protest songs, playlists, memory, dance, film scores, Kendrick Lamar, music therapy, TikTok sounds, sampling, copyright, workout music

After creating the list, review it and circle the ideas that seem most interesting, researchable, and audience-centered.

TOPIC MAPPING

Topic mapping is a visual brainstorming technique. Write a broad topic in the center of the page. Around it, write related subtopics, questions, examples, causes, effects, controversies, and possible angles.

For example:

Broad topic: Artificial Intelligence

Possible branches:

AI in education

AI and cheating

AI and creativity

AI and jobs

AI and misinformation

AI and bias

AI image generation

AI as a study tool

AI and privacy

A topic map helps you see that a broad topic is actually many smaller topics. Your job is to find the part that fits your assignment and audience.

CATEGORY BRAINSTORMING

Category brainstorming means breaking a broad topic into smaller categories.

For example, if your broad topic is video games, possible categories might include:

Game platforms: PlayStation, Xbox, Nintendo, PC, mobile

Game genres: role-playing, racing, sports, fighting, horror, first-person shooter

Game culture: streaming, esports, cosplay, online communities

Game design: storytelling, sound, graphics, difficulty, accessibility

Game effects: teamwork, addiction, problem-solving, reaction time, social connection

Game industry: labor, monetization, microtransactions, artificial intelligence

From there, you can choose a more focused topic.

Weak topic: Video games

Stronger topic: How accessibility settings in modern video games help disabled players participate more fully.

That is narrower, fresher, and more meaningful.

USE AI AS A BRAINSTORMING PARTNER

Generative AI tools can help you brainstorm speech topics, but they should not choose the topic for you. AI can generate possibilities, questions, counterarguments, and narrower angles. You are still responsible for deciding whether the topic fits the assignment, audience, and your own interests.

Useful prompts might include:

Give me ten informative speech topics related to communication and technology.

Help me narrow the topic of social media into a five-minute classroom speech.

Suggest fresh persuasive speech topics for college students that are not overdone.

Give me three possible angles for a speech about AI in education.

What are possible audience concerns about a speech on student stress?

AI can produce useful starting points, but it can also produce bland, generic, or inaccurate suggestions. Do not use AI as a substitute for curiosity. Use it as a tool to generate options, then make your own choice.

IDENTIFY THE PURPOSE OF YOUR SPEECH

Once you have a topic, determine the purpose of the speech. Your purpose answers the question:

Why am I speaking about this topic to this audience on this occasion?

Most speeches have one of three general purposes:

To inform

To persuade

To mark a special occasion

An informative speech increases the audience's understanding of a topic. The goal is to explain, describe, demonstrate, or clarify.

A persuasive speech attempts to influence the audience's attitudes, beliefs, values, or actions.

A special occasion speech celebrates, honors, mourns, entertains, commemorates, or inspires.

The general purpose gives your speech a broad direction. The specific purpose gives it focus.

NARROW YOUR TOPIC

Broad topics are usually too large for classroom speeches. A five-minute speech cannot cover “mental health,” “climate change,” “music,” “artificial intelligence,” or “college.” These topics need to be narrowed.

To narrow your topic, ask:

What part of this topic interests me most?

What does my audience already know?

What does my audience need to know?

What can I explain or prove in the time allowed?

What examples or evidence can I realistically find?

What angle feels fresh or specific?

Examples:

Broad topic: Mental health

Narrowed topic: How sleep habits affect student stress

Broad topic: Artificial intelligence

Narrowed topic: How students can use AI ethically during speech preparation

Broad topic: Food culture

Narrowed topic: How family recipes preserve cultural identity

Broad topic: Transportation

Narrowed topic: Why college campuses should improve bike access

Broad topic: Horror movies

Narrowed topic: How sound design creates fear in horror films

A narrowed topic gives your speech boundaries. Boundaries are good. Without them, your speech becomes a buffet where everything is served cold.

FORM A SPECIFIC PURPOSE

The specific purpose statement identifies exactly what you want your speech to accomplish. It is written from the speaker's perspective and usually begins with "To inform my audience…" or "To persuade my audience…"

A specific purpose should be clear, focused, and realistic.

Example:

GENERAL TOPIC: Artificial intelligence

NARROWED TOPIC: AI as a speech preparation tool

GENERAL PURPOSE: To inform

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three responsible ways students can use AI while preparing a speech.

Another example:

GENERAL TOPIC: Student debt

NARROWED TOPIC: How students can reduce borrowing before transferring

GENERAL PURPOSE: To inform

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three strategies students can use to reduce college debt before transferring to a university.

You do not always state the specific purpose word for word in your speech. It is mainly for you. It helps you understand exactly what you are trying to accomplish.

COMPOSE A THESIS STATEMENT

A thesis statement is a single sentence that expresses the central idea of your speech. The thesis tells your audience what the speech is about. It should be clear, focused, and connected to your main points.

The specific purpose and thesis statement are closely related, but they are not the same.

The specific purpose explains what you want to accomplish.

The thesis statement explains the central idea you want the audience to understand or accept.

Example:

GENERAL TOPIC: Artificial intelligence

NARROWED TOPIC: AI as a speech preparation tool

GENERAL PURPOSE: To inform

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three responsible ways students can use AI while preparing a speech.

THESIS STATEMENT: Students can use AI responsibly during speech preparation by brainstorming topics, organizing early ideas, and generating practice questions while still verifying information and preserving their own voice.

Another example:

GENERAL TOPIC: Student debt

NARROWED TOPIC: How students can reduce borrowing before transferring

GENERAL PURPOSE: To inform

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three strategies students can use to reduce college debt before transferring to a university.

THESIS STATEMENT: Students can reduce college debt before transferring by applying for financial aid early, comparing transfer pathways, and limiting unnecessary borrowing.

A weak thesis announces the topic.

Weak thesis: Today I will talk about student debt.

A stronger thesis makes a focused statement.

Stronger thesis: Students can reduce college debt by planning transfer pathways, applying for aid early, and understanding loan terms before borrowing.

POSTPONE DEVELOPMENT OF MAIN POINTS

Once you have a working thesis, you may be tempted to immediately lock in your main points. Be careful. Main points should be shaped by research, audience needs, and the time limit. Early main points are useful, but they may change.

Do some research before finalizing your main points. You may discover that one idea has little evidence, another is too complicated, and another is more interesting than you expected.

In an informative speech, main points usually explain the major parts of the topic.

In a persuasive speech, main points usually function as arguments that support the thesis.

Example:

GENERAL PURPOSE: To persuade

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To persuade my audience to support free access to basic public speaking courses at community colleges.

THESIS STATEMENT: Public speaking courses should be more widely available because they improve student confidence, strengthen career readiness, and support civic participation.

Possible main points:

1. Public speaking courses help students build confidence.
2. Public speaking courses strengthen career readiness.
3. Public speaking courses support civic participation.

Each main point develops the thesis.

MAKE THE THESIS STATEMENT RELEVANT AND MOTIVATING

A thesis statement should be clear, but it should also give the audience a reason to listen. You can make your thesis more relevant by connecting it to the audience's experiences, concerns, goals, or assumptions.

For informative speeches, you might use phrases such as:

You may not know…

Contrary to popular belief…

Many students assume…

One overlooked reason…

A common misunderstanding is…

A useful way to understand this is…

For persuasive speeches, you might emphasize consequences, values, urgency, or practical action.

Weak thesis: College students should sleep more.

Stronger thesis: College students can improve focus, mood, and academic performance by treating sleep as a study strategy rather than wasted time.

The stronger version gives the audience a reason to care. It connects sleep to outcomes students may value.

TEST YOUR TOPIC BEFORE COMMITTING

Before you fully commit to a topic, test it.

Ask yourself:

Can I explain this topic in one sentence?

Can I find credible sources?

Can I make the topic relevant to my audience?

Can I cover it in the time limit?

Is it appropriate for the assignment?

Do I care enough to work on it for several days or weeks?

Does it offer something fresh, useful, or meaningful?

If the answer to most of these questions is yes, you probably have a workable topic. If not, narrow it, change the angle, or choose something else.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Selecting a topic and purpose is one of the first major steps in preparing a speech. A strong topic should matter to the speaker, matter to the audience, and fit the assignment, occasion, and time limit.

Speakers can generate topics through personal interests, audience analysis, word association, topic mapping, category brainstorming, and responsible use of AI tools. Overdone topics can still work when speakers find a fresh, specific angle.

A broad topic should be narrowed into a focused topic. From there, the speaker develops a general purpose, specific purpose, and thesis statement. The general purpose identifies whether the speech is meant to inform, persuade, or mark a special occasion. The specific purpose states what the speaker wants to accomplish. The thesis statement expresses the central idea of the speech in one clear sentence.

Strong speakers test their topics before committing. A good topic is clear, researchable, audience-centered, appropriate, and manageable within the time limit.

KEY TERMS

Topic

Broad topic

Narrowed topic

Audience relevance

Brainstorming

Word association

Topic mapping

Category brainstorming

General purpose

Specific purpose

Informative speech

Persuasive speech

Special occasion speech

Thesis statement

Main points

Audience-centered topic

Overdone topic

Sensitive topic

AI brainstorming

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why should a speech topic matter to both the speaker and the audience?

2. What makes a topic too broad for a classroom speech?

3. How can an overdone topic become fresh or interesting?

4. What is the difference between a general purpose and a specific purpose?

5. Why should speakers sometimes wait to finalize main points until after doing research?

6. How can AI help with brainstorming without replacing the speaker's own thinking?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

TOPIC NARROWING PRACTICE

Choose one broad topic from the list below:

Artificial intelligence

Mental health

Music

Sports

College

Food

Gaming

Social media

Transportation

Climate

Family traditions

Workplace communication

Complete the following steps:

1. Write the broad topic.

2. Narrow the topic into something that could fit a five-minute classroom speech.

3. Identify the audience.

4. Write the general purpose.

5. Write the specific purpose.

6. Write a thesis statement.

7. List three possible main points.

Example:

Broad topic: Gaming

Narrowed topic: Accessibility settings in video games

Audience: College students who play or know people who play video games

General purpose: To inform

Specific purpose: To inform my audience about how accessibility settings help more people participate in video games.

Thesis statement: Accessibility settings in video games help players with disabilities participate more fully by adapting visual, audio, and control features to different needs.

Main points:

1. Visual settings can support players with different vision needs.

2. Audio settings can support players who are deaf or hard of hearing.

3. Control settings can support players with mobility differences.

AI BRAINSTORMING PRACTICE

Use an AI tool, a search engine, or your own brainstorming to generate ten possible speech topics. Then choose the three strongest topics and answer:

1. Which topic interests me most?

2. Which topic would matter most to my audience?

3. Which topic is easiest to narrow?

4. Which topic can be supported with credible evidence?

5. Which topic feels the least overdone?

Choose one topic and turn it into a specific purpose and thesis statement.

Chapter 8

DEVELOPING SUPPORTING MATERIAL

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Define supporting material and explain why it matters in public speaking.
2. Identify common types of supporting material, including examples, narratives, testimony, facts, and statistics.
3. Distinguish between brief examples, extended examples, and hypothetical examples.
4. Use testimony from experts and ordinary people responsibly.
5. Present statistics clearly and ethically.
6. Evaluate whether supporting material is accurate, relevant, credible, and appropriate for the audience.
7. Explain how AI-generated examples or summaries should and should not be used in a speech.

A speech should contain accurate, relevant, and interesting supporting material. Supporting material gives substance to your thesis and main points. It helps the audience understand your ideas, believe your claims, and remember your message.

Supporting material can include examples, stories, testimony, facts, statistics, analogies, definitions, visuals, demonstrations, and research findings. A speech without support is just a collection of claims. You may sound confident, but confidence is not evidence.

As you research and prepare, try to use a variety of supporting material. A personal story may help the audience connect emotionally. A statistic may show the size of a problem. Expert testimony may build credibility. A concrete example may make an abstract idea easier to understand. Moving between different kinds of support keeps the speech more interesting and more persuasive.

The goal is not to throw random evidence at the audience. The goal is to choose support that helps your audience understand, care, and believe.

USE SUPPORTING MATERIAL STRATEGICALLY

Supporting material should serve a purpose. Before adding a story, statistic, quotation, or example, ask:

What point does this support?

Is this evidence credible?

Is it relevant to my audience?

Is it current enough for my topic?

Is it clear enough to explain out loud?

Does it strengthen my message or distract from it?

Good supporting material does at least one of the following:

Clarifies an idea

Proves or strengthens a claim

Makes an abstract concept concrete

Adds emotional connection

Builds speaker credibility

Helps the audience remember the point

Shows the significance of an issue

Anticipates audience questions or doubts

If the material does not help the audience, leave it out. Not every interesting fact belongs in your speech. Some facts are just academic glitter.

EXAMPLES

Examples help an audience understand ideas by making them more concrete. They are especially useful when explaining something unfamiliar, abstract, technical, or complex.

For example, if you say, “AI can hallucinate sources,” some audience members may not understand what that means. A concrete example would help:

A student may ask an AI tool for sources about social media and anxiety. The tool may generate article titles, author names, and journal names that sound real but do not actually exist. If the student does not verify those sources, the speech may include fake evidence.

That example makes the concept easier to understand.

Examples work because they give the audience something specific to picture. Instead of asking listeners to understand an idea in the abstract, you show them what the idea looks like in real life.

BRIEF EXAMPLES

A brief example offers a single illustration of a point. Brief examples are usually short and should not take more than a few sentences.

For example, if you are giving a speech about workplace communication, you might say:

A manager who gives unclear instructions may think an employee is careless, when the real problem is that the task was never explained clearly.

That brief example clarifies the point without becoming a full story.

Brief examples are useful when you need to clarify an idea quickly, add variety, or help the audience understand a general claim.

EXTENDED EXAMPLES

An extended example develops an idea in more detail. It may take the form of a short story, case study, anecdote, or detailed illustration. Extended examples are

useful when the audience needs more context or when the speaker wants to create stronger emotional connection.

For example, if you are giving a speech about first-generation college students, you might describe a student who works a night shift, commutes to campus, helps care for siblings, and still tries to navigate financial aid forms without family experience in higher education. That extended example helps the audience see the topic as a lived experience rather than just a category.

Extended examples should still be focused. A story should not wander around the speech like it lost its car keys. It should support a clear point.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLES

A hypothetical example describes an imaginary situation that could happen. Hypothetical examples are useful when asking the audience to imagine consequences, possibilities, or decisions.

For example:

Imagine you are about to give a speech and your first source disappears from the website the night before. You still have the statistic in your outline, but you no longer know where it came from. Without a saved citation, you cannot verify it, and now your credibility is at risk.

This situation may be invented, but it illustrates a real problem: speakers need to track their sources carefully.

Hypothetical examples should be realistic and clearly presented as imagined situations. Do not present a hypothetical example as if it actually happened. That is not creativity; that is lying with better lighting.

NARRATIVES

A narrative is a story. Stories are one of the most powerful forms of supporting material because they help audiences connect ideas to human experience. Stories can create emotional connection, build suspense, illustrate consequences, and make information memorable.

Good stories usually include characters, setting, conflict, and movement over time. They do not need to be long, but they should have a clear purpose.

Narratives can come from:

Personal experience

Historical events

Interviews

Case studies

News stories

Biographies

Community experiences

Fictional or hypothetical scenarios, if clearly identified as such

Stories are powerful, but they should not replace evidence. A personal story can show what happened to one person, but it does not automatically prove what happens to most people. If you tell a story about one student struggling with college debt, that story may create emotional connection. But if you want to prove that student debt is a widespread issue, you also need data from credible sources.

Use stories to humanize evidence. Do not use stories as a substitute for evidence when your claim requires proof.

TESTIMONY

Testimony is support that comes from what other people say about a topic. Testimony may come from experts, witnesses, participants, or people with lived experience.

EXPERT TESTIMONY

Expert testimony comes from people who have professional training, research experience, education, or recognized knowledge related to the topic. A climate scientist speaking about climate data, a physician explaining a medical treatment, or a communication scholar discussing public speaking anxiety can provide expert testimony.

LAY TESTIMONY

Lay testimony comes from ordinary people who have firsthand experience with the topic. A student discussing what it feels like to be the first in their family to attend college is offering lay testimony. A worker describing unsafe conditions at a job is offering firsthand experience. A patient describing life with chronic pain is offering lived experience.

Both types of testimony can be valuable, but they serve different purposes.

Expert testimony can help explain, interpret, or validate information.

Lay testimony can help illustrate human experience and emotional reality.

When using testimony, identify the person, explain why their perspective matters, and provide context. Do not simply drop a quote into your speech and sprint away.

For example:

In a 2026 interview, Dr. Maria Lopez, a clinical psychologist who studies student anxiety, explained that speech anxiety often decreases when students rehearse in conditions similar to the final presentation.

This citation gives the audience the person's name, date, qualification, and relevance.

USING TESTIMONY RESPONSIBLY

Testimony must be used fairly. Do not take someone's words out of context. Do not cherry-pick a quote that misrepresents the person's full position. Do not use one person's story to make a sweeping claim about an entire group.

When using testimony, ask:

Is this person qualified or relevant to the topic?

Is the testimony current enough?

Am I representing their view accurately?

Does this testimony support my point?

Have I provided enough context?

Would the person recognize this as a fair use of their words?

If the answer is no, revise.

FACTS

A fact is information that can be verified as true. Facts can include dates, events, names, definitions, records, and documented observations. For example, the year a law passed, the date of a historic speech, or the definition of a technical term may function as factual support.

However, not every statement that sounds factual is reliable. Speakers must verify facts through credible sources. This is especially important when using information from social media, websites, AI tools, podcasts, or online videos.

For example, “Many people say…” is not a fact. “A 2025 Pew Research Center survey found…” is much stronger because it names a source and points toward verifiable evidence.

STATISTICS

Statistics use numbers to summarize, compare, measure, or predict. They can show the size of a problem, the frequency of an event, the relationship between variables, or the change in a trend over time.

Statistics can make a speech more credible, but only if the audience understands them. A statistic that confuses the audience does not help you. Numbers should be explained, simplified, and connected to the point.

For example, saying “one in three” may be easier for an audience to understand than saying “33.3 percent.” Saying “about the size of a football field” may help an audience visualize space better than only giving square footage.

When presenting statistics, translate numbers into meaning.

Weak version:

The program costs $2.7 billion.

Stronger version:

The program costs $2.7 billion, which is about $8 for every person in the United States.

The second version gives the audience a way to understand the scale.

PRESENT STATISTICS ETHICALLY

Statistics can be persuasive, but they can also be misleading. Ethical speakers present statistics accurately and in context.

Use the following guidelines:

Use reliable sources.

Statistics from government agencies, peer-reviewed research, universities, professional organizations, and reputable research centers are usually stronger than numbers from random websites, social media posts, or unsourced graphics.

Explain where the number came from.

Tell the audience who collected the data, when it was collected, and what it measures.

Provide context.

A number by itself may not mean much. Explain whether the number is high, low, increasing, decreasing, unusual, or part of a larger trend.

Avoid cherry-picking.

Do not select only the numbers that support your point while ignoring stronger evidence that complicates it.

Avoid false certainty.

Statistics often estimate, suggest, or indicate. They do not always prove a claim beyond all doubt.

Be careful with old statistics.

Some topics change quickly. Data about AI, social media, public health, technology, employment, and political attitudes can become outdated quickly.

Do not confuse correlation with causation.

Just because two things happen together does not mean one caused the other.

For example, if students who sleep more also report lower stress, that does not automatically prove sleep caused lower stress. Other factors may be involved.

SIMPLIFY WITHOUT DISTORTING

A speaker should simplify statistics for the audience, but simplification should not distort the meaning. Rounding a number may be helpful. Changing the meaning is not.

For example, if a study finds that 48 percent of students report feeling stressed "often," it may be reasonable to say "nearly half." It would not be ethical to say "almost all students are constantly stressed."

Simplifying helps the audience. Exaggerating misleads them.

USE ANALOGIES CAREFULLY

An analogy compares two things to explain a relationship or idea. Analogies can help audiences understand unfamiliar concepts by connecting them to familiar ones.

For example:

A working outline is like a blueprint. It shows how the speech is built before the final version is delivered.

Analogies can be powerful, but they have limits. Two things may be similar in one way but different in many others. Do not push an analogy too far. If the comparison becomes confusing or misleading, it stops helping.

USE AI-GENERATED MATERIAL CAREFULLY

AI tools can help generate possible examples, analogies, or explanations. This can be useful during brainstorming, but AI-generated material should not be treated as automatically true, original, or appropriate.

AI may invent facts, create fake examples, produce biased assumptions, or generate stories that sound realistic but are not based on evidence. If you use AI to brainstorm examples, you are responsible for checking whether those examples are accurate, ethical, and appropriate for your speech.

Use AI to help you think, not to fake support.

Acceptable use:

Asking AI to suggest possible analogies for explaining confirmation bias.

Asking AI to help simplify a complex concept for a general audience.

Asking AI to generate practice examples that you then revise and verify.

Unacceptable use:

Inventing a fake personal story.

Using an AI-generated statistic without verifying it.

Presenting an AI-created example as if it actually happened.

Using AI-generated testimony from a person who does not exist.

A good rule: if the supporting material is being used as evidence, verify it through a credible source.

ORALLY CITE YOUR SOURCES

The way you cite in a speech is different from how you cite in an essay. In a written paper, your audience can look at a works cited page or reference list. In a speech, the audience hears the citation once, in real time.

For oral citations, include enough information for the audience to trust the source.

A strong oral citation usually includes:

The source or organization

The author, when relevant

The type of source

The date

The source's credibility or qualification, when helpful

For example:

According to a 2026 report from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, a federal public health agency…

In a 2025 article published by The Associated Press, technology reporter Matt O'Brien explained…

In her book Quiet, published in 2012, author Susan Cain argues…

Do not recite a full MLA or APA citation out loud. The audience does not need a long URL read to them. Give them the information they need to understand where the material came from and why it is credible.

See Chapter 11 for more on citing sources in your speech.

SUPPORTING MATERIAL CHECKLIST

Before using supporting material in your speech, ask:

Does this support my thesis or main point?

Is it accurate?

Is it relevant?

Is it recent enough for my topic?

Is the source credible?

Will my audience understand it?

Does it need explanation or context?

Am I using it fairly?

Have I cited it properly?

Does it make my speech stronger?

If the answer is no, revise or replace it.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Supporting material gives substance to a speech. It helps explain, prove, clarify, and strengthen the speaker's ideas. Common types of supporting material include examples, narratives, testimony, facts, statistics, analogies, and visual material.

Examples make ideas concrete. Narratives create emotional connection and help audiences understand human experience. Testimony provides support from

experts or people with firsthand experience. Facts and statistics can strengthen credibility when they are accurate, current, and clearly explained.

Ethical speakers use supporting material responsibly. They verify evidence, provide context, avoid exaggeration, cite sources, and do not misrepresent information. AI tools may help with brainstorming examples or simplifying explanations, but AI-generated material must be verified before being used as evidence.

Strong supporting material does not merely decorate a speech. It helps the audience understand, believe, and remember the message.

KEY TERMS

Supporting material

Evidence

Brief example

Extended example

Hypothetical example

Narrative

Testimony

Expert testimony

Lay testimony

Lived experience

Fact

Statistic

Correlation

Causation

Analogy

Oral citation

Source credibility

Cherry-picking

AI-generated material

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does a speech need supporting material?

2. What is the difference between a brief example, an extended example, and a hypothetical example?

3. When is a story useful in a speech, and when might it be insufficient?

4. What is the difference between expert testimony and lay testimony?

5. Why can statistics be both powerful and misleading?

6. How should speakers use AI-generated examples or explanations responsibly?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

SUPPORTING MATERIAL PRACTICE

Choose one of the following claims:

College students should treat sleep as part of academic success.

AI can help students prepare speeches, but it cannot replace original thinking.

Public speaking skills are useful in almost every career.

Social media affects how people understand current events.

Stories make speeches more memorable.

For your chosen claim, create or locate the following:

1. One brief example.

2. One possible extended example or story.

3. One piece of expert testimony you could research.

4. One statistic you could look for.

5. One analogy that could help explain the claim.

6. One question you would ask to make sure your supporting material is ethical and credible.

Example:

Claim: AI can help students prepare speeches, but it cannot replace original thinking.

Brief example: A student might use AI to generate practice questions before presenting.

Extended example: A student who uses AI to brainstorm topics still has to choose the topic, research sources, organize ideas, and deliver the speech in their own voice.

Expert testimony to research: A communication professor or academic integrity expert discussing AI use in education.

Statistic to look for: Data on how many students use AI tools for schoolwork.

Analogy: AI is like a rehearsal partner, not the performer.

Ethical question: Did I verify any factual claim the AI tool gave me?

Chapter 9

LOCATING SUPPORTING MATERIAL

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain the difference between primary and secondary research.
2. Identify common types of secondary sources.
3. Use books, newspapers, periodicals, academic journals, government publications, and reference works responsibly.
4. Understand the strengths and limitations of blogs, social news sites, and online commentary.
5. Evaluate sources using the CRAAP method.
6. Keep a working bibliography while researching.
7. Prepare source information for oral citation.

Finding the right supporting material requires research. Strong research helps you move beyond personal opinion and gives your speech substance, credibility, and depth. A speaker who uses strong research shows the audience that the topic has been taken seriously.

Research usually falls into two broad categories: primary research and secondary research.

Primary research is original, firsthand research you gather yourself. This may include interviews, surveys, observations, experiments, or personal experience.

Secondary research is information produced by others. This may include books, newspaper articles, academic journals, government reports, documentaries, podcasts, reference works, and credible websites.

Both types of research can be valuable. Primary research can give your speech originality and immediacy. Secondary research can provide background, expert analysis, data, and broader context. Many strong speeches use both.

FINDING SECONDARY SOURCES

Secondary sources include information created, collected, interpreted, or published by someone else. They can help you understand the history of a topic, locate statistics, find expert opinions, identify key debates, and develop supporting material.

Common secondary sources include:

Books

Newspapers

Magazines

Academic journals

Government publications

Professional organizations

Reference works

Reports and datasets

Documentaries

Podcasts

Credible websites

Blogs and social news sites, when used carefully

When gathering secondary research, do not simply collect information because it exists. Ask how each source might help your speech. Does it provide background? A statistic? A story? An expert quotation? A definition? A counterargument? A visual aid?

Good research is not about piling up sources. It is about choosing the right sources for the job.

BOOKS

Books allow you to explore a topic in depth. They are useful for history, theory, biography, storytelling, expert explanation, and broader context. A book may help you understand where an issue came from, how experts define it, and how different arguments have developed over time.

To find books, begin with your school library catalog. You can also use ebooks available through your library database. When using books, check the publication date. An older book may be excellent for historical context but less useful for fast-

changing topics such as artificial intelligence, public health, technology, social media, economics, or current law.

Books are especially useful when your topic requires depth rather than breaking news.

NEWSPAPERS AND NEWS ORGANIZATIONS

Newspapers and news organizations can provide timely information about current events, public issues, local developments, political debates, cultural events, and community concerns.

Credible news reporting can help you find:

Recent examples

Public reactions

Interviews

Timelines

Statistics

Expert commentary

Policy changes

Local relevance

When using news sources, consider the reputation of the publication, the date of publication, the author, the type of article, and whether the article is news,

analysis, opinion, or sponsored content. News articles and opinion columns are not the same thing. A news article should emphasize reporting and verification. An opinion column is designed to argue a viewpoint.

For historical newspaper research, library databases can be more reliable than random websites because they often preserve original publication information.

MAGAZINES AND PERIODICALS

A periodical is a publication released at regular intervals, such as a magazine, newsletter, journal, or trade publication. Periodicals can be useful because they often focus on current trends, public issues, professional debates, and specialized topics.

Magazines such as Time, The Atlantic, National Geographic, Scientific American, or Wired may provide accessible explanations for general audiences. Trade publications may provide information for specific industries, such as education, business, health care, technology, or entertainment.

Magazine articles are often easier for general audiences to understand than academic journal articles, but they may not provide the same level of research detail. Always check the author's qualifications, the publication's credibility, the date, and whether sources are cited.

ACADEMIC JOURNALS

Academic journals publish scholarly research written by experts, researchers, and professionals. Many academic journal articles are peer-reviewed, meaning they are evaluated by other experts before publication.

Academic journals are useful when you need:

Research findings

Expert analysis

Theoretical background

Original studies

Literature reviews

Data and methods

Scholarly debate

However, academic articles can be difficult to read because they often use specialized language. If your audience is not familiar with the field, you will need to translate the research into clear, accessible language.

Most colleges and universities provide access to academic databases through the library. These may include EBSCO, Academic Search Complete, JSTOR, ProQuest, ERIC, PubMed, or discipline-specific databases. Google Scholar can also help locate scholarly literature across many disciplines, including articles, theses, books, and abstracts. (Google Scholar)

Do not assume every result in a scholarly search is automatically perfect. Read carefully. Check the publication, author, date, methods, and relevance to your speech.

GOVERNMENT PUBLICATIONS

Government publications can provide strong evidence, especially for statistics, laws, public policy, health information, census data, education, labor, crime, transportation, environment, and economic information.

Examples of useful government sources include:

U.S. Census Bureau

Bureau of Labor Statistics

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention

National Institutes of Health

Department of Education

Environmental Protection Agency

Federal Trade Commission

USA.gov

USA.gov is the official U.S. government portal for locating federal information and services. (USAGov)

Government sources are often credible because they collect and publish official data. However, you still need to understand what the data measures, when it was collected, and how it should be interpreted. A government statistic can still be misunderstood or taken out of context.

PROFESSIONAL ORGANIZATIONS AND RESEARCH CENTERS

Professional organizations and research centers can be excellent sources because they often publish reports, position statements, statistics, guidelines, and expert analysis.

Examples include:

Pew Research Center

American Psychological Association

American Medical Association

National Communication Association

World Health Organization

United Nations

Brookings Institution

RAND Corporation

National Education Association

These sources can be helpful because they often specialize in a particular field. However, always check the organization's mission, funding, methods, and possible bias. A source can be knowledgeable and still have a point of view.

REFERENCE WORKS

Reference works provide quick background information, definitions, summaries, and factual overviews. They are useful at the beginning of the research process, especially when you are unfamiliar with a topic.

Reference works include:

Encyclopedias

Dictionaries

Almanacs

Biographies

Atlases

Quotation books

Poetry anthologies

Handbooks

Statistical abstracts

ENCYCLOPEDIAS

Encyclopedias provide summaries of topics and are useful for background information. They can help you understand basic terms, historical context, important people, major events, and related concepts. Encyclopedia Britannica is one example of a general encyclopedia.

Encyclopedias are a good starting point, but they should not usually be your strongest source. Use them to orient yourself, then move toward more specific sources.

ALMANACS

Almanacs contain facts, dates, statistics, rankings, and summaries. They are usually published annually. Almanacs can be useful when you need quick facts, historical dates, or general statistical information.

BIOGRAPHIES

Biographies tell the story of a person's life. They can be useful for speeches about leaders, artists, scientists, activists, performers, athletes, historical figures, or public figures. Current biographies may provide updated analysis, while older biographies may reflect the assumptions of their time.

QUOTATION BOOKS

Quotations can be useful in introductions and conclusions, but they must be accurate. Online quotes are often misattributed, shortened, rewritten, or taken out of context. Before using a quotation, verify who said it, where it came from, and what it originally meant.

A quote that sounds perfect but is fake will not make you look profound. It will make you look like you got jumped by Pinterest.

POETRY ANTHOLOGIES

Poetry can create emotional impact and may be useful in introductions, conclusions, ceremonial speeches, or speeches involving memory, identity, grief, love, justice, or hope. Use poetic excerpts carefully and credit the poet.

ATLASES

Atlases are collections of maps, charts, images, and geographical information. They can help with speeches about geography, population, migration, climate, history, politics, culture, or environmental issues. Some atlases focus on specialized subjects such as world history, human anatomy, art history, or climate.

BLOGS AND SOCIAL NEWS SITES

Blogs, newsletters, Reddit threads, social news sites, podcasts, and creator platforms can provide current perspectives and firsthand accounts. They may help you discover what people are saying about a topic right now.

However, these sources vary widely in credibility. Some blogs are written by experts and connected to reputable organizations. Others are personal opinion, advertising, speculation, or misinformation. Reddit and similar platforms may provide useful examples of public conversation, but they are not usually strong evidence by themselves.

Use these sources carefully. If a blog or social post introduces you to an interesting claim, trace that claim to stronger evidence. Look for expert sources, original documents, official data, or credible reporting.

Blogs and social platforms can be starting points. They should rarely be the finish line.

AI TOOLS AND RESEARCH

AI tools can help you brainstorm search terms, summarize difficult passages, generate questions, and identify possible directions for research. However, AI should not be treated as a source of truth.

AI tools can invent citations, misrepresent sources, leave out context, or produce confident answers that are wrong. If you use AI to help with research, verify everything through credible sources.

Acceptable uses of AI during research may include:

Generating search terms

Suggesting possible databases or source types

Explaining difficult vocabulary

Helping summarize an article you already found

Generating questions for an interview

Identifying possible counterarguments

Unacceptable uses include:

Using AI-generated citations without checking them

Citing AI as a factual source for claims it cannot verify

Presenting AI-generated summaries as if you read the original source

Using AI to fabricate interviews, testimony, stories, or statistics

AI can help you start research. It should not finish the research for you.

AWW CRAAP

When evaluating sources, consider the CRAAP method:

Currency

Relevance

Authority

Accuracy

Purpose

Yes, the name is ridiculous. That is why students remember it. Use it anyway.

CURRENCY

Currency asks whether the information is recent enough for your topic.

Some topics require current sources. If you are researching artificial intelligence, public health, social media, climate policy, employment trends, or current law, you should use recent information. Other topics, such as ancient history or classical rhetoric, may not require the newest source.

Ask:

When was this published or updated?

Is the information still accurate?

Has new research changed the conversation?

Does my topic require recent evidence?

RELEVANCE

Relevance asks whether the source fits your speech purpose, audience, and main point.

Ask:

Does this source directly support my speech?

Is it appropriate for my audience?

Is it too simple, too advanced, or just right?

Does it help answer my research question?

Would I be comfortable using this source in a college speech?

If the source is interesting but does not support your point, save it for later or leave it out.

AUTHORITY

Authority asks who created the information and why they should be trusted.

Ask:

Who is the author?

What are the author's qualifications?

What organization published it?

What is the source's reputation?

Is the author an expert, witness, journalist, researcher, or advocate?

Can I verify the author's background?

Authority depends on the topic. A surgeon may be an authority on surgery, but not necessarily on education policy. A student may not be an expert on college affordability, but they may offer useful firsthand testimony about their own experience.

ACCURACY

Accuracy asks whether the information is correct, supported, and verifiable.

Ask:

Does the source provide evidence?

Are there citations or links?

Can I verify the information elsewhere?

Do other credible sources agree?

Are there obvious errors?

Is the information presented in context?

Does the source distinguish fact from opinion?

Accurate sources do not hide the parts of the issue that complicate the argument. If a source only tells you what you want to hear, check it carefully.

PURPOSE

Purpose asks why the source exists.

Ask:

Is the source trying to inform, persuade, sell, entertain, provoke, recruit, or raise money?

Who benefits if I believe this?

Is the source sponsored?

Is there advertising or affiliate marketing?

Is the source transparent about its mission or funding?

A source with a purpose is not automatically bad. Every source has a purpose. The question is whether that purpose affects the reliability or fairness of the information.

RECORD REFERENCES AS YOU RESEARCH

Keep track of your sources as you research. Do not wait until the end. You will forget where information came from, and future-you will not be impressed with present-you's confidence.

Create a working bibliography. For each source, record:

Author

Title

Publication or website name

Publisher or organization

Date published or updated

URL or DOI, if available

Date accessed, for web sources

Page number, if using a book or PDF

A short note about how you might use the source

The exact quotation, statistic, or idea you may cite

A working bibliography helps you avoid plagiarism, prepare oral citations, and build your final works cited or reference page.

CITING FROM SOURCE TO SPEECH

Research is not complete until you can explain your sources clearly to the audience. In a written outline, you should include full citations in the required format, such as MLA, APA, or another style assigned by your instructor.

In an oral citation, you usually include only the information the audience needs to understand the source while listening.

A strong oral citation may include:

The author or organization

The source title or publication

The type of source

The date

The source's qualifications or credibility

RECORDING AND CITING BOOKS

When citing a book in your outline, record the author, title, publisher, year of publication, and page number if you are using a direct quotation or specific passage.

In a speech, an oral citation might sound like this:

In his book Mastery, published in 2012, author Robert Greene argues that mastery develops through disciplined practice rather than natural talent alone.

Notice that the oral citation gives the audience the author, title, date, and general idea without reading a full bibliography entry out loud.

CITING ACADEMIC JOURNALS

When citing an academic journal, record the author or authors, article title, journal title, and publication date.

In a speech, you do not need to read every detail. If an article has many authors, you can usually name the lead author and say “and colleagues” unless your instructor requires every author.

An oral citation might sound like this:

In a 2024 article published in the Journal of Communication, researcher Maya Chen and colleagues found that audiences were more likely to remember speeches that used clear examples alongside statistics.

The audience hears the date, publication, author, and claim. That is enough for oral delivery.

RESEARCH CHECKLIST

Before using a source, ask:

What type of source is this?

Who created it?

When was it published?

Is it relevant to my thesis?

Is the author or organization credible?

Does it provide evidence?

Can I verify the information elsewhere?

Is there a clear purpose or bias?

Can I explain this source clearly in my speech?

Have I recorded the citation information?

If you cannot answer these questions, the source is not ready.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Research helps speakers locate accurate, relevant, and credible supporting material. Primary research includes original work such as interviews, surveys, observations, and personal experience. Secondary research includes information produced by others, such as books, newspapers, academic journals, government publications, professional reports, reference works, blogs, and credible websites.

Different source types serve different purposes. Books provide depth. News sources provide current reporting. Academic journals provide scholarly research. Government publications provide official data. Reference works provide background. Blogs and social news sites may provide current perspectives but must be used carefully.

The CRAAP method helps speakers evaluate sources by considering currency, relevance, authority, accuracy, and purpose. Speakers should keep a working bibliography while researching and prepare oral citations that clearly identify source credibility without overwhelming the audience.

KEY TERMS

Primary research

Secondary research

Books

Newspapers

Periodicals

Academic journals

Peer review

Government publications

Professional organizations

Reference works

Encyclopedias

Almanacs

Biographies

Quotation books

Poetry anthologies

Atlases

Blogs

Social news sites

AI tools

CRAAP method

Currency

Relevance

Authority

Accuracy

Purpose

Working bibliography

Oral citation

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What is the difference between primary and secondary research?

2. Why are academic journals useful, and why can they be difficult for general audiences?

3. Why should speakers be careful with blogs, Reddit, and social media sources?

4. How can AI help with research without replacing the speaker's responsibility?

5. Which part of the CRAAP method do you think students are most likely to overlook?

6. Why should speakers record source information while researching instead of waiting until the end?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

SOURCE HUNT

Choose one speech topic and locate four possible sources:

1. One book or ebook.

2. One newspaper, magazine, or periodical article.

3. One academic journal article or scholarly source.

4. One government, professional organization, or research center source.

For each source, answer:

1. What type of source is it?

2. Who created it?

3. When was it published or updated?

4. What useful information does it provide?

5. Which part of your speech could it support?

6. How would you orally cite it?

CRAAP EVALUATION PRACTICE

Choose one online source related to your topic and evaluate it using the CRAAP method:

Currency: Is it current enough?

Relevance: Does it fit your topic and audience?

Authority: Who created it, and why should we trust them?

Accuracy: Is the information supported and verifiable?

Purpose: Why was this source created?

After answering these questions, decide whether you would use the source in your speech.

Chapter 10

INTERNET RESEARCH

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why internet research requires careful evaluation.
2. Describe the difference between misinformation, disinformation, and fake news.
3. Use lateral reading and the SIFT method to evaluate online sources.
4. Identify how algorithms, social media feeds, and commercial factors influence online information.
5. Explain why generative AI should not be treated as a source of truth.
6. Evaluate digital evidence such as screenshots, images, videos, and AI-generated media.
7. Record and orally cite web sources responsibly.

The key to productive internet research begins with a research strategy. The internet can help you find information quickly, but speed is not the same thing as accuracy. A search result, viral post, AI answer, or impressive-looking website can still be wrong, biased, outdated, incomplete, or completely made up.

In public speaking, your audience is trusting you to bring them accurate information. That means research is not just about finding something that supports your point. Research is about finding the best available evidence, understanding where that evidence came from, and explaining it clearly and ethically to your audience.

USE THE LIBRARY FIRST

Relying only on the open internet may be convenient, but it can also lead you into biased, misleading, outdated, or false information. Search engines and social media platforms are not neutral libraries. They are companies. They sort information based on algorithms, advertising, popularity, search habits, location, and profit. The first result is not always the best result. Sometimes it is just the best-optimized result.

For this reason, begin with your school library database whenever possible. Library databases contain sources that have been reviewed, edited, indexed, or selected by professionals. Think of them as organized file cabinets full of credible information. Academic journals, newspapers, magazines, government reports, ebooks, and reference materials are often available through your school library.

Anything you find through your school library database is usually acceptable in my course, but you still need to evaluate it. A peer-reviewed article from 2003 may be useful for historical background, but it may not be current enough for a speech on artificial intelligence, public health, social media, climate change, or present-day politics.

Use the internet, but do not let the internet use you.

BE CRITICAL OF THE INFORMATION YOU CONSUME

How do you know the difference between credible information and untrustworthy information online?

You investigate it.

Search engines cannot fully judge the quality of research. Social media platforms cannot tell you whether a claim is true. AI tools can generate confident an-

swers that sound polished but may contain errors. Only a thoughtful human researcher can evaluate whether a source is credible enough to use in a speech.

Before you use a source, ask:

Who created this?

What evidence do they provide?

When was it published or updated?

Where did the information originally come from?

Why was it created?

What might be missing?

Would I be comfortable citing this in front of my class?

If the answer is no, keep looking.

MISINFORMATION, DISINFORMATION, AND FAKE NEWS

Fake news is content that is made to look like real journalistic content, but it is not. The term fake news is often thrown around casually, especially when people dislike a story or disagree with a source. But for research purposes, we need to be more precise.

Misinformation is false or inaccurate information that may be shared by mistake.

Disinformation is false information created or spread on purpose to mislead people.

Fake news is content designed to look like real journalism even though it is false, misleading, fabricated, or heavily distorted.

A fake news story may imitate the layout of a real news site. It may use dramatic headlines, emotional images, urgent language, or fake quotes. The goal is often to get people to click, share, panic, donate, buy, or take sides before they stop and think.

For example, during fast-moving events such as natural disasters, elections, wars, protests, celebrity deaths, school incidents, or public health scares, false stories often spread before accurate information catches up. A dramatic image may be taken from an older event. A quote may be invented. A video may be edited to remove context. A random person online may claim to be an expert. By the time the truth arrives, the false version may already have been shared thousands or millions of times.

That is the danger. False information does not have to be sophisticated to be persuasive. It only has to be emotional enough for people to share it before checking it.

When citing a source, your job is not to repeat what went viral. Your job is to verify what is true.

READ BEYOND THE HEADLINE

Headlines are designed to get attention. Sometimes they summarize the story accurately. Sometimes they exaggerate. Sometimes they leave out the most important context.

Do not cite a source based on the headline alone. Read the whole article. Look for the evidence. Ask whether the headline actually matches the body of the story.

A headline might say:

“New Study Proves Social Media Causes Depression”

But the article may reveal something more cautious:

A small study found a possible relationship between heavy social media use and self-reported sadness among one age group.

Those are not the same claim. One is a dramatic conclusion. The other is a limited finding.

As a speaker, do not turn careful research into clickbait.

CONSIDER WHO IS DELIVERING THE MESSAGE

The source of the message matters. A report from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention is different from a random wellness blog. An article from The Associated Press is different from an anonymous meme account. A peer-reviewed journal article is different from someone's comment under a YouTube video.

This does not mean that major institutions are always perfect or that small sources are always wrong. It means you should know what kind of source you are using.

Ask:

Is this a newspaper, academic journal, government agency, advocacy group, company, blog, podcast, social media account, or AI-generated summary?

Who owns or funds the source?

Does the source have editors or fact-checkers?

Is the author named?

What are the author's qualifications?

What is the source's reputation?

Does the source correct errors?

If you have never heard of the source, do not immediately reject it. Investigate it. Sometimes unfamiliar sources are excellent. Sometimes they are digital raccoons wearing a journalist costume.

CHECK THE "ABOUT US" SECTION, BUT DO NOT STOP THERE

Most websites have an "About Us" section that explains the organization, leadership, mission, funding, or purpose. Read it. It can help you understand the source's perspective.

But be careful: websites describe themselves in flattering ways. A site can call itself independent, balanced, research-based, or nonpartisan without actually living up to those claims.

Do not only read what the source says about itself. Open a new tab and search what other credible sources say about that organization. This is called lateral reading.

Vertical reading means staying on the same page and studying the website itself.

Lateral reading means leaving the website to investigate the source from the outside.

Good researchers read laterally. They do not let one source control the whole room.

USE THE SIFT METHOD

One useful strategy for evaluating online information is the SIFT method.

STOP.

Before you share, cite, or believe the source, pause. Ask what you are looking at and whether you know enough to trust it.

INVESTIGATE THE SOURCE.

Find out who created the information. Look up the author, organization, publisher, funder, or platform.

FIND BETTER COVERAGE.

Check whether more reliable sources have covered the same claim. Look for reporting from established news organizations, academic sources, government agencies, professional associations, or primary documents.

TRACE CLAIMS BACK TO THE ORIGINAL SOURCE.

Do not rely on someone else's summary if you can find the original report, study, speech, transcript, law, dataset, or interview.

SIFT is useful because it slows down the reaction cycle. The internet wants you to react. Research asks you to investigate.

WHAT'S THE SUPPORT?

When reading a news story, article, report, or post, pay close attention to the support. Does the writer cite sources? Are there links? Do the links work? Do the links actually support the claim being made?

Do not assume that a link equals evidence. Sometimes articles link to sources that do not say what the article claims. Sometimes they link to another article that links to another article that links to another article, and nobody ever reaches the original source. That is not research. That is a digital conga line.

Follow the evidence back to its origin.

For speeches, strong support may include:

Academic research

Government reports

Professional organizations

Credible journalism

Books by qualified authors

Interviews with experts

Original surveys or interviews

Primary documents

Reliable statistics

Firsthand testimony

Weak support may include:

Anonymous posts

Unsourced memes

Comment sections

Random blogs

Unverified screenshots

AI-generated summaries without sources

Sponsored content pretending to be neutral

Old statistics presented as current

Anecdotes presented as proof

IS THIS A JOKE?

Satirical websites and comedy accounts often imitate real news. That is the point. The problem is that people sometimes share satire as if it were factual.

Many satirical stories work because they feel emotionally true to the audience. A person may read a ridiculous headline and think, “That sounds exactly like something those people would do.” That emotional reaction can blind them to the fact that the story is a joke.

Before using a strange or outrageous claim, check whether the site identifies itself as satire. Look at the “About” page. Search the headline elsewhere. See whether fact-checking organizations have addressed it.

If a story seems too perfect, too outrageous, or too perfectly aligned with your anger, slow down.

CHECK YOUR BIASES

People are drawn to information that reinforces what they already believe. This is called confirmation bias. It feels good to find a source that says, “You were right all along.” Unfortunately, feeling right is not the same thing as being right.

Fake news and misleading content are often designed to trigger emotion. Anger, fear, disgust, pride, and moral outrage are powerful. They make people click and share.

Before using a source, ask:

Do I believe this because the evidence is strong?

Or do I believe it because I want it to be true?

Would I trust this same source if it argued against my position?

Have I looked for credible sources that challenge my view?

Research should make you smarter, not just louder.

ALGORITHMIC FEEDS ARE NOT RESEARCH

Many students get information from TikTok, Instagram, YouTube, Reddit, podcasts, X, Facebook, Discord, or other platforms. These platforms can introduce you to interesting topics, but they should not be your final source.

Social media feeds are shaped by algorithms. The platform learns what keeps you watching and gives you more of it. That does not mean the information is accurate. It means the information is engaging.

A video with millions of views may still be wrong. A confident speaker may still be unqualified. A creator with great lighting and dramatic music may still be giving you garbage in HD.

Use social media as a starting point, not as your evidence.

If you discover a topic through a short video, trace the claim:

Who is speaking?

What is their expertise?

What source are they using?

Can you find the original study, report, speech, or document?

Have credible sources confirmed the claim?

Is there missing context?

Do not cite "I saw a TikTok" as evidence. Cite the credible source you found after investigating the TikTok.

AI Can Help, But AI Is Not a Source of Truth

Generative AI tools can be useful during the speech preparation process. You can use AI to brainstorm topics, simplify complex language, generate practice questions, identify opposing arguments, or help organize your ideas.

For example, you might ask an AI tool:

Help me narrow this topic for a five-minute informative speech.

Give me possible counterarguments to this persuasive claim.

Ask me five challenging audience questions about my speech.

Help me turn this thesis into three main points.

Explain this concept in simpler language for a college audience.

Used this way, AI can be a helpful speech coach.

But AI can also be wrong. AI tools can invent facts, misrepresent sources, generate fake citations, flatten your personal voice, and produce language that sounds polished but says very little. Do not let AI become the student and you become the printer.

In this class, you are responsible for every word you say. If AI gives you false information and you repeat it in your speech, that is still your mistake.

Do not cite AI as a factual authority unless your assignment specifically asks you to analyze AI-generated content. Instead, use AI to help you think, then verify the information through credible sources.

AI AND SOURCE VERIFICATION

AI-generated search summaries can be convenient, but they can also create problems. They may summarize sources incorrectly. They may blend multiple sources together. They may omit important context. They may cite sources that are weak, outdated, or unrelated.

When using AI during research:

Do not trust an answer just because it sounds confident.

Ask for sources, but verify each source yourself.

Open the original source.

Check the date.

Check the author.

Check whether the source actually says what the AI claims it says.

Look for stronger sources through the library database.

Never use a citation you have not personally checked.

A fake citation is worse than no citation because it makes your speech look credible while hiding a weak foundation. That is intellectual drywall over termites.

DEEPFAKES AND SYNTHETIC MEDIA

Modern technology can create fake images, fake audio, fake videos, fake screenshots, and fake social media posts. These are sometimes called synthetic media. A deepfake is a manipulated or AI-generated video or audio clip that makes someone appear to say or do something they did not actually say or do.

This creates a serious challenge for public speakers. Images and videos feel persuasive because audiences often believe what they can see. But visual evidence can be edited, staged, taken out of context, or generated from scratch.

Before using an image, video, or audio clip as evidence, ask:

Where did this originally come from?

Who posted it first?

Is there a date and location?

Have credible news outlets verified it?

Is the image from the event being discussed, or is it old footage?

Could it be satire, parody, or AI-generated?

Can I find the same event from another angle or source?

Do not build your argument on a screenshot unless you can verify it. Screenshots are easy to fake. So are quotes placed over someone's photo.

RESPECT SOURCE AUTHORITY

Does your source have authority?

If you are speaking about the NBA, the official NBA website may be useful for schedules, rules, statistics, and organizational information. If you are speaking about federal law or government services, government websites such as USA.gov or official agency websites are often strong sources. If you are speaking about health, look for medical journals, hospitals, universities, or public health agencies.

If you are speaking about a company, the company's own website may be useful for its official position, but not necessarily for neutral evaluation.

Authority depends on the topic.

A celebrity may be an authority on their own career, but not on vaccine safety.

A company may be an authority on its product features, but not on whether its product is good for society.

A professor may be an authority in one field, but not every field.

A person with lived experience may provide valuable testimony, but personal experience alone does not prove a general trend.

Use the right authority for the claim you are making.

HOW TO EVALUATE AUTHORSHIP

The domain is the suffix at the end of a web address. It can give you a clue about the type of site:

.edu usually indicates an educational institution.

.gov usually indicates a government source.

.mil indicates a military source.

.org often indicates a nonprofit organization.

.com usually indicates a commercial or business site.

But domains are only clues. They are not guarantees.

A .org site can still be biased.

A .com site can still publish excellent journalism.

A .edu page may be a student project, an old handout, or an outdated page that no one has touched since the era of low-rise jeans.

A government source may be credible for official data, but you still need to understand the purpose and context of that data.

Investigate the author, publisher, date, purpose, and evidence.

BE CAREFUL OF COMMERCIAL FACTORS

When researching outside your school's official library portal, be alert for commercial influence. Advertisers may have paid for placement. Companies may sponsor articles, reports, videos, podcasts, influencers, or search results.

Sponsored content is not automatically false, but it is created with a purpose. A skincare company funding an article about skincare trends has a financial interest. A fitness company publishing a report about exercise habits has a financial interest. A political organization publishing a voter guide has a persuasive interest.

Ask:

Who paid for this?

Who benefits if I believe this?

Is this information trying to inform me, persuade me, sell to me, or collect data from me?

Search engines often label paid results as sponsored, but not all commercial influence is obvious. Influencer sponsorships, affiliate links, branded content, and promoted posts can blur the line between information and advertising.

CITING FROM SOURCE TO SPEECH

When you use information from a source, you must give credit. In a written paper, you cite sources in a formal citation style such as MLA, APA, or Chicago. In a speech, you cite sources orally so the audience can understand where the information came from while listening.

A strong oral citation usually includes:

The name of the source

The type of source

The date

The author or organization, when relevant

The author's qualifications, when helpful

For example:

According to a 2025 report from the Pew Research Center, a nonpartisan research organization that studies public attitudes and social trends…

According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, in data updated in May 2026…

In a March 2026 article for The Associated Press, technology reporter Matt O'Brien explained…

According to NobelPrize.org, the official website of the Nobel Prize, Nobel laureate Malala Yousafzai said in her Nobel lecture…

Do not overload your audience with a full MLA citation out loud. Nobody wants to hear you recite a URL like you are summoning a demon. Give the audience enough information to trust the source.

RECORDING AND CITING WEB SOURCES

When using a web source, record the following:

Author or organization

Title of the article, page, report, video, or post

Name of the website or publisher

Date published or last updated

Date you accessed it

URL

A short note explaining how you used it

A copy of the exact quotation, statistic, or claim you plan to cite

Internet sources change. Pages are edited, moved, deleted, or updated. Save your sources as you go. Do not wait until midnight before the speech and then try to reconstruct your research like a detective in a bad crime show.

Use a working bibliography. Copy and paste source information into a separate document. Save links. Take screenshots of key information when appropriate. Keep track of which information came from which source.

CITING AI USE

If you use AI to generate words, images, examples, summaries, or ideas that appear directly in your speech or outline, follow your instructor's policy for disclosure and citation.

At minimum, be transparent about meaningful AI assistance. There is a difference between using AI to brainstorm possible topics and using AI to write half your speech. There is also a difference between using grammar assistance and presenting AI-generated ideas as if they were entirely your own.

A basic AI disclosure might look like this:

I used ChatGPT to brainstorm possible topic ideas and generate practice questions. The final topic, research, outline, and speech content are my own.

Or:

I used an AI image generator to create the visual aid on this slide. The image is used as an illustration, not as factual evidence.

Do not use AI-generated citations unless you have verified every source yourself.

FINAL SOURCE CHECKLIST

Before using a source in your speech, ask:

Is the source credible?

Is the author qualified?

Is the information current enough for my topic?

Is the evidence clear?

Can I trace the claim back to an original source?

Have other credible sources confirmed it?

Does the source have a financial, political, or persuasive purpose?

Am I using the source fairly and accurately?

Can I explain this source out loud to my audience?

Would I be comfortable if my instructor asked me where this information came from?

If you cannot answer those questions, the source is not ready for your speech.

Good research is not about finding the first source that agrees with you. Good research is about earning the audience's trust. Your audience does not need you to be perfect, but they do need you to be honest, careful, and prepared.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Internet research can help speakers locate information quickly, but speed does not guarantee accuracy. Search results, viral posts, social media content, AI-generated answers, and professional-looking websites can still be misleading, biased, outdated, incomplete, or false.

Strong researchers begin with credible sources, including school library databases, academic research, government reports, professional organizations, and rep-

utable journalism. Internet sources should be evaluated carefully by considering the creator, evidence, date, purpose, support, and possible bias.

Misinformation, disinformation, fake news, satire, algorithmic feeds, deepfakes, sponsored content, and AI-generated summaries can all distort what audiences believe. Speakers should use lateral reading, the SIFT method, source verification, and careful citation practices to avoid spreading false or unsupported claims.

Generative AI can help with brainstorming, organization, practice questions, and simplification, but it is not a source of truth. Speakers are responsible for verifying any information they use and for disclosing meaningful AI assistance when required.

KEY TERMS

Internet research

Search engine

Library database

Misinformation

Disinformation

Fake news

Satire

Confirmation bias

Lateral reading

Vertical reading

SIFT method

Algorithmic feed

Sponsored content

Source authority

Authorship

Domain

Generative AI

AI-generated summary

AI disclosure

Deepfake

Synthetic media

Oral citation

Working bibliography

Source verification

Commercial influence

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is the first search result not always the best source?

2. What is the difference between misinformation, disinformation, and fake news?

3. Why is lateral reading useful when evaluating an unfamiliar website?

4. How can social media algorithms shape what people believe?

5. What are appropriate and inappropriate ways to use AI during research?

6. Why are screenshots, images, videos, and short clips not always reliable evidence?

7. How can a speaker orally cite a web source without overwhelming the audience?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

ONLINE SOURCE EVALUATION

Choose one online source related to a possible speech topic. This can be a news article, website, blog post, report, video, or social media claim.

Answer the following questions:

1. Who created the source?

2. What type of source is it?

3. When was it published or updated?

4. What evidence does it provide?

5. Does it link to original sources or supporting evidence?

6. What is the purpose of the source?

7. Is there any commercial, political, or persuasive interest?

8. Can you find other credible sources that confirm the same claim?

9. Would you use this source in a speech? Why or why not?

10. How would you orally cite this source?

SIFT PRACTICE

Choose one claim you found online and apply the SIFT method:

Stop: What is your first reaction to the claim?

Investigate the source: Who created it, and what do other sources say about them?

Find better coverage: Can you find a stronger source covering the same claim?

Trace claims: Can you locate the original report, study, transcript, video, or data?

AI VERIFICATION PRACTICE

Ask an AI tool for three sources related to a speech topic. Then verify each source.

For each source, answer:

1. Does the source actually exist?
2. Does the author exist?
3. Does the source say what the AI claims it says?
4. Is the source credible enough for a speech?
5. What did this activity teach you about using AI for research?

Chapter 11

CITING SOURCES IN YOUR SPEECH

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why oral citations are important in public speaking.

2. Identify when information needs to be cited.

3. Distinguish between common knowledge and information that requires source credit.

4. Create clear oral citations for books, articles, websites, videos, interviews, testimony, and statistics.

5. Explain why source credibility should be established for the audience.

6. Cite AI use transparently when required by the assignment.

7. Integrate citations naturally into a speech without interrupting delivery.

Acknowledging where you obtained your material is essential when delivering a speech. Public speakers use other people's ideas, research, statistics, stories, images, and testimony to support their claims. When that material is not your own, you must give credit.

Citing sources is not only an academic requirement. It is an ethical responsibility. Your audience has a right to know where your information came from and why it should be trusted.

A citation in a written paper may appear in MLA, APA, or Chicago style. A citation in a speech works differently. Because the audience is listening in real time, an oral citation must be brief, clear, and easy to understand. You do not need to read a full bibliography entry out loud. You do need to give the audience enough information to evaluate the source.

WHY CITE SOURCES?

Oral citations help speakers build credibility. When you identify your sources, you show that your claims are supported by research rather than guesswork. You also help the audience distinguish between your own ideas and information that comes from another person or organization.

Citing sources also helps prevent plagiarism. Plagiarism occurs when a speaker presents another person's words, ideas, research, or creative work as their own. Whether plagiarism is intentional or accidental, it damages trust.

A speaker who cites sources clearly communicates three important things:

I did the research.

I know where this information came from.

I respect the audience enough to be transparent.

A speech without citations may still sound confident, but confidence is not evidence.

WHEN DO YOU NEED TO CITE?

You should cite a source when you use information, language, or creative material that is not your own.

Cite sources when you use:

Direct quotations

Paraphrased ideas

Summaries of someone else's research

Statistics

Facts that are not common knowledge

Expert testimony

Lay testimony

Images, charts, graphs, or videos

Audio clips

Social media posts

Interviews

AI-generated text, images, or examples when required by the assignment

Information from websites, articles, books, podcasts, documentaries, or reports

You do not need to cite common knowledge.

Common knowledge includes information that most educated people would know or that can be found easily in many general sources. For example, you do not need to cite the claim that the Earth revolves around the sun or that Sacramento is the capital of California.

However, be careful. Some information may seem familiar but still requires a source. For example, “many students experience anxiety” may be a general observation. But if you say “72 percent of college students report anxiety,” you need to cite where that number came from.

When in doubt, cite it. A citation rarely hurts your speech. A missing citation can.

SIGNAL YOUR AUDIENCE

An oral citation should signal to the audience that the information comes from a source. A strong oral citation usually includes some combination of the following:

The author or organization

The type of source

The title or description of the source

The date of publication or update

The source’s qualifications or credibility

The information being used

For example:

According to a 2025 report from the Pew Research Center, a nonpartisan organization that studies public attitudes and social trends…

In her 2023 book on communication and leadership, professor Angela Nguyen argues…

According to data updated in 2026 by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention…

In a March 2026 article for The Associated Press, technology reporter Matt O'Brien explained…

These citations give the audience enough information to understand who produced the information, when it was produced, and why it may be credible.

WHY SHOULD WE TRUST THE SOURCE?

New speakers often name sources without explaining why the audience should trust them. "According to a website…" does not tell the audience much. Which website? Who runs it? Why should we believe it?

Source credibility refers to the audience's level of trust in a source's accuracy, expertise, and reliability. If you make a scientific claim and cite a teenager's personal blog, most listeners will not find that persuasive. If you make the same claim

and cite a peer-reviewed medical journal, a public health agency, or a qualified expert, your credibility improves.

To establish source credibility, briefly mention qualifications when they matter.

Weak citation:

I found an article that says sleep affects memory.

Stronger citation:

According to a 2024 article published in the journal Sleep Medicine Reviews, researchers found that sleep plays an important role in memory and learning.

The stronger version gives the audience a reason to take the claim seriously.

Reliable sources can still be wrong, incomplete, or challenged by newer evidence. For controversial claims, use more than one source when possible. If credible sources disagree, acknowledge that disagreement. Audiences trust speakers who are honest about complexity.

TRY NOT TO SOUND LIKE A ROBOT

Citing sources in a speech may feel awkward at first, but it does not have to interrupt the flow of your delivery. The key is to make citations sound like part of the speech, not like a bibliography escaped from your outline and started yelling.

Avoid using the same phrase every time. If every citation begins with "According to," the speech can sound repetitive.

Instead, vary your source introductions:

According to…

As reported by…

In a study published by…

Data from…

Research from…

In an interview with…

Writing for…

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reports…

Communication scholar Julia Wood explains…

A 2026 report from the Department of Education found…

The goal is to sound natural while still giving credit.

CITING BOOKS

When citing a book in a speech, mention the author, title, and publication date. If the author's qualifications matter, briefly include them.

Example:

In her book Quiet, published in 2012, author Susan Cain argues that introverts often bring important strengths to leadership, creativity, and communication.

Example:

In his book Mastery, published in 2012, author Robert Greene argues that skill develops through long-term practice, discipline, and focused learning.

Things to mention:

Author's first and last name

Title of the book

Date of publication

Author's qualifications, when useful

CITING PRINT OR ONLINE ARTICLES

When citing an article, mention the author if available, the publication, the type of source, and the date.

Example:

In a 2026 article published by The New York Times, education reporter Dana Goldstein explained how schools are adjusting classroom policies in response to generative AI.

Example:

Writing for The Atlantic in 2025, journalist Derek Thompson described how changes in work culture have affected communication habits among younger employees.

Things to mention:

Author, when available

Publication name

Date of publication

Type of publication, when useful

Source credibility, when needed

CITING ACADEMIC JOURNALS

Academic journals often carry strong credibility because they publish scholarly research. Some are peer-reviewed, meaning experts evaluate the research before publication.

When citing an academic journal orally, do not bury the audience in details. Name the author or lead author, the journal, the date, and the key finding.

Example:

In a 2024 study published in the Journal of Communication, researcher Maya Chen and colleagues found that audiences were more likely to remember speeches that combined clear examples with statistics.

If an article has many authors, you do not need to name every author out loud unless your instructor requires it. You can name the lead author and say “and colleagues.”

Things to mention:

Lead author or authors

Journal title

Date of publication

Key finding

Researcher qualifications, when relevant

CITING WEBSITES

When citing a website, name the website or organization, explain what kind of source it is, and provide the date published, updated, or accessed if needed.

Example:

According to the Mayo Clinic website, a nonprofit medical center that provides patient care and health research, information updated in 2026 explains…

Example:

USA.gov, the official website for U.S. government information and services, explains…

Things to mention:

Website or organization name

Source qualifier

Date published, updated, or accessed

Specific information being used

Avoid saying only “According to Google.” Google is usually a search engine, not the source. Cite the source Google helped you find.

CITING BLOGS, PODCASTS, AND SOCIAL MEDIA

Blogs, podcasts, newsletters, and social media can be useful, but they vary widely in credibility. Some are produced by experts or reputable organizations. Others are personal opinion, advertising, or unsupported commentary.

When citing these sources, identify the creator, platform, date, and reason the source is credible or relevant.

Example:

In a 2025 episode of the podcast Hidden Brain, host Shankar Vedantam interviewed psychologist Ethan Kross about how people manage internal self-talk.

Example:

In a 2026 blog post for the American Psychological Association, clinical psychologist Dr. Elena Ramirez explained…

Example:

In a public Instagram post from March 2026, the National Park Service warned visitors about heat safety in desert parks.

Things to mention:

Creator or organization

Platform or publication

Date

Why the source is credible or relevant

Whether the source is firsthand, expert, or commentary

Do not cite a random TikTok, Reddit comment, or meme as evidence unless the speech is specifically analyzing that content as an example. If the post makes a factual claim, trace that claim to a stronger source.

CITING TELEVISION, RADIO, AND ONLINE VIDEO

When citing television, radio, or online video, mention the program, speaker or reporter, organization or platform, and date.

Example:

In a 2026 PBS NewsHour segment, correspondent Amna Nawaz reported…

Example:

In his TED Talk on education and creativity, recorded at a TED conference in 2006, author and educator Sir Ken Robinson argued…

Example:

In a 2025 video published by NASA, agency scientists explained…

Things to mention:

Program or video title

Speaker, reporter, or organization

Platform or publisher

Date aired or published

Source credibility, when useful

CITING TESTIMONY

Testimony may come from experts, witnesses, or people with lived experience. When citing testimony, identify the person, their qualifications or connection to the topic, the context, and the date when possible.

Example:

In congressional testimony delivered in 2024, Federal Trade Commission Chair Lina Khan discussed concerns about consumer data privacy.

Example:

In an interview I conducted on May 2, 2026, Long Beach City College student Maria Torres described how speech anxiety affected her first classroom presentation.

Things to mention:

Name of the person

Qualifications or connection to the topic

Context of the testimony

Date

CITING INTERVIEWS YOU CONDUCT

If you interview someone yourself, tell the audience when the interview happened and why the person's perspective matters.

Example:

In an interview I conducted last week, Professor Anthony James, a microbiologist at UC Irvine, explained…

Example:

On May 5, 2026, I interviewed my grandmother about her experience moving to California in the 1970s. She described…

Things to mention:

Name of the person

Date of interview

Why the person is relevant

Whether the information is expert testimony or personal experience

CITING FACTS AND STATISTICS

Facts and statistics often need clear citations because they can strongly influence how an audience understands an issue.

Example:

According to 2026 data from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, a federal agency that tracks employment and economic trends…

Example:

The National Center for Health Statistics, which provides official health data for the United States, reported in 2025 that…

When citing statistics, do not just throw numbers at the audience. Explain what the number means.

Weak version:

The rate increased by 14 percent.

Stronger version:

According to the report, the rate increased by 14 percent, meaning the problem is growing rather than remaining stable.

Statistics are powerful, but they can also be misleading when taken out of context. Mention the source, date, and scope of the data when relevant.

USING CONDITIONAL LANGUAGE

Data changes. Research develops. New evidence appears. For that reason, avoid overstating what a source proves.

Instead of saying:

This proves that social media causes depression.

Say:

This study suggests a relationship between heavy social media use and reported symptoms of depression.

Useful phrases include:

The data suggest…

The research indicates…

The study found…

The report estimates…

The evidence points to…

Researchers concluded…

This source argues…

Conditional language helps you stay accurate and ethical.

CITING AI USE

Generative AI tools create a new citation challenge. AI can help brainstorm, summarize, organize, revise, generate images, or create practice questions. However, AI can also produce inaccurate information, fake citations, and generic language.

Follow your instructor's policy on AI disclosure. If AI meaningfully contributed to your speech, outline, visual aid, or research process, be transparent.

A basic AI disclosure might sound like this:

I used ChatGPT to brainstorm possible topic ideas and generate practice questions. The final topic, research, outline, and speech content are my own.

Another example:

I used an AI image generator to create the illustration on this slide. The image is used as a visual aid, not as factual evidence.

Do not cite AI as a factual authority unless your assignment specifically asks you to analyze AI-generated content. If AI gives you a fact, statistic, quotation, or source, verify it through a credible source before using it.

AI may help you find a direction. It does not replace your responsibility as the speaker.

CITING IMAGES, CHARTS, AND VISUAL AIDS

If you use an image, chart, graph, video clip, or audio clip that you did not create, give credit. This can be done on the slide, in your oral presentation, or in the bibliography for your outline, depending on the assignment.

Example oral citation:

This chart comes from a 2026 report by the Pew Research Center, a nonpartisan research organization that studies public attitudes and social trends.

Example slide credit:

Source: Pew Research Center, 2026

If the visual is central to your argument, cite it out loud. If it is decorative, ask whether you need it at all. Visual aids should support the speech, not just decorate it like academic wallpaper.

ORAL CITATION EXAMPLES

Book:

In her book Quiet, published in 2012, Susan Cain argues that introverts often bring important strengths to leadership and communication.

Academic Journal:

In a 2024 study published in the Journal of Communication, researcher Maya Chen and colleagues found that clear examples helped audiences remember complex information.

Website:

According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, a federal public health agency, data updated in 2026 shows…

News Article:

In a March 2026 article for The Associated Press, technology reporter Matt O'Brien explained…

Podcast:

In a 2025 episode of Hidden Brain, host Shankar Vedantam interviewed psychologist Ethan Kross about how people manage self-talk.

Interview:

In an interview I conducted on May 2, 2026, student Maria Torres explained how speech anxiety affected her first classroom presentation.

Statistic:

According to 2026 data from the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, a federal agency that tracks employment trends…

AI Disclosure:

I used ChatGPT to generate practice audience questions while preparing this speech. I verified my research through library and government sources, and the final speech content is my own.

COMMON CITATION MISTAKES

Avoid these common mistakes:

Saying “According to Google” instead of naming the actual source.

Using a statistic without a date.

Naming a source but not explaining why it is credible.

Using a quotation without identifying the speaker or author.

Citing a website with no author, date, or organization.

Using a source because it agrees with you, not because it is credible.

Reading a full MLA or APA citation out loud.

Using AI-generated citations without checking whether the sources exist.

Forgetting to cite images, charts, or videos.

Saving citation information after the speech is already written.

Citations should help your audience trust you. They should not confuse, bore, or overwhelm them.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Citing sources is an essential part of ethical public speaking. Oral citations help audiences understand where information came from and why it should be trusted. Speakers should cite direct quotations, paraphrases, summaries, statistics, facts that are not common knowledge, testimony, images, charts, videos, interviews, and meaningful AI assistance when required.

A strong oral citation usually includes the source, author or organization, type of source, date, and source credibility when useful. Oral citations should be clear and natural, not full bibliography entries read out loud.

Speakers should establish source credibility by explaining why a source is reliable or relevant. They should also use conditional language when discussing research or data to avoid overstating claims.

Generative AI should be disclosed when it meaningfully contributes to a speech, outline, visual aid, or preparation process according to instructor policy. AI should not be treated as a factual authority unless the assignment specifically re-

quires analysis of AI-generated content. Speakers remain responsible for verifying all information they present.

KEY TERMS

Oral citation

Written citation

Common knowledge

Plagiarism

Source credibility

Source qualifier

Direct quotation

Paraphrase

Summary

Testimony

Expert testimony

Lay testimony

Interview

Statistic

Conditional language

AI disclosure

Visual aid citation

Bibliography

Works cited

Reference list

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why are oral citations important in public speaking?

2. What is the difference between common knowledge and information that needs to be cited?

3. Why is “According to Google” not a strong oral citation?

4. How can a speaker explain source credibility without making the citation too long?

5. Why should speakers use conditional language when discussing research findings?

6. What kinds of AI use should be disclosed in a speech or outline?

7. How can citations sound natural rather than robotic?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

ORAL CITATION PRACTICE

Rewrite each weak citation as a stronger oral citation.

1. “I found online that students are stressed.”

2. “Google says public speaking is a common fear.”

3. “A website said sleep helps memory.”

4. “Someone on TikTok said AI makes fake sources.”

5. “This chart shows unemployment rates.”

For each revised citation, include:

The source or organization

The type of source

The date, if available

A source qualifier explaining why the audience should trust it

SOURCE CREDIBILITY PRACTICE

Choose one source you plan to use in a speech. Answer the following questions:

1. Who created the source?

2. What type of source is it?

3. When was it published or updated?

4. Why should the audience trust it?

5. What part of your speech will it support?

6. How would you cite it out loud?

AI DISCLOSURE PRACTICE

Write a short AI disclosure for one of the following situations:

1. You used AI to brainstorm possible speech topics.

2. You used AI to generate practice audience questions.

3. You used AI to create an image for a slide.

4. You used AI to summarize an article, then verified the article yourself.

Example:

I used ChatGPT to generate practice audience questions while preparing this speech. I verified my research through library and government sources, and the final speech content is my own.

Chapter 12

ORGANIZATION

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Identify the three major parts of a speech: introduction, body, and conclusion.
2. Explain how main points support a thesis statement.
3. Develop clear main points and supporting points.
4. Use coordination, subordination, and indentation in a speech outline.
5. Apply the principles of unity, coherence, and balance.
6. Use transitions, previews, and reviews to help audiences follow a speech.
7. Organize the body of a speech in a way that is clear, logical, and audience-centered.

A speech has three major parts: an introduction, a body, and a conclusion.

The introduction captures the audience's attention, introduces the topic, establishes the speaker's credibility, and previews the main points. The body develops the speech's main ideas through supporting material. The conclusion reviews the main points, reinforces the central idea, and gives the speech a sense of closure.

A simple way to remember this structure is:

Tell the audience where you are going.

Take them there.

Remind them where they have been and why it matters.

This chapter focuses on the body of the speech. The body is where your main points, supporting material, and transitions work together to develop your thesis. If the introduction opens the door and the conclusion closes it, the body is the house. If the house has no structure, the audience ends up wandering around looking for the bathroom.

MAIN POINTS

Main points are the most important ideas in your speech. They support the thesis statement and help fulfill the speech purpose. In an informative speech, main points often explain the major parts, steps, types, causes, effects, or examples of a topic. In a persuasive speech, main points usually function as arguments that support your claim.

To develop main points, ask:

What is my thesis?

What are the most important ideas the audience needs to understand?

What does my research show?

What evidence best supports my central claim?

What order will make the most sense to the audience?

Each main point should be clear, focused, and connected to the thesis. If a main point does not support the thesis, it probably does not belong in the speech.

LET THE THESIS STATEMENT BE YOUR GUIDE

The thesis statement should guide the structure of your speech. Once you know the central idea, your main points should grow from it.

Example:

SPECIFIC PURPOSE: To inform my audience about three ways mindful meditation can help college students manage stress.

THESIS STATEMENT: Mindful meditation can help college students manage stress by improving breathing awareness, increasing focus, and encouraging physical relaxation.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Mindful meditation helps students become more aware of their breathing.

II. Mindful meditation can improve focus by training attention.

III. Mindful meditation encourages physical relaxation through body awareness.

Notice that each main point connects directly to the thesis. The speech is not trying to cover every possible benefit of meditation. It has a specific purpose, a focused thesis, and three main points that support that thesis.

LIMIT YOUR MAIN POINTS

Most classroom speeches work best with two or three main points. A longer speech may have more, but a short speech with five or six main points usually feels rushed and shallow. Too many main points often means the topic is too broad.

A five-minute speech should not attempt to explain the entire history of climate change, social media, mental health, artificial intelligence, or public education. That is not a speech. That is a panic attack with citations.

Limit your main points so each one can be developed with enough explanation and support.

Weak main point:

I. The Great Pacific Garbage Patch is the largest accumulation of plastic in the ocean and is formed by a trash vortex called a gyre.

This main point combines two ideas.

Stronger main points:

I. The Great Pacific Garbage Patch is a large accumulation of plastic waste located in the Pacific Ocean.

II. Ocean currents called gyres help collect and trap plastic debris in that region.

Each point now has one clear job.

MAKE MAIN POINTS PARALLEL

Main points should be written in a similar grammatical pattern when possible. Parallel structure helps the audience recognize that ideas are connected and of equal importance.

Weak version:

I. Sleep improves memory.

II. How students feel more focused when they sleep enough.

III. Less stress.

Stronger version:

I. Sleep improves memory.

II. Sleep increases focus.

III. Sleep reduces stress.

The stronger version is clearer because each main point follows the same structure.

USE DECLARATIVE STATEMENTS

Main points should usually be written as declarative sentences. A declarative sentence makes a clear statement.

Weak main point:

I. Exercise.

Stronger main point:

I. Regular exercise can improve students' mood and concentration.

The stronger version tells the audience what the speaker is actually claiming about exercise.

For persuasive speeches, main points should state clear arguments.

Weak main point:

I. Parking.

Stronger main point:

I. Colleges should expand student parking because long parking searches can cause students to miss class.

The stronger version gives the audience a specific claim.

USE SUBPOINTS TO SUPPORT MAIN POINTS

Subpoints are supporting ideas that explain, clarify, prove, or develop a main point. They are sometimes called subordinate points because they are placed underneath the main point they support.

Main points are the large claims. Subpoints are the smaller pieces that help build those claims.

Example:

I. Sleep improves academic performance.

A. Sleep helps the brain process and store information.

B. Sleep improves concentration during class.

C. Sleep helps students manage stress during exams.

Each subpoint supports the main point. If a subpoint does not support the main point above it, it should be moved, revised, or removed.

USE SYMBOLIZATION AND INDENTATION

Outlines use symbols and indentation to show the relationship between ideas. The most common outline symbols are Roman numerals, capital letters, numbers, and lowercase letters.

Example:

I. Main Point

A. Supporting Point

1. Subpoint

a. Sub-subpoint

Indentation matters because it shows which ideas are equal and which ideas are subordinate.

Main points should align with other main points. Supporting points should align with other supporting points. Subpoints should align with other subpoints.

Correct structure:

I. Main Point One

A. Supporting Point

B. Supporting Point

II. Main Point Two

A. Supporting Point

B. Supporting Point

If the indentation is messy, the logic of the speech becomes harder to follow. Formatting is not decoration here. It shows the structure of your thinking.

PRINCIPLES OF ORGANIZATION

Strong speeches usually follow three basic principles of organization: unity, coherence, and balance.

UNITY

A speech has unity when all parts of the speech support the purpose and thesis. Each main point should connect to the thesis. Each subpoint should support the main point above it. Each example, statistic, story, or quotation should serve the speech's central idea.

If a piece of information is interesting but does not support the speech, leave it out.

For example, if your speech is about how sleep affects academic performance, a long story about the history of mattresses may be interesting, but it probably does not belong unless it directly supports your point. Not every fun fact deserves a microphone.

COHERENCE

A speech has coherence when the ideas are organized logically and are easy to follow. The audience should understand how one idea connects to the next.

Coherence depends on clear main points, logical order, strong transitions, and consistent language. If your audience feels lost, it may not be because your information is weak. It may be because the path through the information is unclear.

To improve coherence, ask:

Does each point follow naturally from the previous point?

Can the audience tell where I am in the speech?

Have I used transitions?

Have I avoided jumping between unrelated ideas?

Can I summarize the structure in one sentence?

A coherent speech feels guided. The audience should not have to assemble the speech like furniture from a suspicious instruction manual.

BALANCE

A speech has balance when the main points receive appropriate emphasis. In most classroom speeches, each main point should receive roughly equal development unless one point clearly requires more explanation.

If your first main point takes four minutes and your second and third points take thirty seconds each, the speech will feel uneven. Balance does not mean every section must be exactly the same length, but the audience should not feel that one point was fully developed while others were barely mentioned.

Balance also applies to the introduction, body, and conclusion. The body should be the longest part of the speech. The introduction and conclusion should be shorter but still complete.

USE TRANSITION STATEMENTS

Transitions help the audience move from one idea to the next. They are the bridges between parts of the speech. Without transitions, a speech can feel like disconnected pieces stacked on top of each other.

Transitions can be used:

Between the introduction and body

Between main points

Between subpoints

Before the conclusion

A transition often does two things:

1. It briefly reminds the audience what was just covered.

2. It previews what is coming next.

Example:

Now that we have seen how sleep affects memory, let's look at how sleep influences focus during class.

This transition reviews the previous point and previews the next one.

USE SIGNPOSTS

Signposts are words or phrases that tell the audience where they are in the speech. They are especially useful because listeners cannot reread a speech the way they can reread a page.

Common signposts include:

First

Second

Third

Next

Now let’s turn to

Another important point is

In contrast

For example

As a result

Finally

To summarize

Signposts should be clear but not excessive. If every other sentence begins with “now,” “next,” or “finally,” the speech can start to sound like GPS directions.

USE INTERNAL PREVIEWS

An internal preview tells the audience what will come next within the body of the speech. Internal previews are especially helpful when a main point contains several parts.

Example:

To understand how students can reduce speech anxiety, we will look at three strategies: preparation, controlled breathing, and practice with feedback.

This preview helps the audience organize what they are about to hear.

USE INTERNAL REVIEWS

An internal review briefly reminds the audience what has already been covered. Internal reviews are useful after complex information, before major transitions, or near the end of a long main point.

Example:

So far, we have seen that sleep improves memory, strengthens focus, and helps students manage stress.

This review reinforces the main ideas before moving forward.

COMBINE PREVIEW AND REVIEW STATEMENTS

The strongest transitions often combine a review of the previous point with a preview of the next point.

Example:

Now that we understand how AI can help students brainstorm speech topics, let's turn to a second issue: why students must verify AI-generated information before using it in a speech.

This kind of transition helps the audience stay oriented and understand the relationship between ideas.

ORGANIZE FOR THE EAR

A speech is different from an essay because the audience hears it in real time. They cannot go back and reread a confusing sentence. For that reason, oral organization needs to be especially clear.

To organize for the ear:

Use clear main points.

Use repetition strategically.

Use transitions between ideas.

Preview and review important information.

Avoid long, complicated sentences.

Make the structure easy to hear.

A written outline may look organized on the page, but the real test is whether the audience can follow it while listening.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

A speech has three major parts: introduction, body, and conclusion. The introduction prepares the audience for the speech, the body develops the main ideas, and the conclusion reviews the message and provides closure.

The body of the speech is built around main points, supporting points, and transitions. Main points should support the thesis statement, be limited in number, follow parallel structure when possible, and be written as clear declarative statements. Subpoints support, explain, or prove the main points.

Strong organization depends on unity, coherence, and balance. Unity means all parts of the speech support the thesis. Coherence means ideas are logically connected and easy to follow. Balance means each major part of the speech receives appropriate development.

Transitions, signposts, internal previews, and internal reviews help the audience follow the structure of the speech. Because speeches are heard in real time, organization must be clear, direct, and audience-centered.

KEY TERMS

Organization

Introduction

Body

Conclusion

Main points

Subpoints

Supporting points

Thesis statement

Specific purpose

Declarative sentence

Parallel structure

Coordination

Subordination

Symbolization

Indentation

Unity

Coherence

Balance

Transition

Signpost

Internal preview

Internal review

Preview statement

Review statement

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why is organization especially important in public speaking?
2. What is the relationship between the thesis statement and the main points?
3. Why should most classroom speeches limit the number of main points?
4. What is the difference between a main point and a subpoint?
5. How do unity, coherence, and balance improve a speech?
6. Why do listeners need transitions, signposts, previews, and reviews?
7. How is organizing a speech different from organizing an essay?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

MAIN POINT PRACTICE

Choose one thesis statement below and create three main points that support it.

Thesis Option A:

College students can reduce stress by improving sleep habits, managing time more intentionally, and asking for support before problems become overwhelming.

Thesis Option B:

AI can help students prepare speeches, but it should be used as a support tool rather than a replacement for original thinking.

Thesis Option C:

Public speaking skills help students succeed in school, work, and civic life.

For your chosen thesis:

1. Write three main points.
2. Make sure each main point supports the thesis.
3. Make sure each main point is written as a complete declarative sentence.
4. Make the main points parallel if possible.
5. Add two subpoints under each main point.

TRANSITION PRACTICE

Write a transition between the following two main points:

I. Public speaking anxiety is common among college students.

II. Preparation and rehearsal can reduce public speaking anxiety.

Example:

Now that we understand why speech anxiety is common, we can look at one of the most effective ways to manage it: preparation and rehearsal.

OUTLINE STRUCTURE PRACTICE

Using the topic of your next speech, create a basic body outline:

I. Main Point One

A. Supporting Point

B. Supporting Point

II. Main Point Two

A. Supporting Point

B. Supporting Point

III. Main Point Three

A. Supporting Point

B. Supporting Point

Then check your outline for unity, coherence, and balance.

Chapter 13

ORGANIZATIONAL PATTERNS

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Define organizational patterns and explain why they matter in public speaking.
2. Identify common organizational patterns used in speeches.
3. Explain when to use chronological, spatial, topical, problem-cause-solution, cause-effect, comparative, and narrative patterns.
4. Select an organizational pattern that fits the topic, purpose, audience, and occasion.
5. Develop sample main points using different organizational patterns.
6. Recognize how organizational patterns help audiences follow and remember a speech.

Speeches can be organized in many different ways. The pattern you choose affects how the audience understands your message. A strong organizational pattern helps listeners follow your ideas, see the relationship between your points, and remember the speech after it ends.

An organizational pattern is the structure used to arrange the main points of a speech. Some speeches move through time. Some move through physical space. Some explain causes and effects. Some divide a topic into categories. Some tell a story. Some identify a problem and propose a solution.

There is no single best organizational pattern for every speech. The best pattern depends on your topic, purpose, audience, and occasion. Choosing the wrong pattern can make a strong topic feel confusing. Choosing the right pattern can make a complicated topic easier to follow.

CHRONOLOGICAL ORGANIZATION

A chronological pattern organizes information according to time. This pattern works well when the speech explains how something happened, how something developed, or how a process unfolds step by step.

Chronological organization is useful for topics involving history, biographies, events, processes, timelines, instructions, or change over time.

Use chronological organization when your topic answers questions such as:

What happened first?

What happened next?

How did this develop over time?

What steps are involved?

How did we get from one point to another?

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

Generative AI developed from early computer science research into widely available tools that now affect education, work, and communication.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Early artificial intelligence research focused on teaching computers to solve problems and recognize patterns.

II. Later developments in machine learning allowed systems to process large amounts of data and generate more complex responses.

III. Today, generative AI tools can produce text, images, audio, and video, creating new opportunities and ethical challenges.

This pattern works because the audience can follow the development of AI over time.

SPATIAL ORGANIZATION

A spatial pattern organizes information according to physical location, direction, or arrangement. This pattern is useful when describing a place, object, building, environment, route, image, or physical system.

Spatial organization works well when your topic answers questions such as:

Where is each part located?

How is this space arranged?

What would the audience see first, next, and last?

How do the parts relate physically?

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

A well-designed theater space uses the stage, audience seating, backstage area, and technical booth to support the performance.

MAIN POINTS:

I. The stage is the central performance area where actors communicate the story.

II. The audience seating shapes how spectators see and experience the performance.

III. The backstage and technical areas support lighting, sound, costumes, props, and scene changes.

This pattern works because the audience is being guided through a physical space.

Spatial organization can also be useful for speeches about museums, campuses, cities, parks, homes, workplaces, websites, apps, or even the layout of a presentation slide.

TOPICAL ORGANIZATION

A topical pattern divides a subject into categories, types, parts, reasons, or themes. It is one of the most common organizational patterns because it can be used for many kinds of speeches.

Use topical organization when your main points are categories of the larger topic and can be arranged in more than one logical order.

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

Public speaking skills help students succeed academically, professionally, and personally.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Public speaking skills help students succeed in the classroom.

II. Public speaking skills help students communicate in professional settings.

III. Public speaking skills help students advocate for themselves and others.

Each main point is a category of the topic. The speaker could arrange these points in several ways, but this order moves from school to work to personal life.

Topical organization is flexible, but that flexibility can become a trap. If the points feel random, the speech may sound like a list. To avoid this, choose categories that clearly support the thesis and arrange them in the order that will make the most sense to the audience.

PROBLEM–CAUSE–SOLUTION ORGANIZATION

The problem-cause-solution pattern organizes a speech around three major parts: the problem, the cause of the problem, and the solution. This pattern is especially useful for persuasive speeches because it helps the audience understand why an issue matters and what can be done about it.

The basic structure is:

I. Problem

II. Cause

III. Solution

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

To reduce student burnout, colleges should address overloaded schedules, unclear expectations, and limited access to support services.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Student burnout is a serious problem that affects academic performance and well-being.

II. Burnout is often caused by overloaded schedules, financial pressure, unclear expectations, and lack of support.

III. Colleges can reduce burnout by improving advising, communicating expectations clearly, and expanding mental health resources.

This pattern works because it moves the audience from awareness to explanation to action.

When using this pattern, make sure the solution actually responds to the cause. If the problem is student burnout and the cause is financial pressure, a solution focused only on better campus parking may not fully address the issue. That would be like treating a broken arm with a motivational quote.

CAUSE-EFFECT ORGANIZATION

A cause-effect pattern explains why something happens and what results from it. This pattern may focus on causes, effects, or both.

Use cause-effect organization when your topic answers questions such as:

Why did this happen?

What caused this problem?

What are the consequences?

What happens as a result?

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

Poor sleep habits can affect college students' attention, mood, and academic performance.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Poor sleep habits make it harder for students to focus during class.

II. Poor sleep habits can increase irritability, stress, and emotional exhaustion.

III. Poor sleep habits can weaken memory and academic performance.

This speech focuses mainly on effects. A different version could focus on causes:

THESIS STATEMENT:

College students often develop poor sleep habits because of academic pressure, screen use, and inconsistent schedules.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Academic pressure can push students to sacrifice sleep for studying.

II. Screen use before bed can make it harder to fall asleep.

III. Inconsistent schedules can disrupt the body's sleep rhythm.

Both versions use cause-effect reasoning, but they emphasize different parts of the relationship.

COMPARATIVE ORGANIZATION

A comparative pattern organizes a speech by comparing two or more ideas, options, people, products, policies, or approaches. This pattern is useful when the audience needs to understand similarities, differences, advantages, or disadvantages.

Use comparative organization when your topic answers questions such as:

How are these things alike?

How are they different?

Which option is stronger?

What are the advantages and disadvantages?

Why should one option be preferred?

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

Community colleges and universities both serve important educational purposes, but they differ in cost, class size, and student support.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Community colleges are usually more affordable than universities.

II. Community colleges often offer smaller class sizes and more direct instructor contact.

III. Universities usually provide more advanced degree pathways, research opportunities, and campus resources.

This pattern works because each main point compares the two educational options.

Comparative organization is especially useful in persuasive speeches when you want to show why one solution is better than another.

NARRATIVE ORGANIZATION

A narrative pattern organizes a speech as a story or series of connected stories. Narratives usually include characters, setting, conflict, action, and some form of change. This pattern can be powerful because stories help audiences connect emotionally and remember ideas.

Use narrative organization when your topic answers questions such as:

What happened?

Who was involved?

What changed?

What conflict or challenge shaped the experience?

What lesson or meaning came from the story?

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:

One student's first public speaking experience shows how preparation, feedback, and persistence can turn anxiety into confidence.

MAIN POINTS:

I. At first, the student avoided public speaking because of fear and past embarrassment.

II. During preparation, the student used rehearsal and feedback to improve the speech.

III. After delivering the speech, the student realized confidence can grow through practice.

This pattern works because the speech follows a beginning, middle, and end.

Narrative organization does not mean "just tell a story and hope it works." A narrative speech still needs a clear purpose, thesis, main points, transitions, and conclusion. The story should support the larger message. Otherwise, it becomes a campfire story with a grading rubric.

PROBLEM–SOLUTION ORGANIZATION

A problem-solution pattern is a simpler version of problem-cause-solution. It identifies a problem and then proposes a solution. This pattern works well when the cause is already known or does not need extended explanation.

The basic structure is:

I. Problem

II. Solution

Example:

THESIS STATEMENT:
Students should reduce phone distractions during study time by using app limits, scheduled breaks, and phone-free study spaces.

MAIN POINTS:

I. Phone distractions make it harder for students to concentrate and complete academic work.

II. Students can reduce distractions by setting app limits, scheduling phone breaks, and creating phone-free study spaces.

This pattern works well for short persuasive speeches because it is direct and easy to follow.

CHOOSING THE BEST PATTERN

The best organizational pattern depends on the speech's purpose and the audience's needs.

Use chronological organization when time order matters.

Use spatial organization when physical arrangement matters.

Use topical organization when the topic can be divided into categories.

Use problem-cause-solution organization when you need to explain an issue, its causes, and a response.

Use cause-effect organization when explaining why something happens or what happens as a result.

Use comparative organization when evaluating similarities, differences, or advantages.

Use narrative organization when a story structure will help the audience understand the meaning of an experience.

Use problem-solution organization when the audience needs a clear issue and a clear response.

If more than one pattern could work, choose the one that makes the speech easiest for the audience to follow. Organization is not about showing off your outline skills. It is about helping the audience stay with you.

COMBINING ORGANIZATIONAL PATTERNS

Some speeches use more than one organizational pattern. For example, a speech about the history of public speaking might use chronological organization overall but include topical sections within each time period. A persuasive speech might use problem-cause-solution as the main structure while using a narrative example inside the first main point.

Combining patterns can work, but the overall structure should still be clear. If the audience cannot tell where the speech is going, simplify the organization.

A speech can be complex. It should not be chaotic.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Organizational patterns help speakers arrange main points in a way that is clear, logical, and audience-centered. The pattern should fit the topic, purpose, audience, and occasion.

Chronological organization arranges ideas according to time. Spatial organization arranges ideas according to physical location or direction. Topical organization divides a subject into categories. Problem-cause-solution organization identifies a

problem, explains its causes, and proposes a solution. Cause-effect organization explains why something happens or what results from it. Comparative organization examines similarities, differences, advantages, or disadvantages. Narrative organization uses story structure to communicate meaning. Problem-solution organization identifies a problem and proposes a direct response.

Strong speakers choose organizational patterns that help the audience follow, understand, and remember the message. Some speeches combine patterns, but the overall structure should remain clear.

KEY TERMS

Organizational pattern

Chronological organization

Spatial organization

Topical organization

Problem-cause-solution organization

Cause-effect organization

Comparative organization

Narrative organization

Problem-solution organization

Main points

Thesis statement

Time order

Physical arrangement

Category

Cause

Effect

Comparison

Story structure

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does the organizational pattern of a speech matter?

2. Which pattern would work best for a speech explaining how a historical event unfolded? Why?

3. What is the difference between topical organization and spatial organization?

4. When would problem-cause-solution organization be stronger than simple problem-solution organization?

5. How can narrative organization help an audience connect emotionally with a speech?

6. Why might a speaker combine more than one organizational pattern?

7. What can happen when the speaker chooses the wrong organizational pattern?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

PATTERN PRACTICE

Choose one topic from the list below:

Artificial intelligence in education

Student stress

Public transportation

Social media use

A favorite place

A historical event

A personal challenge

College affordability

A health habit

A career field

Complete the following:

1. Write one possible thesis statement for the topic.

2. Choose one organizational pattern that fits the thesis.

3. Create three main points using that pattern.

4. Explain why that pattern fits the topic and audience.

Example:

Topic: Student stress

Thesis statement: College students can reduce stress by improving sleep habits, managing time more intentionally, and asking for support before problems become overwhelming.

Organizational pattern: Topical

Main points:

I. Improving sleep habits can reduce stress.

II. Managing time intentionally can reduce stress.

III. Asking for support early can reduce stress.

Why this pattern fits: Each main point is a category of stress management.

PATTERN COMPARISON PRACTICE

Take the same topic and organize it two different ways.

Example topic: Social media use

Topical pattern:

I. Social media affects attention.

II. Social media affects self-image.

III. Social media affects relationships.

Cause-effect pattern:

I. Constant notifications interrupt focus.

II. Interrupted focus can reduce productivity.

III. Reduced productivity can increase stress.

After creating both versions, answer:

1. Which version is clearer?

2. Which version is more interesting?

3. Which version would work better for your audience?

4. Which version would be easier to support with evidence?

Chapter 14

OUTLINING THE SPEECH

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why outlining is important in speech preparation.
2. Distinguish between a working outline and a speaking outline.
3. Identify the major parts of a complete speech outline.
4. Use main points, subpoints, transitions, and citations in a working outline.
5. Create a speaking outline that supports extemporaneous delivery.
6. Explain how phrase outlines and keyword outlines help speakers avoid reading.
7. Prepare delivery notes that are clear, brief, and easy to use.

Once you have selected an organizational pattern for your main points, the next step is outlining the speech. An outline is a blueprint for your presentation. It helps you organize your ideas, test the structure of your message, connect evidence to main points, and prepare for delivery.

Outlining matters because speeches happen in real time. Your audience cannot reread your last sentence or flip back to your previous paragraph. If your ideas are not organized clearly, the audience may lose the thread. A strong outline gives your speech structure before you ever stand up to deliver it.

Outlines also help speakers think. When you outline, you can see whether your ideas actually fit together. You can identify weak support, missing transitions, repeated points, and sections that need more development. A messy outline usually leads to a messy speech. A clear outline gives you something solid to practice.

CREATE TWO OUTLINES

Most speakers should create two outlines: a working outline and a speaking outline.

A working outline is the detailed planning version of your speech. It includes your topic, general purpose, specific purpose, thesis statement, introduction, main points, subpoints, supporting material, transitions, conclusion, and citations. The working outline helps you develop the speech fully before you practice.

A speaking outline, sometimes called a delivery outline, is the shorter version you use while rehearsing or delivering the speech. It contains only the keywords, short phrases, source reminders, and delivery cues you need to remember your ideas. The speaking outline helps you deliver the speech naturally without reading the entire text.

The working outline is for building the speech.

The speaking outline is for delivering the speech.

Do not confuse the two. If you try to deliver from your full working outline, you will probably read too much. If you try to prepare from only a speaking out-

line, your ideas may not be developed enough. Both outlines serve a different purpose.

WORKING OUTLINES

A working outline is the more complete version of your speech plan. It allows you to organize and develop your ideas before you practice delivery.

A strong working outline usually includes:

Topic

General purpose

Specific purpose

Thesis statement

Introduction

Attention-getter

Speaker credibility

Relevance statement

Preview statement

Body

Main points

Subpoints

Supporting material

Oral citations

Transitions

Conclusion

Review statement

Thesis reminder

Closing statement

Works cited or reference list

The working outline should be detailed enough to show how your speech works. Main points and subpoints should usually be written as complete sentences. Supporting material should be connected to the point it supports. Transitions should be written out. Citations should be included.

A working outline is not just a list of ideas. It is a map of the speech.

SPEAKING OUTLINES

A speaking outline is the shortened version of your speech used for rehearsal and delivery. It should help you remember what comes next without tempting you to read word for word.

A speaking outline may include:

Keywords

Short phrases

Main point reminders

Source names and dates

Statistics that must be stated accurately

Transition reminders

Delivery cues

Slide cues

Timing notes

The speaking outline should be brief. Its job is to trigger your memory, not replace your preparation.

For example, a working outline main point might say:

I. Students can use controlled breathing to reduce the physical symptoms of speech anxiety before a presentation.

A speaking outline version might say:

I. Breathing = reduces physical anxiety

Example: 4-count inhale / 4-count exhale

Demo?

The speaking outline reminds the speaker what to say without scripting every sentence.

AVOID READING YOUR SPEECH

In most classroom speeches, you should not read your speech word for word. Reading usually reduces eye contact, limits gestures, flattens vocal variety, and makes the speech sound less conversational.

Public speaking is not public reading.

There are exceptions. It may be appropriate to read a direct quotation, legal statement, technical definition, poem, ceremonial tribute, or sensitive wording that must be precise. But most of your speech should be delivered extemporaneously, meaning it is carefully prepared and practiced but not memorized word for word.

The goal is to know your ideas well enough that you can speak naturally.

PHRASE OUTLINES

A phrase outline uses short phrases rather than complete sentences. Phrase outlines are useful for delivery because they remind you of your ideas without encouraging you to read.

Example:

Main Point:

Sleep improves academic performance.

Phrase outline version:

Sleep → memory / focus / stress

A phrase outline gives you enough information to stay on track while still requiring you to speak in your own words.

KEYWORD OUTLINES

A keyword outline is even shorter. It uses only the most important words needed to trigger memory. Experienced speakers often use keyword outlines because they allow for stronger eye contact, more natural gestures, and greater flexibility.

Example:

I. Sleep

A. Memory

B. Focus

C. Stress

This outline is simple, but it only works if the speaker has practiced. A keyword outline without rehearsal is not confidence. It is a trap with bullet points.

CREATE THE BODY FIRST

When building a working outline, start with the body of the speech. The body contains your main points, subpoints, supporting material, and transitions. Once the body is clear, it becomes easier to write the introduction and conclusion.

Many speakers make the mistake of spending too much time on the opening line before they know what the speech actually says. A strong introduction should lead into the body. A strong conclusion should grow from the body. If the body changes, the introduction and conclusion may need to change too.

Build the middle first. Then create the opening and ending around it.

USE CLEAR MAIN POINTS AND SUBPOINTS

A working outline should show the relationship between main points and subpoints. Main points support the thesis. Subpoints support the main points. Supporting material supports the subpoints.

Use indentation and symbols to show this relationship.

Example:

I. Main Point

A. Supporting Point

1. Evidence or example

2. Explanation

B. Supporting Point

1. Evidence or example

2. Explanation

II. Main Point

A. Supporting Point

1. Evidence or example

2. Explanation

Indentation is not just formatting. It shows the logic of your speech. If everything is aligned the same way, the audience may not see which ideas are major points and which ideas are support.

INCLUDE TRANSITIONS

Transitions should be included in the working outline. A transition helps the audience move from one idea to the next. It may review what was just covered, preview what comes next, or explain the relationship between points.

Example:

Now that we understand how sleep affects memory, let's look at how sleep also influences focus during class.

Transitions are especially important in speeches because listeners cannot see your outline. They need verbal cues to follow the structure.

INCLUDE ORAL CITATIONS

A working outline should include oral citations where source material appears. Do not wait until the end to figure out where your research came from. Include the source in the section where you plan to use it.

Example:

According to a 2026 report from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, a federal public health agency, insufficient sleep is associated with problems in attention, mood, and overall health.

In the speaking outline, this might become:

CDC, 2026 → sleep affects attention/mood/health

The working outline helps you prepare the full citation. The speaking outline reminds you to say it during delivery.

USING DIGITAL TOOLS WHILE OUTLINING

Digital tools can help you organize your outline, move sections around, check timing, and revise for clarity. Word processors, note-taking apps, cloud documents, and presentation software can all support the outlining process.

The tool matters less than the thinking behind it. Whether you write your outline on paper, in Pages, in Google Docs, or on note cards, the same question matters: Does the structure help the audience follow the speech?

SAMPLE WORKING OUTLINE

The following sample working outline is for an informative speech about sleep and academic performance. Notice that the outline includes an introduction, body, transitions, oral citations, conclusion, and works cited section.

The purpose of this sample is not for you to copy the topic. The purpose is for you to see the structure.

Speech Title: Sleep Is a Study Strategy

Topic: Sleep and academic performance

General Purpose: To inform

Specific Purpose: To inform my audience about three ways sleep affects academic success for college students.

Thesis Statement: Sleep supports academic success by improving memory, strengthening focus, and helping students manage stress.

I. Introduction

A. Attention-Getter:

Many students treat sleep like the thing they do after everything else is finished. Homework first. Work first. Phone first. Stress first. Sleep gets whatever time is left, which usually means sleep gets robbed.

B. Speaker Credibility:

As a student and speaker, I have experienced how lack of sleep affects concentration and performance. I also researched sleep through public health and academic sources.

C. Thesis Statement:

Sleep supports academic success by improving memory, strengthening focus, and helping students manage stress.

D. Preview Statement:

First, we will look at how sleep supports memory. Second, we will examine how sleep affects focus. Finally, we will discuss how sleep helps students manage stress.

Transition:

Let’s begin with one of the most important academic benefits of sleep: memory.

II. Body

A. Main Point One: Sleep supports memory and learning.

1. Sleep helps the brain process and store information.

2. Supporting Material:

According to the National Institutes of Health, a federal medical research agency, sleep plays an important role in learning and memory because the brain processes new information during sleep.

3. Speaker's Idea:

This means studying is not only about the hours spent awake with notes. The brain also needs rest to organize and retain information.

4. Example:

A student who studies vocabulary for a language class may remember more after sleeping than after staying up all night and trying to cram more words.

Transition:

Now that we have seen how sleep supports memory, let's look at how it affects focus.

B. Main Point Two: Sleep strengthens focus and attention.

1. Lack of sleep can make it harder to concentrate during class, reading, studying, or exams.

2. Supporting Material:

According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, insufficient sleep is connected to problems with attention, mood, and overall health.

3. Speaker's Idea:

When students do not sleep enough, they may be physically present in class but mentally checked out. The body is in the chair, but the brain is buffering.

4. Example:

A student may read the same paragraph five times and still not remember what it said because fatigue is interfering with attention.

Transition:

Sleep does not only affect memory and focus. It also affects how students handle stress.

C. Main Point Three: Sleep helps students manage stress.

1. College students often balance school, work, family, relationships, finances, and personal responsibilities.

2. Supporting Material:

In a recent report from the American Psychological Association, researchers noted that sleep and stress are closely connected, with poor sleep often making stress harder to manage.

3. Speaker's Idea:

When students are tired, ordinary problems can feel heavier. A deadline, a quiz, or a small conflict may feel more overwhelming when the body has not recovered.

4. Example:

A student who gets enough sleep before a speech may still feel nervous, but they are more likely to think clearly and manage the pressure.

Transition to Conclusion:

Sleep improves memory, strengthens focus, and helps students manage stress. These benefits show why sleep should be treated as part of academic preparation.

III. Conclusion

A. Review Statement:

Today, we looked at three ways sleep supports academic success: it improves memory, strengthens focus, and helps students manage stress.

B. Thesis Reminder:

Sleep is not wasted time. It is part of how students learn, perform, and recover.

C. Closing Statement:

The next time you are tempted to sacrifice sleep to study, remember that your brain is not a machine. It needs recovery to do the work you are asking it to do. Sleep is not the enemy of productivity. It is part of the strategy.

IV. Works Cited or References

American Psychological Association. “Stress in America.” American Psychological Association.

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. “Sleep and Sleep Disorders.” CDC.

National Institutes of Health. “Brain Basics: Understanding Sleep.” NIH.

USE A SPEAKING OUTLINE WHEN PERFORMING

After completing the working outline, create a shorter speaking outline for rehearsal and delivery. The speaking outline should not include full paragraphs. It should include reminders.

SAMPLE SPEAKING OUTLINE

Sleep Is a Study Strategy

Intro

Attention: sleep gets robbed

Credibility: personal + research

Thesis: sleep = memory, focus, stress

Preview: memory / focus / stress

I. Memory

NIH → sleep helps learning/memory

Idea: brain stores info during sleep

Example: vocab after sleep

Transition: memory → focus

II. Focus

CDC → sleep affects attention/mood/health

Idea: body in chair, brain buffering

Example: rereading same paragraph

Transition: focus → stress

III. Stress

APA → sleep + stress connected

Idea: tired = problems feel heavier

Example: sleep before speech

Conclusion

Review: memory / focus / stress

Thesis reminder: sleep = academic prep

Close: sleep is part of the strategy

Notice how short the speaking outline is. It provides cues, not a script. The speaker must practice enough that these cues bring the full ideas back to mind.

PREPARING NOTES FOR DELIVERY

Different instructors have different policies about delivery notes. Some allow note cards. Some allow printed speaking outlines. Some allow tablets. Some do not allow phones because phones can look casual, create distractions, or tempt speakers to read.

Follow your instructor's policy.

If you use note cards, write large enough that you can read them at a glance. Number the cards. Keep them simple. Do not fill every inch with tiny text unless you enjoy squinting under pressure.

If you use a printed speaking outline, keep it clean and easy to scan. Use spacing, bold words, or indentation to help your eye find the next point quickly.

The goal is to glance, remember, and return to the audience.

PRACTICE WITH YOUR SPEAKING OUTLINE

Do not wait until speech day to use your speaking outline. Practice with it. Revise it when you realize something is missing or confusing. If you keep losing

your place, simplify the outline. If you keep forgetting a source, add a stronger cue. If you keep reading too much, remove extra wording.

Practice out loud. Time yourself. Practice standing. Practice with slides if you are using them. Practice transitions. Practice oral citations. Practice the introduction and conclusion until they feel comfortable.

The outline is not the speech. The speech happens when you bring the outline to life.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Outlining helps speakers organize ideas, develop support, and prepare for clear delivery. A working outline is the detailed planning version of the speech. It includes the introduction, body, conclusion, transitions, supporting material, oral citations, and references. A speaking outline is the shorter version used for rehearsal and delivery.

Working outlines help speakers build the speech. Speaking outlines help speakers deliver the speech without reading word for word. Phrase outlines and keyword outlines can help speakers speak naturally while staying organized.

Strong outlines use clear main points, subpoints, indentation, transitions, and citations. Speakers should create the body of the speech before finalizing the introduction and conclusion.

A good outline does not replace practice. It supports practice. The more familiar you are with your outline, the more confident and natural you will be during delivery.

KEY TERMS

Outline

Working outline

Speaking outline

Delivery outline

Phrase outline

Keyword outline

Main point

Subpoint

Supporting material

Transition

Oral citation

Attention-getter

Speaker credibility

Relevance statement

Preview statement

Review statement

Thesis statement

Works cited

References

Extemporaneous delivery

Delivery cues

Note cards

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why should speakers create both a working outline and a speaking outline?

2. What is the danger of delivering a speech from a full working outline?

3. How does a speaking outline support extemporaneous delivery?

4. Why should speakers usually create the body of the speech before the introduction and conclusion?

5. What information should be included in a working outline?

6. What makes a speaking outline useful during delivery?

7. Why does practice matter even when a speaker has a strong outline?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

WORKING OUTLINE PRACTICE

Choose a speech topic and complete the following:

1. Write your general purpose.

2. Write your specific purpose.

3. Write your thesis statement.

4. Create three main points.

5. Add at least two subpoints under each main point.

6. Add one piece of supporting material under each main point.

7. Write one transition between each main point.

SPEAKING OUTLINE PRACTICE

Using your working outline, create a speaking outline that includes only:

1. Keywords.

2. Short phrases.

3. Source reminders.

4. Transition cues.

5. Delivery cues.

After creating the speaking outline, practice your speech out loud once. Then answer:

1. Did the speaking outline give you enough information?

2. Did it tempt you to read too much?

3. What cues should you add?

4. What words should you remove?

5. How can you make the outline easier to scan while speaking?

OUTLINE REVIEW

Exchange outlines with a classmate. Review the outline and answer:

1. Do the main points clearly support the thesis?
2. Are any points repeated?
3. Are any points missing evidence?
4. Do the transitions help the audience follow the speech?
5. Does the structure fit the speech purpose?
6. What is one specific revision that would make the outline stronger?

Chapter 15

INTRODUCING AND CONCLUDING THE SPEECH

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why introductions and conclusions are important in public speaking.
2. Identify the major parts of a strong speech introduction.
3. Create an attention-getter that fits the topic, audience, and occasion.
4. Establish speaker credibility early in a speech.
5. Write a clear thesis or thematic statement.
6. Use a preview statement to guide the audience.
7. Identify the major parts of a strong speech conclusion.
8. Create a conclusion that reviews the speech, reinforces the central idea, and provides closure.

The opening and closing moments of a speech carry special weight. The introduction is your first opportunity to earn the audience's attention. The conclusion is your final opportunity to reinforce the message and leave the audience with something to remember.

Because these moments matter, you should know your opening and closing especially well. You do not need to memorize the entire speech word for word, but

you should rehearse the introduction and conclusion until they feel comfortable. A speaker who begins with confidence and ends with purpose immediately appears more prepared.

Do not attempt to wing the opening. Audience attention is limited, and people have plenty of distractions competing for it: phones, messages, side conversations, hunger, fatigue, stress, and whatever else is happening in their lives. Your job is to give them a reason to listen.

Avoid beginning with an apology or disclaimer such as “I’m really nervous,” “I didn’t have much time to prepare,” or “This probably won’t be very good.” These statements weaken your credibility before the speech begins. Most audiences are willing to give you a chance. Do not talk them out of it.

What matters is the audience, the topic, and the message. Start with something that brings the audience into the speech.

THE PURPOSE OF AN INTRODUCTION

A strong introduction should do several things:

Get the audience’s attention.

Introduce the topic.

Show why the topic matters.

Establish speaker credibility.

Present the thesis or central idea.

Preview the main points.

The introduction does not need to be long, but it does need to be complete. A weak introduction can make even a strong topic feel unfocused. A strong introduction gives the audience a clear path into the speech.

CREATE AN ATTENTION-GETTER

The purpose of an attention-getter is exactly what it sounds like: to get the audience's attention. It should make the audience want to hear what comes next.

Common attention-getters include:

Quotations

Stories

Questions

Surprising facts or statistics

Vivid descriptions

Humor

Powerful images

Brief demonstrations

Curiosity-building statements

The best attention-getter depends on the topic, audience, and occasion. A joke may work well for a light topic but fail badly during a serious one. A startling statistic may work well for a persuasive speech but feel unnecessary for a toast. A personal story may build connection, but only if it leads clearly into the topic.

The attention-getter should not feel like a random trick. It should connect to the speech.

QUOTATIONS

A quotation can be a strong way to begin a speech when the quote expresses an idea related to your topic. A good quotation is brief, memorable, and relevant.

However, quotations are often overused, misquoted, or misattributed. Before using a quote, verify who said it, where it came from, and what it originally meant. Online quote graphics are not reliable sources. They are often the academic equivalent of “trust me, bro” in cursive font.

If you use a quotation, do not simply drop it into the room and move on. Explain how it connects to your topic.

Weak use of a quote:

Albert Einstein once said, “Imagination is more important than knowledge.” Today I will talk about creativity.

Stronger use of a quote:

Albert Einstein is often associated with the idea that imagination matters deeply in problem-solving. Whether or not we are discussing science, art, or communication, creativity often begins with the ability to see possibilities others miss. Today, I want to explain why creativity is not just a talent, but a skill students can practice.

The stronger version uses the quote as a doorway into the speech.

STORIES

Stories are one of the most powerful ways to begin a speech. A story can create emotional connection, establish relevance, and help the audience understand why the topic matters.

A strong opening story should be focused. It does not need every detail. It needs the right details.

Ask yourself:

Who is involved?

What happened?

What is at stake?

What does this story reveal about the topic?

How quickly can I get to the point?

For example, a speech about sleep and academic performance might begin with a student staying up until 3:00 a.m. to study, only to blank during the exam

the next morning. That story immediately connects the topic to a common student experience.

Do not let the story become the whole speech. The story should open the door, not move in and start paying rent.

QUESTIONS

Questions can involve the audience and encourage them to think about the topic. There are two common types: rhetorical questions and direct questions.

A rhetorical question is meant to make the audience think, not answer out loud.

Example:

Have you ever stayed up late preparing for something important, only to feel completely unprepared the next day?

A direct question invites an actual response.

Example:

By a show of hands, how many of you have ever felt nervous before giving a presentation?

Use direct questions carefully. If you ask for a response, be prepared to acknowledge it and move forward. Do not ask a question and then ignore the audience completely. That is not interaction; that is emotional hit-and-run.

IGNITE CURIOSITY

An introduction can create curiosity by opening a knowledge gap. A knowledge gap happens when the audience realizes there is something they do not know but wants to understand.

For example:

Most students think they know how to study. But one of the most powerful study strategies is something many students sacrifice first: sleep.

This kind of opening gives the audience a reason to listen because it challenges an assumption.

Curiosity works especially well when your topic seems familiar. If your audience thinks they already know what you are going to say, you need to show them there is more to the topic.

USE HUMOR CAREFULLY

Humor can help an audience relax, connect with the speaker, and become more willing to listen. However, humor must fit the audience, topic, and occasion.

Do not use humor that demeans, stereotypes, humiliates, or distracts from the message. Avoid jokes that rely on cruelty or shock value. A joke that makes the audience uncomfortable in the wrong way can damage your credibility quickly.

Humor also depends on delivery. Timing, facial expression, rhythm, and confidence matter. A joke that looks funny on paper may not work when spoken. If you are unsure whether a joke fits, test it on someone who will tell you the truth. Not someone who loves you too much. Someone with standards.

TEASE THE TOPIC

Some speakers give away too much too soon. They begin with a flat announcement:

Hi, my name is Sarah, and today I'm going to talk about social media.

This opening is clear, but it is not interesting. The audience may assume they already know what the speech will say.

A stronger opening creates anticipation:

Every morning, millions of people reach for their phones before they speak to another human being. Before breakfast, before class, before brushing their teeth, they are already scrolling. Today, we will look at how social media has changed the way people begin the day.

This version still introduces the topic, but it gives the audience a reason to listen.

ESTABLISH RELEVANCE

After gaining attention, the speaker should show why the topic matters to the audience. Relevance answers the audience's silent question: "Why should I care?"

A relevance statement connects the topic to the audience's experiences, needs, values, goals, or concerns.

Example:

This topic matters because most of us use social media every day, but few of us stop to think about how it shapes our attention, mood, and relationships.

Example:

This issue matters to college students because sleep affects memory, focus, stress, and academic performance.

Relevance does not mean every audience member will care equally. It means the speaker makes a thoughtful effort to connect the topic to the listeners.

ESTABLISH SPEAKER CREDIBILITY

Speaker credibility is the audience's perception that the speaker is prepared, trustworthy, and qualified to speak about the topic. You do not need to be a world expert, but you do need to show that you have done the work.

Credibility can come from:

Personal experience

Research

Education or training

Professional experience

Interviews

Observation

Connection to the topic

Example:

As someone who has struggled with procrastination, I became interested in how students manage time. For this speech, I also researched studies on time management and student performance.

Example:

I am not a sleep scientist, but I researched this topic using public health sources and academic studies because I wanted to understand how sleep affects learning.

Do not exaggerate your expertise. Be honest. Audiences can usually tell when a speaker is puffing themselves up like a résumé with stage fright.

STATE THE THESIS OR THEMATIC STATEMENT

The introduction should clearly tell the audience what the speech is about. In many speeches, this is done through a thesis statement or thematic statement.

A thesis statement expresses the central idea of the speech. In a persuasive speech, the thesis usually makes a claim. In an informative speech, the thematic statement may explain the main focus or central theme.

Example for an informative speech:

Sleep supports academic success by improving memory, strengthening focus, and helping students manage stress.

Example for a persuasive speech:

College students should treat sleep as part of academic preparation because it improves learning, performance, and emotional control.

The thesis should be clear, focused, and easy to understand. If the audience cannot identify the central idea of your speech, the speech will feel scattered.

USE A PREVIEW STATEMENT

A preview statement tells the audience the main points that will be covered. It gives the audience a roadmap.

Example:

First, we will look at how sleep improves memory. Second, we will examine how sleep affects focus. Finally, we will discuss how sleep helps students manage stress.

A strong preview helps the audience listen. It tells them what to expect and how the speech will unfold.

Avoid vague previews:

I will talk about sleep, school, and some other things.

That is not a preview. That is a fog machine.

A clearer preview names the specific direction of the speech.

PUTTING THE INTRODUCTION TOGETHER

A complete introduction often includes:

Attention-getter

Relevance statement

Speaker credibility

Thesis statement

Preview statement

Example:

Many students treat sleep like the thing they do after everything else is finished. Homework first. Work first. Phone first. Stress first. Sleep gets whatever time is left, which usually means sleep gets robbed.

Most college students have stayed up late to study, only to feel foggy, distracted, or overwhelmed the next day.

As a student, I have experienced how lack of sleep affects concentration and performance. I also researched sleep through public health and academic sources.

Sleep supports academic success by improving memory, strengthening focus, and helping students manage stress.

First, we will look at how sleep supports memory. Second, we will examine how sleep affects focus. Finally, we will discuss how sleep helps students manage stress.

Notice that each part has a job. The introduction gets attention, connects to the audience, builds credibility, states the central idea, and previews the structure.

CREATE A CONCLUSION

If the introduction opens the speech, the conclusion closes it. A strong conclusion helps the audience understand that the speech is ending and reinforces what they should remember.

Do not let your conclusion fade out awkwardly. Avoid endings such as:

That's it.

Yeah, so…

I guess I'm done.

That's all I have.

A conclusion should feel intentional. The audience should not have to guess whether the speech is over.

THE PURPOSE OF A CONCLUSION

A strong conclusion should do several things:

Signal the end of the speech.

Review the main points.

Reinforce the thesis or central idea.

Provide closure.

Leave the audience with a final thought, image, challenge, or call to action.

The conclusion is not the place to introduce a new main point. If you suddenly bring up brand-new information at the end, the audience may feel like the speech is trying to grow a second head.

SIGNAL THE ENDING

A speaker should clearly signal that the speech is moving toward the conclusion. This helps the audience prepare for closure.

Examples:

In conclusion…

As we bring this speech to a close…

To review…

As we have seen today…

Before I leave you with one final thought…

Signaling the ending does not need to be dramatic. It just needs to be clear.

SUMMARIZE WITH A REVIEW STATEMENT

A review statement reminds the audience of the main points. This is especially important because audiences remember only part of what they hear.

Example:

Today, we looked at three ways sleep supports academic success: it improves memory, strengthens focus, and helps students manage stress.

A review statement should be brief. Do not redeliver the whole speech. The conclusion is the landing, not another flight.

REINFORCE THE THESIS

After reviewing the main points, return to the central idea of the speech. This helps the audience remember the message.

Example:

Sleep is not wasted time. It is part of how students learn, perform, and recover.

The thesis reminder should sound natural, not copied and pasted from the introduction. It can be reworded to fit the conclusion.

SHOW THE BIG PICTURE

A conclusion can help the audience see the larger significance of the speech. Ask yourself:

What does this topic mean beyond the classroom?

What could happen if the audience applies this idea?

What could happen if they ignore it?

What future does this speech invite them to imagine?

Example:

If students begin treating sleep as part of academic preparation, they may not only perform better in school, but also feel more focused, more balanced, and more capable of handling pressure.

The big picture helps the speech feel meaningful rather than merely finished.

USE A CALL TO ACTION

A call to action challenges the audience to do something, think differently, or make a change. Calls to action are especially common in persuasive speeches, but informative speeches can also invite reflection or further learning.

Examples:

Tonight, choose one habit that will help you protect your sleep before your next exam.

The next time you see a shocking claim online, pause before sharing it and check the source.

Before your next presentation, practice your introduction and conclusion out loud at least three times.

A good call to action should be specific and realistic. Do not ask the audience to "change the world" unless you are giving them a clear place to start.

USE AN ATTENTION-GETTER REMINDER

An attention-getter reminder connects the conclusion back to the introduction. This creates a sense of unity and closure.

If you began with a story, return to the story.

If you began with a question, answer the question.

If you began with a quote, return to its meaning.

If you began with an image, bring that image back.

Example:

At the beginning of this speech, I described students treating sleep like the thing they do only after everything else is finished. But if sleep supports memory, focus, and stress management, then sleep should not be last on the list. It should be part of the plan.

This technique creates narrative symmetry. It makes the speech feel complete.

AVOID FALSE ENDINGS

A false ending happens when a speaker sounds like they are finishing, but then keeps going. This can frustrate the audience and weaken the final impact.

Avoid phrases like:

And finally…

One last thing…

Before I end…

Actually, I also wanted to say…

And another thing…

Once you signal the conclusion, conclude. Do not trap the audience in the speech version of a movie with seven endings.

PUTTING THE CONCLUSION TOGETHER

A complete conclusion often includes:

Signal phrase

Review statement

Thesis reminder

Big picture or call to action

Attention-getter reminder or final closing line

Example:

As we bring this speech to a close, remember the three ways sleep supports academic success: it improves memory, strengthens focus, and helps students manage stress.

Sleep is not wasted time. It is part of how students learn, perform, and recover.

The next time you are tempted to sacrifice sleep to study, remember that your brain is not a machine. It needs recovery to do the work you are asking it to do.

At the beginning of this speech, I said sleep often gets whatever time is left. But if we want to think clearly, perform well, and handle pressure, sleep cannot be an afterthought. Sleep is not the enemy of productivity. It is part of the strategy.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Introductions and conclusions are two of the most important parts of a speech. The introduction gives the audience a reason to listen and prepares them for the message. A strong introduction usually includes an attention-getter, relevance statement, speaker credibility, thesis or thematic statement, and preview statement.

Attention-getters may include quotations, stories, questions, surprising facts, humor, vivid descriptions, or curiosity-building statements. The attention-getter should fit the topic, audience, and occasion. Speakers should avoid apologizing, making excuses, or beginning with weak disclaimers.

The conclusion gives the speech closure and reinforces what the audience should remember. A strong conclusion usually signals the end, reviews the main points, reinforces the thesis, shows the big picture, offers a call to action when appropriate, and may return to the opening attention-getter.

Strong speakers rehearse the beginning and ending carefully. A confident opening helps the audience enter the speech. A purposeful ending helps the message stay with them.

KEY TERMS

Introduction

Conclusion

Attention-getter

Quotation

Story

Rhetorical question

Direct question

Humor

Relevance statement

Speaker credibility

Thesis statement

Thematic statement

Preview statement

Review statement

Thesis reminder

Big picture

Call to action

Attention-getter reminder

Closure

False ending

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why are the introduction and conclusion especially important in a speech?
2. What makes an attention-getter strong or weak?
3. Why should speakers avoid beginning with an apology or disclaimer?
4. How does a relevance statement help the audience care about the topic?
5. What is the difference between a thesis statement and a preview statement?
6. Why should a conclusion avoid introducing new main points?
7. How can an attention-getter reminder help a speech feel complete?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

INTRODUCTION PRACTICE

Choose a speech topic and write an introduction that includes:

1. Attention-getter.

2. Relevance statement.

3. Speaker credibility.

4. Thesis or thematic statement.

5. Preview statement.

After writing the introduction, answer:

1. Does the opening make the audience want to listen?

2. Does the introduction clearly connect the topic to the audience?

3. Does the speaker credibility sound honest and appropriate?

4. Is the thesis clear?

5. Does the preview identify the main points?

CONCLUSION PRACTICE

Using the same topic, write a conclusion that includes:

1. Signal phrase.

2. Review statement.

3. Thesis reminder.

4. Big picture statement or call to action.

5. Final closing line or attention-getter reminder.

After writing the conclusion, answer:

1. Does the conclusion clearly signal the end?

2. Does it review the main points without repeating too much?

3. Does it reinforce the central idea?

4. Does it end with purpose?

5. Does it avoid a false ending?

OPENING LINE CHALLENGE

Write three different opening lines for the same speech topic:

1. One using a question.

2. One using a story or scenario.

3. One using a surprising fact or statement.

Then choose the strongest opening and explain why it would work best for your audience.

Chapter 16

LANGUAGE

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why language matters in public speaking.
2. Use clear, simple, and specific language in a speech.
3. Distinguish between abstract and concrete language.
4. Use imagery, simile, metaphor, analogy, repetition, and alliteration appropriately.
5. Adapt language to the audience, occasion, and purpose.
6. Use inclusive and respectful language.
7. Avoid jargon, clichés, vague wording, and language that distracts from the message.

Word choice can make a presentation soar or bore. In a speech, language does more than fill time. It shapes how the audience understands your ideas, remembers your message, and responds to you as a speaker.

Public speaking is different from writing because listeners cannot easily go back and reread what you said. They hear the message once as it happens. For that reason, speeches should be written for the ear, not just the eye. A sentence that looks impressive on paper may sound stiff, confusing, or unnatural when spoken out loud.

Strong speech language is clear, specific, vivid, appropriate, and audience-centered. Your goal is not to sound complicated. Your goal is to be understood.

KEEP IT SIMPLE

Simple language is not weak language. Simple language is clear language.

Avoid using complicated words just to sound intelligent. If your audience has to work too hard to understand the sentence, they may stop listening. Public speaking rewards clarity. A speaker who explains a difficult idea simply usually sounds more prepared, not less.

Weak version:

The implementation of improved nocturnal behavioral routines may facilitate enhanced academic cognition.

Stronger version:

Better sleep habits can help students think more clearly in class.

The stronger version is easier to understand and easier to remember.

This does not mean every speech should sound casual or basic. Some topics require technical terms. If you use unfamiliar language, define it clearly before using it again. Once the audience understands the term, you can use it more confidently.

For example:

CRISPR is a gene-editing tool that allows scientists to make precise changes to DNA. Once we understand that basic definition, we can look at why CRISPR raises both medical possibilities and ethical concerns.

The speaker defines the term first, then builds on it.

AVOID JARGON

Jargon is specialized language used by people in a particular field, profession, or group. Jargon can be useful when speaking to experts, but it can confuse a general audience.

For example, a nurse, lawyer, mechanic, gamer, actor, or software engineer may use language that makes perfect sense within their field but sounds like a secret code to everyone else.

Weak version:

The patient presented with acute dyspnea and was placed on supplemental oxygen.

Stronger version:

The patient had sudden difficulty breathing, so doctors gave them extra oxygen.

The best speakers translate specialized knowledge into language the audience can understand.

Before using jargon, ask:

Does my audience already know this term?

Can I define it quickly?

Is there a simpler word?

Will this term help the audience or make them feel lost?

If the jargon does not help, cut it.

USE SPECIFIC LANGUAGE

Specific language helps the audience form a clear picture of what you mean. Vague language leaves too much room for interpretation.

Weak version:

A lot of students have problems with time management.

Stronger version:

Many students wait until the night before an assignment is due, then try to finish five hours of work in one exhausted sprint.

The stronger version gives the audience something concrete to imagine.

Specific language is especially important when you make claims. Words like things, stuff, bad, good, many, a lot, society, and people can be too vague unless you define them.

Weak version:

Social media affects people in bad ways.

Stronger version:

Heavy social media use can affect sleep, attention, and self-esteem, especially when students scroll late at night or compare themselves to unrealistic images.

The stronger version tells the audience exactly what the speaker means.

USE CONCRETE LANGUAGE

Concrete language refers to words that describe things people can see, hear, touch, taste, or smell. Abstract language refers to ideas or qualities that are harder to picture, such as justice, freedom, success, stress, love, or responsibility.

Abstract language is not wrong. Many important speeches deal with abstract ideas. But abstract ideas become more powerful when connected to concrete examples.

Abstract version:

Stress affects students.

Concrete version:

Stress is the student staring at a blank document at 1:00 a.m., knowing the assignment is due in seven hours.

The concrete version gives the audience a mental image.

If your speech includes abstract ideas, bring them down to earth. Give the audience examples, stories, images, comparisons, or details they can hold onto.

USE IMAGERY

Imagery is language that appeals to the senses. It helps the audience see, hear, feel, taste, or smell what the speaker is describing.

For example:

The room was silent except for the hum of the projector and the nervous tapping of my shoe against the floor.

That sentence gives the audience sound, setting, and mood.

Imagery can make a speech more memorable because it helps the audience experience the idea rather than simply hear about it. It is useful in introductions, stories, examples, ceremonial speeches, and persuasive appeals.

However, imagery should serve the message. Do not add decorative language just to sound poetic. A little vivid language can strengthen a speech. Too much can make the speech feel like it is wearing a cape indoors.

USE FIGURES OF SPEECH

Figures of speech are expressions that go beyond literal meaning to create emphasis, comparison, rhythm, or imagery. Common figures of speech include simile, metaphor, analogy, repetition, and alliteration.

SIMILE

A simile compares two things using like or as.

Example:

Speech anxiety can feel like standing under a spotlight with nowhere to hide.

The comparison helps the audience understand the feeling.

METAPHOR

A metaphor compares two things by saying one thing is another.

Example:

A strong outline is the skeleton of a speech.

The speech is not literally a body, and the outline is not literally a skeleton. The metaphor helps the audience understand structure.

ANALOGY

An analogy is an extended comparison used to explain something unfamiliar by comparing it to something familiar.

Example:

Think of a thesis statement like a destination on a map. If you do not know where you are going, your main points can take the audience in every direction except the right one.

Analogies are especially useful when explaining difficult concepts.

AVOID CLICHÉS

A cliché is an overused expression that has lost its force. Clichés may be familiar, but they often make a speech sound lazy or predictable.

Examples of clichés include:

At the end of the day

Think outside the box

It is what it is

Everything happens for a reason

Happy as a clam

Avoid it like the plague

Don’t judge a book by its cover

Some clichés are harmless in conversation, but speeches usually need fresher language. If the audience can predict the phrase before you finish saying it, consider revising it.

Weak version:

At the end of the day, public speaking is about thinking outside the box.

Stronger version:

Public speaking asks us to make clear choices: what to say, why it matters, and how to make the audience care.

The stronger version sounds more direct and original.

BE APPROPRIATE

Appropriate language fits the audience, occasion, topic, and speaker. A speech at a wedding, a classroom presentation, a job interview, a funeral, and a city council meeting all require different language choices.

Appropriate language does not always mean formal language. It means language that fits the situation.

A classroom speech may allow a conversational tone. A professional presentation may require more polished language. A ceremonial speech may use warmer or more elevated language. A persuasive speech on a serious issue may need language that is direct but respectful.

Ask:

Who is my audience?

What is the occasion?

How serious is the topic?

What tone will help my message?

What language might distract, confuse, or alienate listeners?

The goal is to sound like yourself at your best, not like a robot who swallowed a thesaurus.

USE INCLUSIVE LANGUAGE

Inclusive language recognizes and respects the diversity of the audience. It avoids unnecessary assumptions about people's identities, experiences, bodies, families, abilities, backgrounds, or beliefs.

Inclusive language does not mean making every sentence awkward or overly cautious. It means choosing words that help more listeners feel respected and included.

For example, instead of assuming everyone has a mother and father at home, you might say “parents or guardians.” Instead of assuming all students have reliable internet, you might say “students with regular internet access.” Instead of saying “mankind,” you might say “humanity” or “people.”

Inclusive speakers avoid language that stereotypes, demeans, mocks, or reduces people to a single characteristic. They also avoid using outdated terms when more respectful and accurate language is available.

A strong speaker does not need to agree with every audience member. But a strong speaker should avoid careless language that damages credibility or distracts from the message.

BE CAREFUL WITH SLANG, PROFANITY, AND HUMOR

Slang, casual language, and profanity may sometimes fit a speech, depending on the audience, topic, and occasion. But they require judgment.

Slang can make a speech sound current and conversational, but it can also become dated quickly or exclude listeners who do not understand it. Profanity may express intensity or realism, but it can also distract from the message or make the speaker seem less professional. Humor can build connection, but it can also damage credibility if it feels cruel, lazy, or inappropriate.

Before using slang, profanity, or edgy humor, ask:

Does this serve the speech?

Will this help the audience understand or connect?

Could this distract from my message?

Could this harm my credibility?

Is there a cleaner way to say this?

Do not shock the audience just to prove you are brave. That is not courage. That is verbal fireworks in a dry field.

USE REPETITION

Repetition can make a speech more memorable. Repeating an important word or phrase gives the speech rhythm and helps the audience remember the central idea.

One famous form of repetition is anaphora, which repeats a word or phrase at the beginning of successive clauses or sentences.

Example:

We need better preparation.

We need better practice.

We need better support.

The repetition creates rhythm and emphasis.

Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s "I Have a Dream" speech is one of the most famous examples of anaphora in American public address. The repeated phrase helped build emotional force and gave the speech a memorable structure.

Use repetition carefully. Repetition should reinforce an important idea, not fill space. If you repeat a phrase too often without purpose, it can become annoying instead of powerful.

USE ALLITERATION

Alliteration is the repetition of the same beginning sound in nearby words.

Example:

Clear claims create confidence.

Example:

Practice prevents panic.

Alliteration can make a phrase more memorable, but it should be used lightly. Too much alliteration sounds like a tongue twister escaped and took over the speech.

MAKE LANGUAGE SOUND SPOKEN

Speech language should sound natural when delivered out loud. A sentence may look good on the page but feel awkward when spoken.

Written version:

The necessity of preparation cannot be overstated in relation to the successful execution of oral communication assignments.

Spoken version:

Preparation matters because speeches are easier to deliver when you know what you are doing.

The spoken version is clearer and more direct.

To prepare language for speaking:

Use shorter sentences.

Choose familiar words when possible.

Define unfamiliar terms.

Read the speech out loud.

Revise sentences that make you stumble.

Listen for rhythm and clarity.

Use contractions when appropriate.

Avoid sentences that sound like they were built by a committee.

If you cannot say the sentence naturally, rewrite it.

ADAPT LANGUAGE TO THE AUDIENCE

Audience-centered speakers choose language based on who is listening. The same topic may require different language for different audiences.

For example, a speech about theater might use technical terms such as blocking, objective, subtext, or dramaturgy when speaking to actors. But for a general audience, the speaker should define those terms or use simpler explanations.

A speech about personal finance might use different examples for high school students, college students, working adults, or retirees. A speech about health may need different language for medical professionals than for a general public audience.

Adapting language does not mean talking down to the audience. It means meeting the audience where they are and helping them move toward understanding.

CHOOSE ETHICAL LANGUAGE

Language has consequences. Speakers should use language ethically by avoiding deception, exaggeration, stereotyping, name-calling, and deliberate distortion.

Ethical language should be:

Accurate

Respectful

Clear

Fair

Appropriate

Inclusive

Supported by evidence

This is especially important when speaking about controversial topics or groups of people. The more emotionally charged the topic, the more carefully the speaker should choose words.

Ethical speakers can be passionate without being reckless. They can be forceful without being cruel. They can challenge an audience without insulting them.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Language plays a major role in public speaking. Because audiences hear a speech in real time, speakers must use language that is clear, specific, vivid, appropriate, and audience-centered.

Simple language helps audiences understand complex ideas. Specific and concrete language helps listeners form clear mental pictures. Imagery and figures of speech such as simile, metaphor, analogy, repetition, and alliteration can make a message more memorable when used carefully.

Speakers should avoid unnecessary jargon, clichés, vague wording, and language that distracts from the message. They should also use inclusive and ethical language that respects the audience and fits the occasion.

Strong speech language sounds natural when spoken aloud. The best speakers do not use language to show off. They use language to connect.

KEY TERMS

Language

Word choice

Jargon

Specific language

Concrete language

Abstract language

Imagery

Figure of speech

Simile

Metaphor

Analogy

Cliché

Appropriate language

Inclusive language

Slang

Profanity

Repetition

Anaphora

Alliteration

Audience-centered language

Ethical language

Oral style

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why should speeches be written for the ear rather than only for the eye?
2. What is the difference between abstract and concrete language?
3. Why can jargon be useful for one audience but confusing for another?
4. How can imagery make a speech more memorable?
5. What is the difference between a simile, metaphor, and analogy?
6. Why should speakers be careful with slang, profanity, and humor?
7. How does inclusive language strengthen speaker credibility?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

LANGUAGE REVISION PRACTICE

Revise each sentence to make it clearer and more specific.

1. Social media has a lot of bad effects on people.

2. Students should do better things with their time.

3. Public speaking is very important in life.

4. There are many issues with education today.

5. Exercise helps people in many ways.

For each sentence, ask:

1. What is vague?

2. What could be more specific?

3. What concrete example could help?

4. Would this sentence sound natural out loud?

IMAGERY PRACTICE

Choose one of the following topics and write three vivid sentences that appeal to the senses:

Speech anxiety

A crowded classroom

A late-night study session

A family celebration

A job interview

A city street

A theater stage before a performance

Use at least two sensory details.

AUDIENCE ADAPTATION PRACTICE

Choose one topic and explain it to two different audiences.

Topic options:

Artificial intelligence

Budgeting money

Theater rehearsal

Healthy sleep

Social media

Public speaking anxiety

Audience A: A group of college students

Audience B: A group of professionals

Write two short explanations. Then answer:

1. How did your word choice change?

2. What terms did you define?

3. What examples did you use for each audience?

4. Which version sounded more natural? Why?

Chapter 17

METHODS OF DELIVERY

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why delivery matters in public speaking.
2. Describe the relationship between preparation, authenticity, and confidence.
3. Identify the four basic methods of delivery.
4. Explain the strengths and limitations of manuscript speaking.
5. Explain the strengths and limitations of memorized speaking.
6. Explain the strengths and limitations of impromptu speaking.
7. Explain why extemporaneous speaking is often the preferred method for classroom speeches.
8. Use delivery choices that help a speech sound natural, prepared, and audience-centered.

Many people feel nervous at the idea of delivering a speech. That reaction is normal. Public speaking can feel intense because the audience is watching, listening, and evaluating what we say. Even experienced speakers can feel that pressure.

An effective delivery depends on more than simply saying the words correctly. Delivery is the way a speaker presents a message through voice, body, eye contact, movement, facial expression, pacing, energy, and presence. A strong delivery helps the audience understand the message and trust the speaker.

The best delivery usually feels conversational, not robotic. That does not mean casual, careless, or improvised. It means the speaker sounds like a real person communicating with other real people. A prepared speaker can still sound natural. In fact, preparation is often what allows a speaker to relax enough to be natural.

BE AUTHENTIC AND ENERGETIC

Do not think of a speech as a stiff formal performance where you pretend to be someone else. Think of it as a prepared conversation with a purpose. You are still speaking to people, not delivering words into the void.

Authenticity means the speaker's delivery feels honest, present, and connected to the message. It does not mean "just wing it" or "do whatever feels comfortable." A speaker can be authentic and still organized, polished, and professional.

Energy also matters. Speakers who care about their topic are easier to listen to. Energy does not mean yelling, pacing, or trying to become a motivational speaker trapped in a coffee commercial. It means bringing enough focus, vocal life, and physical presence to make the audience feel that the message matters.

To sound authentic and energetic:

Focus on the message, not only on yourself.

Speak to the audience, not at the audience.

Use direct and meaningful eye contact.

Let your voice show interest in the topic.

Use facial expressions that match the message.

Stand or move with purpose.

Avoid hiding behind notes, slides, or the podium.

Practice enough that you can speak naturally.

When you focus only on how you are being judged, anxiety often increases. When you focus on what you want the audience to understand, your delivery usually improves.

DELIVERY IS AUDIENCE-CENTERED

Good delivery is not about showing off. It is about helping the audience receive the message.

A speaker may feel more comfortable reading from a full script, but if reading causes weak eye contact and flat vocal delivery, the audience may struggle to stay engaged. A speaker may enjoy walking around the room, but if the movement becomes distracting, it hurts the message. A speaker may love humor, but if the audience or occasion does not fit the joke, the delivery choice fails.

Audience-centered delivery asks:

Can the audience hear me?

Can they follow my ideas?

Does my delivery match the topic?

Does my tone fit the occasion?

Am I making it easier or harder for people to listen?

Do my notes support me or trap me?

Does my delivery help the message land?

Delivery choices should serve the speech.

METHODS OF DELIVERY

There are four basic methods of delivery:

Manuscript speaking

Memorized speaking

Impromptu speaking

Extemporaneous speaking

Each method has strengths and limitations. The best method depends on the situation, assignment, audience, and purpose.

MANUSCRIPT SPEAKING

Manuscript speaking means reading a speech word for word from a prepared text. The speaker writes out the entire speech and delivers it exactly as written.

Manuscript delivery can be useful when precise language is necessary. For example, politicians, public officials, broadcasters, executives, attorneys, and organizational leaders may read from prepared remarks when accuracy matters. A speaker may also use manuscript delivery for formal ceremonies, public statements, legal announcements, crisis communication, or highly sensitive topics.

Manuscript speaking has advantages:

It allows precise wording.

It helps avoid accidental misstatements.

It can be useful for formal or official occasions.

It helps speakers stay within carefully planned language.

It can support complex or sensitive information.

However, manuscript speaking also has limitations:

It can reduce eye contact.

It can limit gestures and movement.

It can make the speaker sound flat or disconnected.

It can make the speech feel read rather than spoken.

It can prevent the speaker from adapting to audience feedback.

In most classroom speeches, manuscript delivery should be used rarely unless the assignment specifically calls for it. Public speaking is usually stronger when the speaker knows the material well enough to speak directly to the audience.

If you must use manuscript delivery, practice reading the text out loud several times. Mark places to pause. Underline words that need emphasis. Look up regularly. Write in a style that sounds spoken, not like an essay being dragged across the room.

MEMORIZED SPEAKING

Memorized speaking, sometimes called oratory, means delivering a speech from memory. The speaker writes or prepares the speech ahead of time, memorizes it, and then presents it without notes.

Memorized delivery can be useful for short speeches, ceremonial remarks, performances, competitions, introductions, toasts, or moments when exact wording matters. Memorizing part of a speech can also be helpful. Many speakers memorize the opening, closing, key transitions, or important quotations.

Memorized speaking has advantages:

It allows strong eye contact.

It can sound polished when delivered well.

It can be powerful for short formal speeches.

It helps the speaker avoid relying heavily on notes.

It can create a strong opening or conclusion.

However, memorized speaking also has risks:

The speaker may sound rehearsed rather than natural.

The speaker may focus more on remembering words than communicating ideas.

If the speaker forgets one line, they may freeze.

The delivery may become stiff or overly performed.

The speaker may look above the audience while trying to remember the script.

Memorizing an entire speech word for word is usually not necessary for classroom speaking. It can create pressure because the speaker becomes attached to exact wording. If one word disappears, panic enters like it owns the place.

A better approach is to memorize the structure, not every sentence. Know the introduction, main points, transitions, evidence, and conclusion. Practice the language enough that it feels familiar, but allow yourself to speak naturally.

IMPROMPTU SPEAKING

Impromptu speaking is speaking with little or no formal preparation. It is spontaneous, improvised, or delivered on short notice.

Impromptu speaking happens often in everyday life. You may be asked to answer a question in class, speak during a meeting, introduce yourself, respond to feedback, explain a decision, fill in for someone, or give a quick opinion during a discussion.

Impromptu speaking has advantages:

It teaches quick thinking.

It helps speakers adapt to unexpected situations.

It can sound natural and conversational.

It builds confidence under pressure.

It prepares speakers for real-world communication.

However, impromptu speaking also has limitations:

Ideas may be disorganized.

The speaker may ramble.

Evidence may be weak or missing.

The speaker may rely too much on filler words.

The response may lack a clear beginning, middle, and end.

When speaking impromptu, take a moment before you begin. A short pause is better than a rushed mess. Think about the question, choose a simple structure, and answer with a clear point.

A useful impromptu structure is:

Point

Reason

Example

Restatement

Example:

Point: I think students should practice presentations out loud before speech day.

Reason: Speaking out loud reveals problems that silent reading does not.

Example: A sentence may look fine on paper but feel awkward when spoken.

Restatement: That is why rehearsal should happen out loud, not just in your head.

This simple structure can help you organize your thoughts quickly.

EXTEMPORANEOUS SPEAKING

Extemporaneous speaking is carefully prepared and practiced, but not memorized word for word. The speaker uses a speaking outline or brief notes while delivering the speech in a natural, conversational style.

Extemporaneous speaking is often the preferred method for classroom speeches because it balances preparation and flexibility. The speaker knows the topic, structure, evidence, and main ideas, but still speaks directly to the audience.

Extemporaneous speaking has advantages:

It sounds natural and conversational.

It allows strong eye contact.

It gives the speaker freedom to gesture and move.

It allows adaptation to audience feedback.

It helps the speaker stay organized without reading.

It shows preparation and control.

Extemporaneous speaking also has challenges:

The speaker may struggle to find the right words.

The speech may become longer than planned.

The speaker may repeat ideas.

The speaker may rely too heavily on notes.

The speaker may lose track without enough rehearsal.

The best way to handle these challenges is to practice with a speaking outline. Do not practice from the full written speech if you plan to deliver extemporaneously. Practice from the same notes you will use during delivery.

Extemporaneous delivery is not winging it. It is prepared flexibility.

COMPARING THE FOUR METHODS

Each delivery method works best in different situations.

Manuscript delivery is best when exact wording is necessary.

Memorized delivery is best for short, polished moments or when exact language must be delivered without notes.

Impromptu delivery is best for short, spontaneous responses.

Extemporaneous delivery is best for most classroom, workplace, and public presentations because it allows the speaker to be prepared and conversational.

A strong speaker knows how to use all four methods when appropriate. The goal is not to choose the method that feels easiest. The goal is to choose the method that best serves the audience, topic, and occasion.

DEVELOP A CONVERSATIONAL STYLE

A conversational style does not mean speaking casually without structure. It means sounding like you are communicating with the audience rather than reciting at them.

To develop a conversational style:

Know your main ideas.

Practice out loud.

Use a speaking outline.

Avoid memorizing every word.

Look at the audience while completing a thought.

Pause instead of using filler words.

Let your voice rise and fall naturally.

Use language that sounds spoken.

Adapt when the audience responds.

A conversational speaker still has purpose and control. The difference is that the delivery feels alive.

USE NOTES WISELY

Notes should help you deliver the speech, not become the speech. If your notes contain full paragraphs, you may be tempted to read. If your notes are too brief, you may forget important material. The goal is to find the right balance.

Good speaking notes may include:

Keywords

Short phrases

Source citations

Statistics

Transition cues

Delivery cues

Slide cues

Timing reminders

Weak notes contain too much text or too little structure. Strong notes help the speaker glance down, remember the next idea, and return attention to the audience.

PRACTICE WITH THE DELIVERY METHOD YOU PLAN TO USE

Your rehearsal should match your delivery method. If you plan to deliver extemporaneously, practice from a speaking outline. If you plan to use slides, practice with the slides. If you plan to stand, practice standing. If you plan to use a microphone, practice with one if possible.

Do not prepare one way and perform another. That is how speakers get surprised by their own speech.

Practice should help you answer these questions:

Can I explain each main point without reading?

Can I remember my transitions?

Can I cite sources clearly?

Can I stay within the time limit?

Can I recover if I lose my place?

Can I sound natural while staying organized?

Rehearsal turns delivery from a mystery into a routine.

ADAPT DURING DELIVERY

Even a prepared speech may require adjustment. Audience members may look confused, laugh, nod, check out, ask questions, or react differently than expected. A speaker who is too tied to a manuscript may miss these signals. A speaker who knows the material can adapt.

Adaptation might include:

Pausing longer after a complex point.

Repeating an important idea.

Explaining an unfamiliar term.

Skipping a less important example if time is short.

Slowing down when the audience looks confused.

Moving on when the audience already understands.

Adjusting energy to fit the room.

Adaptation does not mean abandoning the speech. It means responding to the actual speaking situation.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Delivery is the way a speaker presents a message through voice, body, eye contact, movement, facial expression, pacing, energy, and presence. Strong delivery helps the audience understand and trust the message.

The four basic methods of delivery are manuscript speaking, memorized speaking, impromptu speaking, and extemporaneous speaking. Manuscript speaking uses a fully written text. Memorized speaking requires the speaker to deliver from memory. Impromptu speaking happens with little or no preparation. Extemporaneous speaking is prepared and practiced but delivered conversationally from brief notes.

Each method has strengths and limitations. Manuscript and memorized delivery can be useful when precise language matters, but they can also make speakers sound stiff or disconnected. Impromptu speaking helps speakers think quickly, but it may lack organization. Extemporaneous speaking is often preferred for classroom speeches because it balances preparation, flexibility, and natural delivery.

Strong speakers practice with the method they plan to use. They use notes wisely, focus on the audience, and adapt when necessary.

KEY TERMS

Delivery

Authenticity

Energy

Audience-centered delivery

Manuscript speaking

Memorized speaking

Oratory

Impromptu speaking

Extemporaneous speaking

Speaking outline

Conversational style

Delivery notes

Filler words

Adaptation

Eye contact

Vocal variety

Presence

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does delivery matter in public speaking?

2. What does it mean for delivery to be audience-centered?

3. What are the advantages and disadvantages of manuscript speaking?

4. When might memorized speaking be useful?

5. Why is impromptu speaking an important skill outside the classroom?

6. Why is extemporaneous speaking often the best method for classroom speeches?

7. How can notes help or hurt a speaker's delivery?

8. What are some ways a speaker can adapt during delivery?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

DELIVERY METHOD PRACTICE

Choose one topic and prepare a one-minute explanation using each method:

1. Manuscript: Write the full explanation and read it word for word.

2. Memorized: Memorize the explanation and deliver it without notes.

3. Impromptu: Give a response with only ten seconds of preparation.

4. Extemporaneous: Prepare a brief speaking outline and deliver from notes.

After trying each method, answer:

1. Which method felt most natural?

2. Which method felt most controlled?

3. Which method helped you make the most eye contact?

4. Which method made you sound most conversational?

5. Which method would work best for a classroom speech? Why?

SPEAKING OUTLINE PRACTICE

Create a short speaking outline for a two-minute speech. Include:

1. Opening idea.

2. Three main points.

3. One source reminder.

4. One transition.

5. Closing idea.

Practice delivering the speech out loud twice. After the second attempt, remove any words from the outline that tempted you to read too much.

IMPROMPTU STRUCTURE PRACTICE

Answer one of the following questions using the point-reason-example-restatement structure:

1. Should students be required to take a public speaking course?
2. Is practicing out loud better than silently reading an outline?
3. Should speakers use humor in serious speeches?
4. Is confidence more important than preparation?
5. What makes a speaker memorable?

Structure your answer like this:

Point: State your answer clearly.

Reason: Explain why.

Example: Give a specific example.

Restatement: End by repeating your main idea in a fresh way.

Chapter 18

THE VOICE

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why vocal delivery matters in public speaking.
2. Use appropriate volume for the room, audience, and occasion.
3. Explain how pitch affects meaning and audience perception.
4. Control speaking rate so the audience can follow the message.
5. Use pauses to emphasize ideas and give listeners time to process information.
6. Use vocal variety to make a speech more engaging.
7. Distinguish between pronunciation and articulation.
8. Practice vocal exercises that improve clarity and confidence.

No matter how important your content is, if the audience cannot hear or understand you, the message will suffer. Vocal delivery is one of the most important parts of public speaking because it affects clarity, energy, credibility, and audience attention.

Your voice carries the speech. It helps the audience know what matters, when to listen closely, when an idea is changing, and how you feel about the message. A strong voice does not mean a loud voice. It means a voice that is clear, expressive, controlled, and appropriate for the speaking situation.

As you rehearse, pay attention to the major elements of vocal delivery: volume, pitch, rate, pausing, vocal variety, pronunciation, and articulation. These elements work together. When used well, they help your speech sound confident and conversational. When ignored, they can make even strong content difficult to follow.

VOLUME

Volume refers to how loudly or softly you speak. It is usually one of the first things an audience notices. If you speak too softly, listeners may strain to hear you. If you speak too loudly, you may overwhelm the room. The goal is to be heard clearly without sounding like you are yelling at people who simply showed up to learn something.

Good volume depends on the space, audience size, background noise, and whether you are using a microphone. A small classroom may require only moderate projection. A large lecture hall, auditorium, or outdoor space may require stronger projection or amplification.

Do not assume your normal conversational volume is enough. Public speaking usually requires more vocal energy than everyday conversation. You may need to speak slightly louder than feels natural at first, especially if you are nervous or speaking in a larger room.

Use audience feedback to adjust. If people are leaning forward, looking confused, or asking you to repeat yourself, you may need more volume. If people are pulling back or reacting as if the sound is too intense, reduce your volume.

A useful rehearsal strategy is to practice in the actual room when possible. Stand where you will speak and ask someone to sit near the back. If they cannot hear you clearly, adjust before speech day.

PITCH

Pitch refers to how high or low your voice sounds. Pitch helps communicate emotion, emphasis, and meaning. A speaker's pitch naturally rises and falls during conversation. This movement helps the voice sound alive.

A monotone voice has little pitch variation. Monotone delivery can make a speaker sound bored, detached, or robotic, even when the content is interesting. If your voice stays at the same level for too long, the audience may have trouble identifying what is important.

Instead of forcing yourself to speak in a lower or higher voice, aim for a natural and supported pitch. Your voice should sound like you, but with enough energy and variation to carry the message.

Pitch can change meaning. For example, the sentence "That was a great idea" can sound sincere, doubtful, sarcastic, or excited depending on how the speaker uses pitch. The words stay the same, but the vocal delivery changes the meaning.

Use pitch to support your message. Let your voice rise when asking a question, shift when introducing a new idea, and deepen or soften when the subject be-

comes serious. The goal is not to perform a character. The goal is to let your voice reflect the meaning of your words.

RATE

Rate refers to how fast or slowly you speak. There is no single perfect speaking rate for every speaker or every speech. The best rate depends on the audience, topic, room, and purpose.

If you speak too quickly, the audience may struggle to follow your ideas. Fast speaking can make you sound nervous or rushed. It can also cause words to run together, which weakens clarity.

If you speak too slowly, the audience may become restless or lose focus. A slow rate can be useful for serious or complex ideas, but if the entire speech crawls, listeners may check out.

The goal is a balanced rate with purposeful variation. Move more slowly when explaining complex material, giving important evidence, or making an emotional point. You can move more quickly through familiar material, transitions, or lighter examples.

When rehearsing, time your speech out loud. Silent reading is not enough. Many speakers discover that their actual speaking rate is very different from what they imagined.

PAUSING

Pausing is one of the most powerful tools in vocal delivery. A pause gives the audience time to process information. It also gives the speaker a moment to breathe, think, and transition.

Pauses can be used to:

Emphasize an important idea.

Separate one main point from another.

Give the audience time to think.

Create suspense or curiosity.

Allow laughter or reaction to settle.

Replace filler words.

Signal that something important is coming.

For example:

The most important part of delivery is not perfection.

It is connection.

The pause before the second sentence gives the idea more weight.

Many beginning speakers fear silence, so they fill every gap with “um,” “uh,” “like,” “you know,” or “so.” Filler words are common, and everyone uses them oc-

casionally. But too many fillers can distract the audience and make the speaker sound less prepared.

A pause is usually stronger than a filler word. Silence may feel longer to the speaker than it does to the audience. What feels like three years in your head may only be one second in the room.

Use pauses naturally. Do not insert dramatic pauses after every sentence or the speech will start sounding like a trailer for a movie no one asked for. Pause where the meaning needs space.

VOCAL VARIETY

Vocal variety refers to changes in volume, pitch, rate, and pausing. Variety keeps the voice interesting and helps the audience follow the message.

A speech without vocal variety can sound flat. Even if the information is strong, the audience may struggle to stay engaged. A speech with strong vocal variety feels more dynamic because the voice changes with the ideas.

Vocal variety can help a speaker:

Show enthusiasm.

Emphasize key points.

Signal transitions.

Clarify emotional tone.

Maintain audience attention.

Make the speech sound conversational.

For example, a speaker might slow down and lower volume when telling a serious story, then increase energy when moving into a solution. A speaker might pause before stating the thesis. A speaker might raise pitch slightly when asking a question.

The best vocal variety comes from understanding your message. If you know what each part of the speech is doing, your voice can help guide the audience through it.

PRONUNCIATION

Pronunciation refers to saying words correctly according to accepted usage or the intended language. Mispronouncing a word can distract the audience, especially if the word is central to the topic.

If you are unsure how to pronounce a word, look it up and practice it out loud. This is especially important for names, places, technical terms, authors, organizations, and words from languages you do not speak.

Do not guess on someone's name. Names deserve care. If possible, ask how the person pronounces their name or check a reliable source. Mispronouncing a name may seem small to the speaker, but it can signal carelessness to the audience.

Pronunciation practice is part of preparation. If your speech includes difficult words, mark them in your outline and say them repeatedly until they feel natural.

ARTICULATION

Articulation refers to how clearly you form sounds and words. Good articulation helps the audience understand you. Poor articulation can make words sound blurred, swallowed, or unfinished.

Mumbling is one of the most common articulation problems. It often happens when speakers are nervous, tired, underprepared, or speaking too softly. When volume drops and words are not clearly formed, the audience has to work harder to listen.

To improve articulation:

Open your mouth enough to shape the words.

Finish the ends of words.

Slow down slightly when needed.

Emphasize consonants clearly.

Practice difficult phrases out loud.

Record yourself and listen for unclear words.

Warm up before speaking.

You do not need to over-enunciate every syllable like you are announcing a royal decree. The goal is clear, natural speech.

VOCAL ENERGY

Vocal energy is the life in your voice. It does not mean shouting or being overly dramatic. It means your voice has enough strength, focus, and intention to hold the room.

Low vocal energy can make a speaker sound uninterested, even if they care about the topic. Strong vocal energy tells the audience that the message deserves attention.

Vocal energy comes from breath, posture, preparation, and commitment to the message. If your body collapses, your voice often collapses with it. Stand or sit with good posture, breathe fully, and speak through the end of each sentence.

A simple rule: do not let your voice disappear at the ends of sentences. Many speakers start strong but fade out before the thought is finished. The audience needs the whole sentence, not just the opening bid.

BREATHING AND SUPPORT

Good vocal delivery begins with breath. Nervous speakers often breathe shallowly, which can make the voice sound thin, shaky, or rushed. Deep, controlled breathing helps the speaker sound steadier.

Before speaking, take a slow breath. During the speech, breathe at natural pauses. Do not try to get through long sections without breathing. That is not public speaking; that is underwater survival with citations.

Breath support helps with volume, pacing, and confidence. You do not need to become a trained singer to improve your breath. You simply need to avoid holding your breath or rushing through sentences without air.

Try this simple exercise:

Stand with your feet grounded.

Relax your shoulders.

Inhale slowly through your nose.

Exhale while saying one full sentence clearly.

Pause.

Repeat with the next sentence.

This trains your body to connect breath with speech.

WARM UP YOUR VOICE

Athletes warm up before competition. Musicians warm up before performance. Speakers should warm up before presenting too.

A vocal warm-up prepares the voice, mouth, tongue, face, and breath. It can also help reduce nervous tension.

Useful warm-ups include:

Gentle humming.

Lip trills.

Slow deep breathing.

Reading the opening paragraph out loud.

Practicing difficult words.

Repeating tongue twisters.

Stretching the jaw, face, and neck.

Speaking the first sentence several times with energy.

Tongue twisters can help improve articulation. Examples include:

Red leather, yellow leather.

Unique New York.

Toy boat.

She sells seashells by the seashore.

Clear claims create confidence.

Say them slowly first. Speed is not the goal. Clarity is the goal.

Some speakers practice articulation by gently holding a clean cork between their teeth while speaking a short passage, then removing it and repeating the passage normally. If you try this, do it carefully and briefly. The purpose is to wake up the muscles involved in speech, not to turn rehearsal into dental combat.

PRACTICE VOCAL DELIVERY

Vocal delivery improves through rehearsal. Reading the speech silently does not train your voice. You need to practice out loud.

As you rehearse, ask:

Can I be heard clearly?

Am I speaking too quickly?

Do I pause after important ideas?

Does my voice change with the meaning?

Do I pronounce key terms correctly?

Are my words clear?

Do I sound interested in my own topic?

Do I fade out at the ends of sentences?

Do I use too many filler words?

Recording yourself can be uncomfortable, but it is useful. Listen for volume, pace, clarity, and variety. You may notice habits you were unaware of, such as rushing, mumbling, trailing off, or sounding flat.

The goal is not to hate your own voice. Most people dislike hearing recordings of themselves at first. The goal is to hear what the audience hears and make adjustments.

ADAPTING TO MICROPHONES

If you use a microphone, your vocal delivery still matters. A microphone amplifies your voice, but it does not create energy, clarity, or expression for you.

When using a microphone:

Test it before speaking if possible.

Keep a consistent distance from the microphone.

Do not tap or blow into it.

Speak clearly and naturally.

Avoid turning your head away while speaking.

Pause if there is feedback or a technical issue.

Do not assume the microphone fixes mumbling.

A microphone helps the audience hear you. It does not do the speaking for you.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Vocal delivery affects how clearly and effectively an audience receives a speech. The major elements of vocal delivery include volume, pitch, rate, pausing, vocal variety, pronunciation, and articulation.

Volume refers to how loudly or softly a speaker speaks. Pitch refers to how high or low the voice sounds. Rate refers to speaking speed. Pausing helps create emphasis and gives the audience time to process ideas. Vocal variety combines changes in volume, pitch, rate, and pauses to keep the speech engaging.

Pronunciation refers to saying words correctly. Articulation refers to forming words clearly. Both are important for audience understanding. Speakers can improve vocal delivery by rehearsing out loud, warming up the voice, practicing difficult words, recording themselves, and adapting to the room or microphone.

A strong voice is not about sounding perfect. It is about sounding clear, expressive, prepared, and connected to the message.

KEY TERMS

Vocal delivery

Volume

Projection

Pitch

Monotone

Rate

Pausing

Filler words

Vocal variety

Pronunciation

Articulation

Mumbling

Vocal energy

Breath support

Vocal warm-up

Tongue twister

Microphone technique

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does vocal delivery matter in public speaking?
2. How can a speaker know whether their volume is appropriate?
3. Why is a monotone voice difficult for audiences to listen to?
4. How can speaking rate help or hurt audience understanding?
5. Why are pauses often stronger than filler words?
6. What is the difference between pronunciation and articulation?
7. How can vocal warm-ups improve delivery?
8. What should speakers remember when using a microphone?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

VOCAL DELIVERY SELF-CHECK

Practice one minute of your speech out loud. Record yourself and listen back. Then answer:

1. Was your volume strong enough?

2. Was your rate too fast, too slow, or balanced?

3. Did your voice include variety?

4. Did you pause after important ideas?

5. Were any words unclear?

6. Did your voice fade at the ends of sentences?

7. What is one vocal habit you want to improve?

ARTICULATION PRACTICE

Read the following sentences out loud slowly and clearly:

1. Clear claims create confidence.

2. Red leather, yellow leather.

3. Unique New York.

4. Practice prevents panic.

5. The speaker should slow down before the strongest sentence.

Then choose three difficult words from your own speech and practice saying each one five times.

PAUSE PRACTICE

Choose one important sentence from your speech. Practice saying it three different ways:

1. With no pause.

2. With a pause before the key word.

3. With a pause after the sentence.

Then answer:

1. Which version sounded strongest?

2. Where did the pause help the meaning?

3. Where did the pause feel unnatural?

4. How can you use pauses more intentionally in your speech?

Chapter 19

THE BODY

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain why physical delivery matters in public speaking.
2. Use facial expressions that support the meaning and tone of a speech.
3. Use eye contact to build connection with an audience.
4. Use gestures naturally and purposefully.
5. Move with intention during a speech.
6. Choose clothing and appearance choices that fit the occasion.
7. Practice physical delivery in a way that reduces anxiety and strengthens confidence.
8. Focus physical delivery on the message rather than self-consciousness.

Physical delivery refers to how speakers use the body while presenting a speech. This includes facial expressions, eye contact, gestures, posture, movement, appearance, and physical presence.

Audiences do not only listen to words. They also watch the speaker. A speaker's physical delivery can affect whether the audience sees the speaker as confident, prepared, interested, nervous, disconnected, or sincere. Even strong content can lose impact if the speaker appears uninterested, frozen, distracted, or physically closed off.

Physical delivery should support the message. The goal is not to perform fake confidence or copy someone else's style. The goal is to look present, prepared, and connected to the audience.

FACIAL EXPRESSIONS

Facial expressions help communicate emotion, interest, and meaning. Audiences often look to the speaker's face to understand how they should respond to the message. If your face does not match your words, the audience may feel confused or disconnected.

For example, if you are giving a lighthearted introduction, a relaxed smile may help build rapport. If you are discussing a serious topic, a steady and focused expression may be more appropriate. If you are telling a personal story, your facial expression should reflect the emotional tone of that story.

Smiling can help a speaker appear welcoming and approachable, but it should fit the moment. A smile during a friendly greeting can build warmth. A smile during a painful or serious example may feel inappropriate.

The key is alignment. Your facial expressions should match your topic, purpose, and tone. Do not force expressions that feel fake, but do not let nerves erase your face completely either. A blank expression can make a speaker seem uninterested, even when they care deeply about the topic.

EYE CONTACT

Eye contact is one of the most important tools for building connection with an audience. It helps listeners feel included and shows that the speaker is speaking to them, not merely reciting words in their direction.

Strong eye contact does not mean staring intensely at one person until they begin questioning their life choices. It means looking at audience members long enough to complete a thought, then moving naturally to another part of the room.

Try to make eye contact for a full phrase or sentence. This helps you connect ideas to people. Looking up for half a second and then immediately looking back down at your notes is not meaningful eye contact. It is a drive-by glance.

In a small audience, try to include people from different parts of the room. In a larger audience, it may not be possible to make direct eye contact with every listener. Instead, look at different sections of the room and connect with several individuals throughout the speech. This creates the feeling that the entire audience is included.

Avoid these eye contact habits:

Looking only at the instructor.

Looking only at friends.

Looking over everyone’s heads.

Reading from notes the entire time.

Staring at the slides instead of the audience.

Scanning the room too quickly without landing anywhere.

Eye contact can feel uncomfortable at first, but it becomes easier with practice. Remember that the audience is not a single monster with many faces. It is a group of individual people listening one moment at a time.

GESTURES

Gestures are movements of the hands, arms, shoulders, or body that help express meaning. Good gestures can emphasize ideas, show size or direction, clarify relationships, and add energy to the speech.

For example, if you are describing a large increase, your hands might move upward. If you are comparing two ideas, you might gesture to one side for the first idea and the other side for the second. If you are numbering main points, you might count them with your fingers.

The best gestures usually feel natural. They come from the meaning of the words. Forced gestures can look stiff or theatrical. No gesture at all can make a speaker look tense or disconnected.

Your gestures should be:

Visible

Purposeful

Natural

Appropriate to the topic

Consistent with your personality

Large enough for the audience to see

Controlled enough not to distract

Avoid distracting gestures such as fidgeting with clothing, playing with hair, clicking a pen, jangling keys, gripping note cards too tightly, or repeatedly adjusting glasses, watches, or jewelry. These movements often come from nervous energy. They may feel small to you, but the audience may start watching the habit instead of listening to the speech.

If you do not know what to do with your hands, begin in a neutral position. Let your hands rest naturally near your sides or lightly together. Then gesture when the speech gives you a reason to gesture.

POSTURE

Posture affects how the audience sees the speaker and how the speaker uses the voice. A collapsed posture can make the speaker look unsure and can weaken vocal energy. A tense posture can make the speaker look uncomfortable. A strong posture helps the speaker look grounded and ready.

Good speaking posture usually means:

Stand with feet grounded.

Keep shoulders relaxed.

Face the audience.

Avoid locking the knees.

Keep the chest open.

Avoid slouching or leaning away from the audience.

Hold notes in a way that does not cover your face.

Posture should look confident but not stiff. You are not a statue guarding a museum. You are a speaker communicating with people.

BODY MOVEMENT

Movement can help create energy and connection, but it must have a purpose. Audiences can become bored watching a speaker stay frozen behind a podium, but they can also become distracted by a speaker who paces without control.

Move with intention.

Purposeful movement might include:

Stepping closer during an important point.

Moving to one side when transitioning to a new main point.

Turning toward a visual aid.

Returning to center for the conclusion.

Using space to show contrast between ideas.

Avoid pacing back and forth like an animal at the zoo. Pacing usually signals nervousness, not confidence. If movement does not support the message, it becomes visual noise.

A helpful rule is to move during transitions, then plant your feet while making an important point. This gives movement structure. It also prevents wandering.

USING SPACE

The speaking space is part of your delivery. Before presenting, notice the room. Where will you stand? Where is the audience? Is there a podium? Are there cords, chairs, tables, or bags in the way? Will you use slides? Will you need to access a computer, remote, or microphone?

If possible, practice in the space before the speech. Even a quick walk-through can help you feel more comfortable.

Ask yourself:

Where should I begin?

Where should I place my notes?

Can everyone see me?

Can I move safely?

Will I block the screen?

Where should I stand during the strongest point?

Where should I end?

Speakers who understand the space usually look more prepared.

APPEARANCE AND CLOTHING

Audience members often notice appearance before the speaker begins. This does not mean speakers must dress expensively or abandon personal style. It means appearance should fit the audience, occasion, purpose, and setting.

A classroom presentation, job interview, wedding toast, business pitch, academic conference, and memorial speech may all call for different choices. The question is not “What is the fanciest thing I can wear?” The better question is “What appearance supports the message and occasion?”

Consider:

Does my clothing fit the setting?

Can I move comfortably?

Will anything distract from the message?

Are accessories noisy or visually distracting?

Will I be adjusting this outfit the whole time?

Does my appearance support the image I want to project?

Avoid bringing unnecessary items with you to the speaking area. A giant backpack, noisy keys, loose papers, oversized bag, or uncovered drink can create distractions. Bring what you need and remove what you do not.

Your appearance should help the audience focus on the speech, not on the logistics of your pockets.

PHYSICAL PRESENCE

Physical presence is the overall sense that the speaker is in the room with the audience and ready to communicate. It includes posture, eye contact, energy, stillness, movement, and focus.

Presence does not require being loud, flashy, or dramatic. A quiet speaker can have strong presence. A serious speaker can have strong presence. A humorous speaker can have strong presence. Presence comes from attention and intention.

To strengthen physical presence:

Begin before you speak.

Take your place calmly.

Pause before the first sentence.

Look at the audience.

Breathe.

Start with intention.

Finish each thought before looking away.

Let your body support your message.

The audience often begins judging delivery before the first word. How you walk to the front, arrange your notes, look up, and begin can affect how prepared you seem.

PRACTICE PHYSICAL DELIVERY

Practicing is one of the best ways to reduce speech anxiety. We often fear the unknown. Practice makes the speech less unknown. It helps you learn what the speech feels like in your body, not just what it looks like on the page.

Do not only practice silently. Physical delivery requires physical rehearsal. Stand up. Use your notes. Practice gestures. Practice movement. Practice where you will look. Practice with slides or visual aids if you are using them.

If possible, record yourself. Watching yourself can feel awkward, but it gives you useful information. You may notice habits you did not know you had, such as rocking, pacing, fidgeting, avoiding eye contact, or standing too stiffly.

When reviewing a recording, ask:

Do I look prepared?

Do my facial expressions match the topic?

Do I make meaningful eye contact?

Are my gestures natural?

Do I move with purpose?

Do I fidget?

Does my posture support my voice?

Do I look connected to the message?

The goal is not to become obsessed with every movement. The goal is to notice patterns and make useful adjustments.

FOCUS ON THE MESSAGE

The main purpose of delivery is to help the audience understand and connect with the message. Physical delivery is not about showing off. It is not about pretending to be fearless. It is about supporting the speech.

When speakers become overly focused on themselves, anxiety often grows. They may think:

What if I look nervous?

What if I move weird?

What if my hands look awkward?

What if everyone notices I am uncomfortable?

These thoughts are common, but they pull attention away from the audience. A better focus is:

What do I want them to understand?

Where do they need emphasis?

How can I help them follow this idea?

What feeling should this moment carry?

How can I make this message clearer?

When you focus on the message, your delivery usually becomes more natural. The body has a job to do.

PRACTICE OFTEN

If time allows, begin practicing your speech several days before you deliver it. More time is better, especially for longer or more formal speeches. Practicing early gives you time to revise parts that do not flow naturally.

Always practice with the notes you plan to use. If you plan to deliver from a speaking outline, practice from that outline. If you plan to use slides, practice with the slides. If you plan to stand, practice standing. If you plan to move, practice moving.

Try to practice under realistic conditions. If you can use the actual room, do it. If not, mimic the conditions as closely as possible. Stand up, speak out loud, time yourself, and imagine the audience.

During practice, check whether the introduction, body, and conclusion fit the time limit. A speech that is too long often creates panic near the end. A speech that is too short may lack development. Practicing out loud helps you control timing.

Practice does not eliminate every nervous feeling, but it gives you something stronger than nerves: preparation.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Physical delivery refers to how speakers use the body while presenting a speech. It includes facial expressions, eye contact, gestures, posture, movement, space, appearance, and overall physical presence.

Facial expressions should match the tone and meaning of the speech. Eye contact helps build connection with listeners. Gestures should be natural, visible, and purposeful. Posture should look grounded without becoming stiff. Movement should support the message rather than distract from it.

Speakers should also consider how they use the speaking space and how their appearance fits the audience, occasion, and topic. Physical presence begins before the first word and continues through the final moment of the speech.

Strong physical delivery comes from practice. Speakers should rehearse out loud, use their notes, practice movement, record themselves when possible, and focus on the message rather than on self-consciousness.

KEY TERMS

Physical delivery

Facial expressions

Eye contact

Gestures

Posture

Body movement

Purposeful movement

Speaking space

Appearance

Physical presence

Fidgeting

Rapport

Audience connection

Self-consciousness

Message focus

Rehearsal

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why does physical delivery matter in public speaking?
2. How can facial expressions support or weaken a speech?
3. What makes eye contact meaningful rather than random?
4. Why should gestures feel natural and purposeful?
5. How can movement help or hurt a speech?
6. What should speakers consider when choosing what to wear?
7. Why is practicing physical delivery different from silently reviewing an outline?
8. How can focusing on the message reduce self-consciousness?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

PHYSICAL DELIVERY SELF-CHECK

Practice one minute of your speech while standing. Record yourself if possible.

Then answer:

1. Did your facial expressions match your message?
2. Did you make meaningful eye contact?
3. Were your gestures natural?
4. Did you fidget?
5. Was your posture grounded?
6. Did your movement have a purpose?

7. What is one physical delivery habit you want to improve?

GESTURE PRACTICE

Choose three important ideas from your speech. For each idea, decide whether a gesture would help the audience understand or remember the point.

For each idea, answer:

1. What is the idea?

2. What gesture could support it?

3. Would the gesture feel natural?

4. Could the gesture distract from the message?

5. Should you use the gesture, revise it, or avoid it?

MOVEMENT PRACTICE

Mark your speaking outline with movement cues.

For example:

Begin at center.

Move to the left side of the speaking area for Main Point One.

Return to center during the transition.

Move to the right side of the speaking area for Main Point Two.

Return to center for Main Point Three.

Take one step closer to the audience for the conclusion.

After practicing, answer:

1. Did the movement support the structure of the speech?

2. Did you move too much, too little, or just enough?

3. Did movement help you feel more confident?

4. Did any movement feel forced?

5. What should you change before delivery?

Chapter 20

PRESENTATION AIDS

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain the purpose of presentation aids in public speaking.
2. Choose presentation aids that clarify, support, and strengthen a speech.
3. Use photos, videos, charts, graphs, text, and props effectively.
4. Design slides that are simple, readable, and visually clear.
5. Apply basic principles of typeface, font size, color, contrast, and layout.
6. Use AI tools responsibly when creating slides or visual materials.
7. Test presentation aids before delivering a speech.
8. Explain why presentation aids should support the speaker rather than replace the speaker.

People have used presentation aids for as long as people have been speaking to audiences. A speaker might use an object, drawing, map, chart, photograph, video, slide, demonstration, or prop to help an audience understand an idea more clearly.

A presentation aid is anything used to support, clarify, or strengthen the message of a speech. Presentation aids can make abstract ideas more concrete. They can help audiences understand numbers, visualize places, compare information, remember key points, and stay engaged.

However, presentation aids can also distract from the message. A confusing slide, blurry image, tiny chart, awkward video, or unnecessary prop can pull attention away from the speaker. The question is not “Can I add a slide?” The better question is “Will this help the audience understand?”

Presentation aids should serve the speech. They should not become the speech.

USE PRESENTATION AIDS WITH PURPOSE

A strong presentation aid should do at least one of the following:

Clarify an idea.

Show what words alone cannot show.

Make information easier to remember.

Support evidence.

Help the audience compare information.

Create emotional impact.

Guide the audience through the structure of the speech.

Demonstrate a process.

Make an abstract idea concrete.

If the aid does not help the audience, remove it. More media does not automatically create a better speech. Sometimes one strong image is more effective than ten forgettable slides.

Before using any presentation aid, ask:

What does this help the audience understand?

Could I explain this clearly without it?

Does this add clarity or clutter?

Will the audience focus on the aid instead of the message?

Can everyone see, hear, or understand it?

Have I practiced using it?

If a presentation aid creates more problems than it solves, it is not helping.

PHOTOS

Photos can be powerful because they help audiences see what you are describing. A strong photo can create emotion, provide evidence, establish context, or make an abstract point feel real.

For example, you could spend several minutes describing the effects of melting glaciers, but a clear time-lapse image or side-by-side comparison may communicate the idea more immediately.

When using photos:

Choose high-quality images.

Avoid blurry or pixelated photos.

Use images that directly support the point.

Do not overload one slide with too many photos.

Avoid decorative images that add nothing.

Make sure the image is large enough to see.

Use contrast so the image is easy to view.

Give credit when required or appropriate.

In many cases, photos should be large and simple. A full-slide image can be effective when the image is strong and the speaker explains its meaning. Do not place important text over a busy part of the photo where it becomes hard to read.

If you use a photo only because the slide “felt empty,” reconsider. Empty space is not the enemy. Clutter is.

FULL-BLEED IMAGES

A full-bleed image fills the entire slide. This can make a photo feel more immersive and visually powerful. Full-bleed images work best when the image is high resolution and not too visually crowded.

If you place text over a full-bleed image, make sure the text is readable. You may need to use a solid color bar, transparent overlay, or empty area of the image to create contrast.

A beautiful slide is not useful if no one can read it.

ASPECT RATIO

Aspect ratio refers to the shape of the slide. Most modern presentation screens use a widescreen format, usually 16:9. Older screens and projectors may use 4:3. Before presenting, check the expected format when possible.

A slide deck designed for the wrong aspect ratio may look stretched, cropped, or awkwardly framed. This is especially noticeable with photos, charts, and videos.

When preparing slides:

Use 16:9 for most modern classrooms, conference rooms, and online presentations.

Check the venue if you are presenting in an older room.

Preview the slides on the actual screen when possible.

Make sure photos, text, and charts still look correct after projection.

Avoid placing important content too close to the edges.

The slide may look fine on your laptop and still look strange on the projector. Test it.

PHOTO CREDITS AND IMAGE USE

Images belong to someone. Even when an image is easy to copy, that does not mean it is free to use without credit or permission.

When using photos, follow your instructor's requirements and the expectations of the speaking situation. Some images may be in the public domain. Some may use Creative Commons licenses. Some may require permission. Some may be available through university databases or stock image services.

Photo credits should be readable but should not overpower the slide. If the credit is required on the slide, place it consistently in a small, unobtrusive location. If all images come from the same source, you may be able to include a single credit slide or brief oral credit, depending on the assignment or rights requirements.

Do not use images in a way that misleads the audience. A dramatic photo from one event should not be used as if it shows a different event. A stock photo should not be presented as documentary evidence. A generated image should not be presented as a real photograph.

Images can persuade. Use them honestly.

VIDEOS

Videos can be excellent presentation aids when they show something that words or still images cannot show well. A video may demonstrate a process, show movement, capture sound, document an event, or create emotional impact.

However, videos should be used sparingly. In most classroom speeches, a short clip is better than a long one. If the video takes over the presentation, the audience may remember the video more than the speaker.

When using video:

Keep clips short.

Use video only when it adds something important.

Make sure the video quality is clear.

Check that the sound works.

Cue the video before the speech.

Test playback on the actual equipment.

Do not talk over the video unless you have a specific reason.

Explain why the video matters after it plays.

A good rule is this: if a still image can do the job, use the still image. Use video when motion, sound, sequence, or timing is necessary.

TEXT ON SLIDES

Slides are not documents. They are visual support for a spoken message. If a slide contains too much text, the audience will read instead of listen.

Avoid placing full paragraphs on slides. Avoid copying your outline onto the screen. Avoid using slides as a teleprompter. Your audience came to hear you speak, not to watch you read your own handout out loud like it owes you money.

Text on slides should be brief, clear, and purposeful.

Good slide text may include:

A key phrase.

A short quotation.

A major statistic.

A title or section marker.

A question.

A label for an image or chart.

A word or phrase that anchors the idea.

Slide text should support the spoken message, not duplicate it.

TYPEFACE

Typeface refers to the design of the letters. For presentations, readability should matter more than decoration.

Simple, clean typefaces usually work best. Sans serif typefaces are often easier to read on screens because they have clean lines and less visual clutter. Examples include Arial, Helvetica, Calibri, Avenir, and similar typefaces.

Avoid typefaces that are overly decorative, thin, crowded, or difficult to read from a distance. A font that looks stylish on your laptop may become useless on a projector.

Use one or two typefaces at most. Too many typefaces can make the presentation look messy and unprofessional.

FONT SIZE

Font size should be large enough for the audience to read easily. Tiny text is one of the most common slide design mistakes.

As a general rule, use large text for titles and key ideas. Avoid anything so small that the back of the room has to squint. If your slide requires tiny text to fit everything, the slide probably has too much information.

A useful test is to stand several feet away from your screen. Can you read the slide quickly? Can someone in the back of the room read it? If not, increase the size, cut text, or redesign the slide.

BACKGROUND AND COLOR

Color can help create emphasis and visual interest, but it should never hurt readability. The most important principle is contrast.

High contrast is easier to read:

Dark text on a light background.

Light text on a dark background.

White text on black or dark blue.

Black text on white or light gray.

Low contrast is harder to read:

Yellow on white.

Light blue on white.

Red on black.

Dark gray on black.

Neon colors on bright backgrounds.

Keep color choices simple. Use color to support meaning, not to decorate every slide like a birthday invitation. If you use a color for emphasis, use it consistently.

When placing text over an image, make sure the text is readable. If the image is too busy, place the text in a solid box, use a dark overlay, or move the text to a cleaner area of the image.

LAYOUT

Layout refers to how visual elements are arranged on the slide. A strong layout helps the audience know where to look.

Good slide layout usually includes:

Clear visual focus.

Enough empty space.

Consistent alignment.

Readable text.

Balanced placement.

Limited clutter.

Images that support the message.

Charts or graphs that are easy to understand.

Do not fill every corner of the slide. Empty space can make a slide cleaner and more professional. A crowded slide makes the audience work too hard.

One idea per slide is often stronger than five ideas fighting for oxygen.

WHAT NOT TO DO

Many slide mistakes come from trying to make the presentation look more exciting. Usually, the result is the opposite.

Avoid:

Too much text.

Tiny fonts.

Distracting animations.

Random clip art.

Low-quality images.

Too many colors.

Busy backgrounds.

Unreadable charts.

Unnecessary sound effects.

Decorative transitions.

Slides that repeat everything you say.

Reading directly from the slides.

Bullets can be useful when used carefully, but avoid turning every slide into a long bullet-point list. If every slide is a list, the presentation starts to feel like a meeting that should have been an email.

Use slides to support your best ideas, not to store every thought you have ever had.

TRANSITIONS AND ANIMATIONS

Slide transitions and animations should be simple. Their job is to help the audience move through the presentation, not to call attention to the software.

Simple cuts or fades are usually enough. Flashy effects such as spinning, bouncing, glittering, exploding, or flying text often distract from the message. The audience should remember your idea, not the moment your title cartwheeled onto the screen.

Use transitions and animations only when they serve a purpose. For example, revealing one part of a chart at a time may help the audience follow the explanation. Showing a process step by step may clarify sequence. But if the animation adds nothing, remove it.

A good transition should feel almost invisible.

GRAPHS AND CHARTS

Graphs and charts help audiences understand numerical information. They can make data more concrete and easier to compare.

Common types of graphs and charts include:

Line graphs.

Bar graphs.

Pie charts.

Tables.

Infographics.

Diagrams.

Flowcharts.

A line graph is useful for showing change over time.

A bar graph is useful for comparing quantities.

A pie chart is useful for showing parts of a whole.

A table is useful for precise values, but it can be hard to read during a speech.

A diagram is useful for showing relationships or processes.

A flowchart is useful for showing steps or decisions.

Charts should be simple enough to understand quickly. If the audience needs thirty seconds just to figure out what the chart is showing, simplify it.

When using charts:

Use clear titles.

Label important parts.

Remove unnecessary gridlines or clutter.

Highlight the most important data.

Explain what the audience should notice.

Do not show more numbers than the audience needs.

Make sure the chart is readable from the back of the room.

Do not simply put a chart on the screen and say, "As you can see." Tell the audience what they should see.

STATISTICS AND VISUALS

Statistics can be difficult for audiences to process. Presentation aids can help make numbers more understandable.

For example, saying "80 million people" may be hard to picture. But comparing that number to the population of a country, a state, or a familiar group may make it more concrete.

When presenting statistics:

Round numbers when appropriate.

Use comparisons.

Use visuals to show scale.

Avoid overwhelming the audience with too many numbers.

Explain why the number matters.

Not every statistic needs a graph. A simple number can be powerful if it is clear and meaningful. But when numbers are complex, visual support can help the audience understand.

PROPS AND DEMONSTRATIONS

A prop is a physical object used during a speech. A demonstration shows how something works or how something is done.

Props and demonstrations can be effective because they give the audience something concrete to see. However, they can also distract if they are awkward, unsafe, too small, too complicated, or unrelated to the message.

Before using a prop or demonstration, ask:

Can everyone see it?

Is it safe?

Is it necessary?

Can I handle it smoothly?

Will it distract from the message?

Have I practiced with it?

What will I do with it when I am finished?

Avoid bringing something into the room that upstages the speech. If you bring in an animal, a giant object, a noisy device, or anything unpredictable, the audience may remember that instead of your message.

A presentation aid should support the speaker, not steal the show.

USING AI TO CREATE SLIDES

AI tools can help speakers create presentation aids, especially during the early design process. They can suggest slide organization, generate layout ideas, summarize dense information, create first-draft slide titles, suggest visuals, and help simplify text.

For example, you might use an AI tool to:

Turn a speech outline into a possible slide sequence.

Suggest one visual idea for each main point.

Rewrite long slide text into shorter phrases.

Create a simple title for each slide.

Suggest chart types for data.

Generate a clean visual theme.

Help identify where a slide is too crowded.

Create practice questions about whether the slides support the message.

AI can be useful, but it should not make the presentation for you without your judgment. Many AI-generated slide decks are generic, text-heavy, visually bland, or filled with weak structure. AI may also invent information, use inaccurate visuals, or create images that look real but are not.

When using AI for slides:

Check every factual claim.

Verify every source.

Revise the language so it sounds like you.

Make sure the slides fit the assignment.

Avoid fake or misleading images.

Label generated images when necessary.

Make sure the design is readable.

Do not let AI choose style over clarity.

Follow your instructor's policy.

A good use of AI might be asking, "Based on this outline, suggest five simple slide titles and one visual idea for each." A weak use would be asking AI to create the entire speech and slide deck, then presenting it without understanding or revising it.

AI can help you design. It cannot replace your responsibility as the speaker.

TESTING

Testing is one of the most important parts of using presentation aids. There are two kinds of testing: human testing and technical testing.

Human testing means showing your presentation aids to another person before you deliver the speech. Choose someone who will be honest with you. Ask what they understood, what confused them, what seemed unnecessary, and what questions they still have.

Good human testing questions include:

What did you notice first?

Was anything hard to read?

Did any slide feel too crowded?

Did the visuals help the message?

Was anything distracting?

What do you remember most?

What needs to be clearer?

Technical testing means making sure your presentation aids actually work. A great slide deck is not useful if the file will not open, the video will not play, the audio is too quiet, or the projector cuts off half the screen.

Before presenting, check:

File format.

Internet access.

Projector or screen connection.

Slide size and aspect ratio.

Audio levels.

Video playback.

Remote or clicker.

Fonts.

Image quality.

Speaker notes.

Backup copy.

Battery life.

Microphone, if needed.

Never assume the technology will work just because it worked at home. Technology has a flair for betrayal at exactly the wrong moment.

LESS IS MORE

Presentation aids should make the speech clearer, not heavier. The best visual aid is not always the flashiest one. It is the one that helps the audience understand.

Ask yourself:

Does this aid help me communicate?

Does it clarify an idea?

Does it support my evidence?

Does it help the audience remember?

Does it distract from what I am saying?

Would the speech be stronger without it?

As soon as a presentation aid becomes a distraction, revise it or remove it.

Remember, you are the speaker. The slides, images, charts, videos, and props are there to support you. They should not upstage you, replace you, or give the audience a reason to stop listening.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Presentation aids are tools used to support, clarify, or strengthen a speech. They may include slides, photos, videos, charts, graphs, props, demonstrations, diagrams, audio, or digital visuals.

Strong presentation aids help the audience understand and remember the message. Weak presentation aids distract, confuse, or overwhelm the audience. Speakers should use photos, videos, text, charts, and props with clear purpose.

Effective slide design depends on readability, contrast, simplicity, layout, image quality, and restraint. Speakers should avoid clutter, tiny fonts, distracting transitions, low-quality media, and slides that simply repeat the entire speech.

AI tools can help speakers brainstorm slide structure, simplify text, suggest visuals, and create design drafts, but speakers must verify accuracy, revise the content, and use generated materials ethically. Presentation aids should always support the speaker's message.

Before delivering a speech, speakers should test their presentation aids with real people and with the actual technology whenever possible. The goal is simple: use presentation aids only when they help the audience understand.

KEY TERMS

Presentation aid

Visual aid

Slide deck

Photo

Full-bleed image

Aspect ratio

Photo credit

Public domain

Creative Commons

Video clip

Typeface

Font size

Contrast

Layout

Transition

Animation

Graph

Chart

Line graph

Bar graph

Pie chart

Table

Diagram

Flowchart

Statistic

Prop

Demonstration

AI-generated image

Technical testing

Human testing

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Why should presentation aids support the speech rather than become the speech?

2. What makes a photo effective in a presentation?

3. Why is readability more important than decoration in slide design?

4. What are some common mistakes speakers make with text on slides?

5. When is video more useful than a still image?

6. How can charts and graphs help audiences understand statistics?

7. What are the benefits and risks of using AI to create slides?

8. Why is technical testing important before a presentation?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

SLIDE DESIGN REVIEW

Choose three slides from a presentation you have created. For each slide, answer:

1. What is the purpose of this slide?

2. Is the main idea clear?

3. Is the text readable from a distance?

4. Is there too much information?

5. Does the image, chart, or design support the message?

6. What should be removed or simplified?

BEFORE-AND-AFTER SLIDE REVISION

Create one weak slide on purpose. Include too much text, poor contrast, or a cluttered design.

Then revise the slide so that it is clear, readable, and visually focused.

After revising, answer:

1. What did you remove?

2. What did you enlarge?

3. What did you simplify?

4. How did the revision improve the audience's ability to understand?

AI SLIDE PLANNING PRACTICE

Use your speech outline to create a simple slide plan. You may do this on your own or with the help of an AI tool.

Create:

1. One title slide.

2. One slide for each main point.

3. One visual idea for each main point.

4. One final slide for the conclusion.

Then answer:

1. Does each slide have a clear purpose?

2. Does each slide support the spoken message?

3. Is any slide unnecessary?

4. Did you verify the accuracy of any information?

5. If AI helped create the plan, what did you revise yourself?

Chapter 21

INFORMATIVE SPEAKING

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain the purpose of an informative speech.
2. Distinguish between informing and persuading.
3. Choose informative topics that are fresh, relevant, and audience-centered.
4. Explain how audience analysis helps shape an informative speech.
5. Use definition, description, explanation, and demonstration to communicate information.
6. Use examples, analogies, visuals, and repetition to reduce confusion.
7. Organize complex information so the audience can understand and remember it.
8. Present information ethically and clearly.

An informative speech provides listeners with new information, a clearer understanding of a topic, or a new way of thinking about something. Informative speeches may explain a concept, describe a person or place, clarify an event, define an idea, teach a process, or demonstrate how something works.

The goal of an informative speech is understanding. You are not trying to force the audience to agree with you, vote a certain way, buy something, or change their behavior. You are helping the audience learn.

That does not mean informative speeches are boring. A strong informative speech can be surprising, vivid, useful, and memorable. The speaker's job is to make information clear, meaningful, and worth listening to.

ENLIGHTEN RATHER THAN ADVOCATE

Informative speaking is different from persuasive speaking. In a persuasive speech, the speaker tries to influence the audience's beliefs, attitudes, values, or actions. In an informative speech, the speaker explains the topic and leaves the audience better informed.

The aim is to enlighten rather than advocate.

For example, an informative speech about electric vehicles might explain how batteries work, how charging stations operate, and what factors affect driving range. A persuasive speech about electric vehicles might argue that everyone should buy one, that the government should expand charging infrastructure, or that electric vehicles are better than gas-powered vehicles.

The difference is purpose.

Informative purpose:

To explain how electric vehicle batteries work.

Persuasive purpose:

To convince my audience that electric vehicles are the best option for reducing transportation emissions.

An informative speaker can still discuss important issues. But the speaker should avoid manipulating information, hiding opposing evidence, or turning the speech into an argument disguised as a lesson.

BUILD SUSTAINED AUDIENCE INVOLVEMENT

Listeners are not sponges that automatically soak up every fact, figure, and definition you present. Before audiences can remember information, they need a reason to care about it. They also need help following it.

Sustained involvement means keeping the audience mentally connected throughout the speech. This requires more than giving facts. It requires relevance, clarity, examples, organization, and variety.

To build involvement:

Connect the topic to the audience.

Use clear examples.

Avoid overwhelming listeners with too much information.

Use transitions and repetition.

Explain why each main point matters.

Use stories, comparisons, or visuals when helpful.

Keep the speech moving.

A speaker who simply dumps information onto the audience may technically be "informing," but the audience may not learn much. Information needs structure.

DEMONSTRATE THE TOPIC'S RELEVANCE

Early in the speech, the audience needs to know why the topic matters. Listeners often ask themselves, even silently, "Why should I care?"

This is not selfish. It is human. People pay closer attention when they understand how a topic connects to their lives, goals, problems, values, interests, or responsibilities.

A relevance statement helps the audience see the connection.

Example:

This topic matters because most of us use our phones every day, but few of us understand how those devices shape our attention and habits.

Example:

Understanding sleep matters because it affects memory, focus, stress, and academic performance.

Example:

Learning how credit scores work matters because they can affect whether you qualify for an apartment, car loan, or lower interest rate.

If the audience does not immediately care about your topic, do not blame the audience. Build the bridge.

ANALYZE YOUR AUDIENCE

Audience analysis is especially important in informative speaking because different audiences need different levels of information.

If you are speaking about gene editing to biology professors, you can use more technical language. If you are speaking to a general audience, you may need to define terms such as DNA, gene, mutation, and CRISPR before moving into more complex ideas.

Audience analysis helps you decide:

What does the audience already know?

What do they need to know first?

What terms should I define?

What examples will make sense to them?

What assumptions might they have?

How technical should I be?

What information can I leave out?

What information must I include?

A common mistake is assuming the audience knows what the speaker knows. Another mistake is assuming the audience knows nothing. The best informative speakers meet the audience where they are and guide them forward.

KEEP IT FRESH

A strong informative speech should feel fresh. Freshness does not always mean the topic has never been discussed before. It means the speaker finds a specific angle, example, story, question, or explanation that makes the audience see the topic in a new way.

A familiar topic can become fresh through:

A surprising statistic.

A recent development.

A personal story.

An unusual comparison.

A misunderstood fact.

A behind-the-scenes explanation.

A practical application.

A strong visual example.

Weak topic:

Exercise is good for you.

Fresher topic:

How short walking breaks during the day can improve focus and reduce stress.

Weak topic:

Social media affects people.

Fresher topic:

How infinite scroll is designed to keep users from noticing time passing.

A fresh angle gives the audience a reason to listen, even when the topic seems familiar.

HELP YOUR AUDIENCE LISTEN

Live audiences cannot pause, rewind, or reread a speech. This means informative speakers must help listeners keep up.

Use preview statements, transitions, signposts, examples, and repetition. These tools are not filler. They are listening aids.

A preview statement tells the audience what they will learn.

Example:

First, we will look at how sleep affects memory. Second, we will examine how it affects focus. Finally, we will discuss how sleep helps students manage stress.

A transition moves the audience from one idea to the next.

Example:

Now that we understand how sleep supports memory, let's look at how it affects attention during class.

A signpost labels where the speaker is in the speech.

Example:

The first major cause is poor time management.

Repetition helps important information stick. You should not repeat yourself randomly, but you should repeat central ideas in clear and purposeful ways.

If the audience gets lost, the speaker has to work harder to bring them back.

AVOID INFORMATION OVERLOAD

One of the biggest challenges in informative speaking is deciding what not to include. When speakers research a topic, they often discover more information than they can use. The temptation is to cram all of it into the speech.

Do not do that.

An informative speech should be focused. The audience does not need to know everything about the topic. They need to understand the specific part of the topic your speech is designed to explain.

Too much information can overwhelm the audience. Too many definitions, statistics, names, dates, or details can make listeners shut down.

To avoid overload:

Limit your main points.

Use only the most useful evidence.

Define only the terms the audience needs.

Choose examples carefully.

Cut details that do not support the purpose.

Leave out interesting facts that do not fit.

Use visuals to simplify complex information.

Give the audience time to process.

A strong informative speech is not the result of saying everything. It is the result of choosing wisely.

HOW TO COMMUNICATE YOUR INFORMATION

Informative speakers usually communicate information through one or more of the following methods:

Definition

Description

Explanation

Demonstration

Many speeches combine these methods. A speaker might define a term, describe what it looks like, explain how it works, and then demonstrate the process.

Choose the method that best fits your topic and your audience.

DEFINITION

Definition explains what something means. Definitions are especially useful when the audience is unfamiliar with a term, concept, object, process, or issue.

There are several ways to define something.

A formal definition explains the meaning of a term in a clear and direct way.

Example:

A podcast is a digital audio program that listeners can stream or download.

An operational definition explains how something works or what it does.

Example:

A search engine is a tool that scans indexed webpages and returns results based on keywords, relevance, and ranking systems.

A definition by negation explains what something is by explaining what it is not.

Example:

Mindfulness is not the same as ignoring problems. It is the practice of paying attention to the present moment without immediately judging it.

A definition by example explains a category by giving specific examples.

Example:

Healthcare workers include doctors, nurses, EMTs, medical assistants, physical therapists, and many others who support patient care.

A definition by word origin, or etymology, explains where a word comes from and how its meaning developed.

Example:

The word theater comes from the Greek word theatron, meaning “a place for viewing.”

Definitions should be clear, brief, and useful. Do not define words the audience already knows unless the definition changes how they understand the topic.

DESCRIPTION

Description helps the audience form a mental picture. It uses specific and vivid language to show what something looks, sounds, feels, or seems like.

Description is useful when discussing places, objects, people, events, experiences, or conditions.

Example:

Instead of saying, “The classroom was stressful,” a speaker might say, “The room was silent except for the tapping of pencils, the hum of the projector, and the sound of students turning over the exam page.”

That description gives the audience something to imagine.

Visual aids can strengthen description. Photos, maps, diagrams, models, and videos can help the audience see what the speaker is describing. However, the speaker still needs to explain what the audience should notice.

Do not assume the visual will do all the work.

EXPLANATION

Explanation shows how or why something happens. It may identify causes, describe relationships, interpret meaning, or clarify a process.

A professor explaining a theory is using explanation. A mechanic explaining why an engine overheats is using explanation. A speaker explaining how sleep affects memory is using explanation.

Good explanations usually move step by step. If the idea is complicated, slow down. Define terms. Use examples. Compare the unfamiliar to the familiar.

Weak explanation:

Blockchain is a decentralized ledger system that verifies transactions through distributed consensus mechanisms.

Stronger explanation:

Blockchain is a digital record book shared across many computers. Instead of one person controlling the record, many computers help verify and store the information.

The stronger version gives the audience a way in.

DEMONSTRATION

A demonstration shows the audience how something works or how to do something. Demonstrations are useful for processes, skills, tools, techniques, or physical tasks.

Examples of demonstration topics include:

How to perform CPR.

How to change a bike tire.

How to prepare a basic budget.

How to warm up before a speech.

How to use a camera setting.

How to plant herbs in a small container.

How to fold a fitted sheet, for the brave.

A strong demonstration should be organized clearly. Show the steps in order. Make sure everyone can see. Explain what you are doing while you do it. Practice with the materials ahead of time.

If the demonstration involves safety concerns, address them. If it requires equipment, test it. If it might get messy, plan for that too.

REDUCE CONFUSION

New information can be difficult for audiences to understand, especially when the topic is abstract, technical, emotional, or counterintuitive. A good informative speaker anticipates confusion before it happens.

To reduce confusion:

Define unfamiliar terms.

Use examples.

Use analogies.

Show visuals.

Explain one step at a time.

Repeat central ideas.

Avoid unnecessary jargon.

Check whether the order of ideas makes sense.

Compare new information to something familiar.

Tell the audience why the information matters.

The speaker's job is not to make the audience feel impressed by how complicated the topic is. The speaker's job is to make the audience feel capable of understanding it.

USE ANALOGIES

An analogy is a comparison that explains something unfamiliar by comparing it to something familiar. Analogies are useful because they give the audience a mental shortcut.

Example:

A thesis statement is like a destination on a map. If you do not know where you are going, the rest of the speech can wander.

Example:

The immune system is like a security team. It identifies threats, responds to intruders, and remembers certain dangers so it can respond faster next time.

Analogies are powerful, but they are not perfect. Every comparison has limits. If you use an analogy, make sure it clarifies the point without misleading the audience.

DEMONSTRATE CAUSES

Sometimes audiences misunderstand a topic because they assume it works one way when it actually works another way. In those cases, the speaker may need to explain causes.

For example, an audience may assume sleep only affects energy. A speaker might explain that sleep also affects memory, attention, mood, and decision-making.

When explaining causes:

Identify the assumption.

Explain what actually happens.

Show the relationship between cause and effect.

Use evidence or examples.

Avoid oversimplifying complex issues.

Cause-and-effect explanation helps audiences understand why something happens, not just what happens.

USE MULTIPLE WAYS OF EXPLAINING

People process information in different ways. Some listeners respond well to stories. Others need definitions. Some understand better with visuals. Others need examples, repetition, or demonstrations.

Rather than assuming each person has one fixed learning style, strong speakers use multiple methods to help the whole audience understand.

For example, if you are explaining how a wildfire spreads, you might:

Define key terms.

Show a map.

Describe wind conditions.

Use a simple analogy.

Give a real example.

Show a short video or image.

Review the main causes.

This gives the audience several ways to understand the same idea.

Using multiple methods does not mean overwhelming the audience. It means choosing different tools that support the same point.

USE VISUAL AIDS WISELY

Informative speeches often benefit from visual aids because visuals can make information easier to understand. A chart can clarify numbers. A diagram can show parts of a system. A photo can make a place or condition more real. A short video can show motion or sequence.

Use visuals when they help the audience understand something more clearly than words alone.

Visual aids can be especially useful for:

Processes

Timelines

Statistics

Locations

Comparisons

Parts of an object

Before-and-after examples

Cause-and-effect relationships

However, visual aids should not replace explanation. Do not simply show a chart, image, or diagram and expect the audience to understand it automatically. Guide them through it.

Tell the audience what they are seeing, why it matters, and how it connects to the speech.

PRESENT INFORMATION ETHICALLY

Informative speakers have an ethical responsibility to present information accurately and fairly. Because the audience is learning from you, you should be careful not to distort, exaggerate, oversimplify, or cherry-pick information.

Ethical informative speaking means:

Use credible sources.

Cite sources clearly.

Explain uncertainty when necessary.

Avoid misleading visuals.

Avoid fake or unverified statistics.

Distinguish between fact and interpretation.

Do not hide important context.

Avoid presenting opinion as fact.

Represent people and groups respectfully.

Even when you are not trying to persuade, the way you select and frame information can influence the audience. Be honest about what you know, what the evidence shows, and where limits exist.

PRACTICE FOR CLARITY

Informative speeches require rehearsal because clarity often improves through practice. When you practice out loud, you may discover that a sentence sounds confusing, a definition comes too late, a transition is missing, or a main point needs a stronger example.

As you rehearse, ask:

Can the audience follow the order?

Are my definitions clear?

Do my examples help?

Am I using too much jargon?

Are my visuals easy to understand?

Do I explain why the topic matters?

Have I included too much information?

Do I repeat the most important ideas?

If the speech feels too dense, simplify it. If it feels too vague, add specific examples. If it feels too familiar, find a fresher angle.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

An informative speech provides listeners with new information, a clearer understanding of a topic, or a new way of thinking. The goal is to enlighten rather

than advocate. Unlike persuasive speeches, informative speeches do not primarily attempt to change beliefs or actions. They help audiences understand.

Strong informative speeches are relevant, fresh, organized, clear, and audience-centered. Speakers should analyze the audience, demonstrate the topic's relevance, avoid information overload, and use preview statements, transitions, repetition, and examples to help listeners follow the message.

Informative speakers often communicate through definition, description, explanation, and demonstration. They can reduce confusion by using analogies, visuals, examples, cause-and-effect explanation, and multiple ways of explaining the same idea.

Ethical informative speakers present information accurately and fairly. They use credible sources, avoid misleading the audience, and distinguish between fact, interpretation, and opinion. The best informative speeches make the audience feel smarter, not smaller.

KEY TERMS

Informative speech

Persuasive speech

Enlighten

Advocate

Audience involvement

Relevance statement

Audience analysis

Freshness

Preview statement

Transition

Signpost

Information overload

Definition

Formal definition

Operational definition

Definition by negation

Definition by example

Etymology

Description

Explanation

Demonstration

Analogy

Cause and effect

Visual aid

Ethical informative speaking

Clarity

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What is the main purpose of an informative speech?

2. How is an informative speech different from a persuasive speech?

3. Why is audience analysis important in informative speaking?

4. What makes an informative speech feel fresh?

5. How can speakers avoid information overload?

6. What is the difference between definition, description, explanation, and demonstration?

7. How can analogies help audiences understand complex topics?

8. Why is ethical responsibility important in informative speaking?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

INFORMATIVE TOPIC PRACTICE

Choose one broad topic and narrow it into three possible informative speech topics.

Broad topic examples:

Health

Technology

Education

Sports

Theater

Music

Food

Social media

Environment

Money

For each narrowed topic, answer:

1. What would the audience learn?

2. Why would this topic matter to them?

3. What would make the topic fresh?

4. What terms would need to be defined?

5. What visual aid might help?

DEFINITION, DESCRIPTION, EXPLANATION, OR DEMONSTRATION

Choose one topic and decide which method would work best.

Topic options:

How credit scores work

The history of a cultural tradition

How to prepare for a job interview

What artificial intelligence means

How a wildfire spreads

The role of stage lighting in theater

How sleep affects memory

Answer:

1. Would this topic work best through definition, description, explanation, demonstration, or a combination?

2. Why?

3. What example would help the audience understand?

4. What visual aid would support the speech?

CLARITY CHECK

Write one paragraph from an informative speech. Then revise it for clarity.

Ask:

1. Are any words too technical?

2. Does the audience need a definition?

3. Is there a concrete example?

4. Is the information in the right order?

5. Could a visual aid help?

6. What sentence could be simplified?

Chapter 22

PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain the purpose of persuasive speaking.
2. Distinguish between attitudes, values, beliefs, behaviors, and actions.
3. Use ethos, pathos, and logos ethically in a persuasive speech.
4. Explain how audience needs and motivation influence persuasion.
5. Identify claims of fact, value, and policy.
6. Build arguments using claims, evidence, reasoning, and warrants.
7. Recognize common logical fallacies.
8. Choose an organizational pattern for a persuasive speech.
9. Create a persuasive speech that is ethical, audience-centered, and supported by credible evidence.

The goal of persuasive speaking is to influence an audience's attitudes, values, beliefs, behaviors, or actions. Some persuasive speeches try to change what an audience believes. Others try to move the audience toward a specific action, such as voting, donating, volunteering, changing a habit, or supporting a policy. Some persuasive speeches try to do both.

Persuasion is not the same as manipulation. Ethical persuasion respects the audience's ability to think, question, and decide. Manipulation hides information,

distorts evidence, or uses emotional pressure to control the audience. A persuasive speaker can be passionate and forceful without being dishonest.

The best persuasive speeches do not simply tell the audience what to think. They give the audience reasons to care, reasons to trust the speaker, and reasons to consider a new position.

MOTIVATE THE AUDIENCE

Persuasion begins with motivation. If the audience does not care about the topic, even a logical argument may fail. A speaker must understand what the audience values, what they already believe, what they need, and what might prevent them from accepting the message.

Audience analysis is especially important in persuasive speaking. You need to know whether your audience is likely to agree, disagree, feel neutral, feel uninformed, or feel hostile toward your position.

Ask yourself:

What does my audience already believe?

What do they care about?

What objections might they have?

What values do we share?

What evidence will they trust?

What emotional concerns might shape their reaction?

What action am I asking them to take?

Is that action realistic?

Persuasive goals should be reasonable. If your audience strongly disagrees with you, your goal may not be to completely change their minds in one speech. A more realistic goal may be to get them to reconsider one assumption, accept one piece of evidence, or take one small step.

People are more likely to act when the action feels possible.

BALANCE LOGOS, PATHOS, AND ETHOS

Effective persuasion often depends on the balance of logos, pathos, and ethos. These three persuasive appeals come from Aristotle's rhetorical theory and remain useful for understanding how persuasion works.

Logos refers to logic, reasoning, and evidence.

Pathos refers to emotion and audience values.

Ethos refers to speaker credibility and character.

A persuasive speech that uses only logic may feel cold or disconnected from real human concerns. A speech that uses only emotion may feel powerful in the moment but weak once the audience thinks more carefully. A speech that depends only on credibility may fail if the audience wants stronger evidence.

Strong persuasion uses all three appeals ethically.

USE LOGOS

Logos is the appeal to logic and reason. It includes claims, evidence, statistics, examples, expert testimony, comparisons, and clear reasoning.

A logical argument makes a claim and supports it with evidence. The speaker then explains how that evidence proves or supports the claim.

Example:

Claim: Students should practice speeches out loud before presenting.

Evidence: Rehearsing aloud helps speakers identify awkward wording, timing problems, and unclear transitions.

Reasoning: Because public speaking happens out loud, practicing silently does not fully prepare the speaker for delivery.

Logos matters because audiences need reasons to accept the speaker's position. If a speech asks people to change their beliefs or actions, the speaker should provide evidence that the change makes sense.

USE PATHOS

Pathos is the appeal to emotion, values, and human experience. Emotional appeals can help the audience feel the importance of the issue.

A persuasive speech about distracted driving, for example, may include statistics about crashes, but it may also include a story about a family affected by a

preventable accident. The statistic helps the audience understand the scale of the issue. The story helps them feel why it matters.

Emotional appeals can include:

Stories

Vivid language

Examples

Images

Values

Personal testimony

Hypothetical scenarios

Consequences

Hope

Fear

Anger

Compassion

Pride

Pathos should be used ethically. Do not use emotion to distract from weak evidence. Do not exaggerate suffering to shock the audience. Do not use fear if you cannot offer a realistic response. Emotion should deepen understanding, not replace it.

USE ETHOS

Ethos refers to speaker credibility. Audiences are more likely to listen when they believe the speaker is trustworthy, prepared, knowledgeable, and fair.

Credibility can come from:

Personal experience

Research

Education or training

Professional background

Careful source use

Honesty about limits

Respect for the audience

Balanced treatment of opposing views

Clear organization

Confident delivery

You do not need to be the world's leading expert to speak persuasively, but you do need to show that you have done the work.

For example:

I am not a financial advisor, but I researched this topic through government consumer resources, banking information, and interviews with students who have struggled with credit card debt.

This kind of credibility statement is honest and useful. It does not exaggerate expertise, but it shows preparation.

Avoid bragging. If your credibility statement sounds like a trophy case being dragged across the stage, revise it. The goal is to build trust, not perform a résumé.

BUILD COMMON GROUND

Common ground is the shared belief, value, concern, or experience between the speaker and the audience. Finding common ground helps reduce defensiveness and makes persuasion more possible.

For example, if you are arguing that college students should reduce phone use during studying, some listeners may resist because they rely on their phones. You might begin with common ground:

Most of us are not trying to waste time on our phones. We use them for school, work, family, directions, reminders, and connection. The problem is that the same device that helps us function can also interrupt our focus.

This statement does not attack the audience. It acknowledges their reality and then opens the door to the argument.

Common ground does not mean pretending disagreement does not exist. It means beginning from a place the audience can recognize.

TARGET AUDIENCE NEEDS

One way to motivate listeners is to connect your argument to their needs. People are more likely to listen when they understand how an issue affects their safety, relationships, success, identity, values, or future.

Abraham Maslow's hierarchy of needs is one familiar way to think about motivation. Maslow described human needs in categories such as physiological needs, safety, belonging, esteem, and self-actualization. Although scholars have debated and revised aspects of the theory, it remains a useful starting point for thinking about what audiences may care about.

Physiological needs involve basic survival and bodily comfort, such as food, water, rest, and health.

Example:

A speech about campus food insecurity might focus on students who cannot study effectively because they do not have reliable access to meals.

Safety needs involve protection from harm, instability, danger, or uncertainty.

Example:

A speech about emergency preparedness might explain how students can protect themselves during wildfires, earthquakes, or severe weather.

Belonging needs involve connection, friendship, family, community, and acceptance.

Example:

A speech about joining student organizations might focus on how involvement helps students build community and reduce isolation.

Esteem needs involve confidence, respect, achievement, recognition, and self-worth.

Example:

A speech about public speaking practice might focus on how communication skills help students feel more capable in school, work, and relationships.

Self-actualization needs involve purpose, growth, creativity, fulfillment, and meaning.

Example:

A speech about volunteering might emphasize how service allows people to connect their actions to a larger purpose.

Not every audience member will be motivated by the same need. The more you understand your audience, the more effectively you can connect the topic to what they care about.

ENCOURAGE DEEP PROCESSING

Listeners process persuasive messages in different ways. Sometimes they think carefully about the message, evaluate evidence, and consider the argument. Other times, they rely on shortcuts such as a speaker's popularity, appearance, confidence, or reputation.

A speaker should encourage the audience to think carefully rather than simply react quickly.

To encourage deeper processing:

Make the topic relevant.

Use clear evidence.

Explain why the evidence matters.

Use examples the audience understands.

Avoid unnecessary complexity.

Address likely objections.

Connect the issue to real consequences.

Show respect for the audience's intelligence.

For example, an audience may support a policy because a celebrity endorsed it. That is not deep processing. A stronger persuasive speech would help the audience understand the issue, evaluate the evidence, and consider the consequences.

The goal is not just to get agreement. The goal is to help the audience make a thoughtful decision.

MAKE AN ARGUMENT

In public speaking, an argument is not a shouting match. An argument is a claim supported by evidence and reasoning.

A strong argument includes:

Claim

Evidence

Reasoning

Warrant

The claim is the point the speaker wants the audience to accept.

The evidence is the supporting material used to back up the claim. Evidence may include facts, statistics, examples, narratives, testimony, or research.

The reasoning explains how the evidence supports the claim.

The warrant is the underlying assumption or principle that connects the evidence to the claim.

Example:

Claim: Students should practice speeches out loud before presenting.

Evidence: Many delivery problems, such as awkward wording, poor timing, and unclear transitions, only become obvious when the speech is spoken aloud.

Reasoning: Since speeches are delivered orally, practicing silently does not prepare the speaker for the actual speaking situation.

Warrant: Preparation should match the conditions of the performance.

If the audience does not accept the warrant, they may reject the argument even if the evidence seems accurate. That is why speakers must think carefully about the assumptions behind their claims.

TYPES OF CLAIMS

There are three major types of persuasive claims: claims of fact, claims of value, and claims of policy.

A persuasive speech may focus mainly on one type of claim, but many speeches include more than one.

CLAIMS OF FACT

A claim of fact argues that something is true or false, that something did or did not happen, or that something will or will not happen.

Claims of fact are not always simple facts. They often involve disagreement about evidence, interpretation, prediction, or cause.

Examples:

Regular sleep improves academic performance.

Social media use affects attention span.

Public speaking anxiety can be reduced through preparation and practice.

Artificial intelligence will change how students prepare for presentations.

A claim of fact requires credible evidence. The speaker must show why the audience should accept the claim as accurate or likely.

CLAIMS OF VALUE

A claim of value argues that something is good or bad, right or wrong, ethical or unethical, fair or unfair, beneficial or harmful.

Claims of value involve judgment. They often depend on criteria.

Examples:

It is unfair for students to pay high parking fees when public transportation options are limited.

It is unethical for companies to hide important privacy settings from users.

Community college is one of the most valuable investments in public education.

A claim of value requires the speaker to explain the standard of judgment. If you say something is unfair, explain what fairness means in that context. If you say something is harmful, explain what kind of harm is being considered.

CLAIMS OF POLICY

A claim of policy argues that something should or should not be done. Policy claims call for action, change, support, opposition, or a specific solution.

Claims of policy often use the word “should.”

Examples:

Colleges should provide more mental health resources for students.

Students should practice speeches out loud before presentation day.

City leaders should expand shaded public spaces during extreme heat.

Social media companies should make privacy settings easier to understand.

Claims of policy usually require the speaker to show that a problem exists, that the proposal addresses the problem, and that the solution is practical or worth supporting.

USE COMPELLING EVIDENCE

Every persuasive claim needs credible evidence. Evidence gives the audience a reason to believe the speaker.

Types of evidence include:

Facts

Statistics

Examples

Narratives

Expert testimony

Lay testimony

Analogies

Case studies

Historical examples

Scientific research

Personal experience

Personal experience can be powerful, but it is rarely enough by itself. A speaker's own experience may explain why they care, but outside evidence helps show that the issue extends beyond one person.

Current evidence is often more persuasive than outdated evidence, especially when discussing technology, health, economics, law, education, or public policy. However, older evidence may still be useful when discussing history, philosophy, literature, or long-standing patterns.

When using evidence, ask:

Is the source credible?

Is the evidence current enough?

Does the evidence directly support the claim?

Have I explained what the evidence means?

Could the evidence be interpreted another way?

Is there important context I need to include?

What counterevidence might the audience know?

Evidence does not speak for itself. The speaker must connect it to the argument.

ADDRESS COUNTERARGUMENTS

A counterargument is an argument that opposes or challenges your position. Strong persuasive speakers do not ignore serious counterarguments. They address them.

Ignoring obvious objections can damage credibility. The audience may think you did not research carefully or that you are hiding information.

You do not need to respond to every possible objection. Focus on the strongest or most relevant ones.

To address a counterargument:

State the opposing view fairly.

Acknowledge why some people may believe it.

Explain where the opposing argument is limited, incomplete, outdated, or unsupported.

Offer stronger evidence or reasoning for your position.

Example:

Some students may argue that practicing out loud is unnecessary if they already understand the topic. That concern makes sense because preparation can feel time-

consuming. However, understanding a topic and delivering it clearly are not the same skill. Speaking out loud helps reveal timing problems, awkward sentences, and unclear transitions before the audience hears them.

This response does not mock the opposing view. It answers it.

USE REASONING

Reasoning is the process of drawing conclusions from evidence. In persuasive speaking, reasoning helps the audience understand why the evidence supports the claim.

Two common types of reasoning are deductive reasoning and inductive reasoning.

DEDUCTIVE REASONING

Deductive reasoning begins with a general principle and applies it to a specific case.

Classic example:

Major premise: All humans are mortal.

Minor premise: Socrates is human.

Conclusion: Therefore, Socrates is mortal.

If the general principle is true and the specific case fits, the conclusion follows logically.

In speeches, deductive reasoning can help audiences move from a shared belief to a specific conclusion.

Example:

Students should prepare in ways that match the assignment.

A speech is an oral assignment.

Therefore, students should practice speeches out loud.

INDUCTIVE REASONING

Inductive reasoning begins with specific examples and moves toward a general conclusion.

Example:

A student who practiced out loud noticed timing problems before speech day.

Another student who practiced out loud discovered unclear transitions.

Another student who practiced out loud improved eye contact.

Therefore, practicing out loud often improves speech delivery.

Inductive reasoning does not guarantee the conclusion, but it can make the conclusion seem likely. The strength of inductive reasoning depends on the quality and number of examples.

AVOID LOGICAL FALLACIES

A logical fallacy is an error in reasoning. Fallacies can make an argument seem persuasive when it is actually weak.

Speakers should avoid fallacies in their own arguments and recognize them in the arguments of others.

HASTY GENERALIZATION

A hasty generalization reaches a conclusion based on too little evidence.

Example:

One student gave a bad group presentation, so group projects never work.

The example may show that one group project went badly. It does not prove that all group projects fail.

FALSE ANALOGY

A false analogy compares two things that are not truly similar in the relevant way.

Example:

Running a college is just like running a fast-food restaurant, so students should be treated exactly like customers.

Colleges and restaurants both provide services, but they have different purposes, responsibilities, and relationships with the people they serve.

CAUSAL FALLACY

A causal fallacy assumes that because one event happened before another, the first event caused the second.

Example:

I wore my lucky shoes during my speech and earned an A, so the shoes caused my success.

The shoes may be part of the story, but preparation probably had more to do with the result.

SLIPPERY SLOPE

A slippery slope argument assumes that one action will automatically lead to a chain of extreme consequences without enough evidence.

Example:

If students are allowed to revise one assignment, soon they will expect unlimited revisions on everything.

One revision policy does not automatically lead to unlimited revisions.

RED HERRING

A red herring distracts from the real issue by introducing irrelevant information.

Example:

We should not discuss campus parking fees when there are bigger problems in the world.

There may be bigger problems, but that does not address whether campus parking fees are fair or reasonable.

APPEAL TO TRADITION

An appeal to tradition argues that something should continue simply because it has always been done that way.

Example:

We should keep this policy because this is how the department has always handled it.

Tradition may be worth considering, but it is not proof that the policy is effective or fair.

FALSE DILEMMA

A false dilemma presents only two options when more options exist.

Example:

Either students attend every class perfectly, or they do not care about their education.

Students may miss class for many reasons, including illness, work, transportation, or family responsibilities.

BANDWAGON FALLACY

A bandwagon fallacy argues that something is correct or valuable simply because many people believe it or do it.

Example:

Everyone is using this study app, so it must be the best one.

Popularity alone does not prove quality.

AD HOMINEM

An ad hominem argument attacks a person instead of addressing the argument.

Example:

We should ignore his proposal about tutoring because he is annoying.

The speaker's personality does not determine whether the proposal is good or bad.

STRAW PERSON

A straw person fallacy misrepresents an opposing argument to make it easier to attack.

Example:

People who support online classes just want students to sit at home and do nothing.

That is an unfair distortion. A stronger argument would respond to what supporters of online classes actually claim.

ORGANIZATION IN PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Once you have developed your claims, evidence, and reasoning, you need to organize the speech. Persuasive speeches often use specific organizational patterns because they must move the audience from attention to understanding to possible agreement or action.

Before choosing a pattern, consider your audience.

Are they likely to agree?

Are they undecided?

Are they uninformed?

Are they skeptical?

Are they hostile?

Do they already recognize the problem?

Do they need motivation to act?

Do they need more evidence before deciding?

The best organizational pattern depends on where your audience stands.

PROBLEM–CAUSE–SOLUTION PATTERN

The problem-cause-solution pattern is useful when the speaker wants to explain a problem, identify its causes, and propose a solution.

Basic structure:

I. Explain the problem.

II. Explain the causes of the problem.

III. Propose a solution.

This pattern works well for policy speeches.

Example topic:

Students should have access to more affordable textbooks.

I. Textbook costs create financial stress for students.

II. Costs are driven by publishing practices, frequent new editions, and limited used-book options.

III. Colleges should expand open educational resources and low-cost textbook programs.

MONROE'S MOTIVATED SEQUENCE

Monroe's Motivated Sequence is a five-step persuasive pattern developed by Alan Monroe. It is especially useful when the speaker wants the audience to take action.

The five steps are:

Attention

Need

Satisfaction

Visualization

Action

Attention

The speaker gets the audience's attention and shows why the topic matters.

Need

The speaker explains the problem or need.

Satisfaction

The speaker presents the solution.

Visualization

The speaker helps the audience imagine what will happen if the solution is adopted or ignored.

Action

The speaker asks the audience to take a specific step.

Example topic:

Students should practice speeches out loud before presentation day.

Attention: Describe the panic of realizing your speech is too long while standing in front of the class.

Need: Explain how silent preparation fails to reveal delivery problems.

Satisfaction: Recommend practicing out loud at least three times before speech day.

Visualization: Show how rehearsal leads to better timing, smoother transitions, and more confidence.

Action: Ask students to schedule three short practice sessions before their next speech.

COMPARATIVE ADVANTAGE PATTERN

The comparative advantage pattern is useful when the audience already knows there is a problem but is unsure which solution is best. The speaker compares possible solutions and argues that one has the greatest advantages.

Example topic:

The best way to reduce textbook costs is to expand open educational resources.

I. Open educational resources are more affordable than traditional textbooks.

II. They are easier to update than printed textbooks.

III. They can be more accessible to students on the first day of class.

This pattern works well when the audience is already open to change but needs help choosing between options.

REFUTATION PATTERN

The refutation pattern is useful when the audience may disagree with the speaker or when the opposing arguments are well known. In this pattern, the speaker addresses opposing claims and shows why the speaker's position is stronger.

Basic structure:

I. State the opposing position fairly.

II. Explain the implications of that position.

III. Present evidence for your position.

IV. Show why your position is stronger.

Refutation should be fair. Do not attack weak versions of the opposing argument while ignoring the strongest objections. That damages credibility.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Persuasive speaking aims to influence an audience's attitudes, values, beliefs, behaviors, or actions. Ethical persuasion respects the audience and uses evidence, reasoning, emotion, and credibility responsibly.

The three major persuasive appeals are logos, pathos, and ethos. Logos appeals to reason and evidence. Pathos appeals to emotion and values. Ethos appeals to credibility and character. Strong persuasive speeches often use all three.

Persuasive arguments include claims, evidence, reasoning, and warrants. Claims may be claims of fact, value, or policy. Speakers should use credible evidence, address counterarguments, and avoid logical fallacies such as hasty generalization, false analogy, slippery slope, red herring, false dilemma, bandwagon, ad hominem, and straw person arguments.

Persuasive speeches can be organized using patterns such as problem-cause-solution, Monroe's Motivated Sequence, comparative advantage, and refutation. The best pattern depends on the audience, topic, purpose, and desired outcome.

KEY TERMS

Persuasive speech

Attitude

Value

Belief

Behavior

Action

Ethical persuasion

Manipulation

Logos

Pathos

Ethos

Credibility

Common ground

Audience needs

Claim

Evidence

Reasoning

Warrant

Claim of fact

Claim of value

Claim of policy

Counterargument

Deductive reasoning

Inductive reasoning

Logical fallacy

Hasty generalization

False analogy

Causal fallacy

Slippery slope

Red herring

Appeal to tradition

False dilemma

Bandwagon fallacy

Ad hominem

Straw person

Problem-cause-solution pattern

Monroe’s Motivated Sequence

Comparative advantage pattern

Refutation pattern

Call to action

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What is the main purpose of persuasive speaking?

2. How is ethical persuasion different from manipulation?

3. Why do persuasive speakers need to understand their audience?

4. What is the difference between logos, pathos, and ethos?

5. Why is common ground important in persuasion?

6. What is the difference between a claim of fact, a claim of value, and a claim of policy?

7. Why should persuasive speakers address counterarguments?

8. Which logical fallacy do you think is most common in everyday arguments? Why?

9. When would Monroe's Motivated Sequence be more useful than problem-cause-solution?

10. Why is a specific call to action important in persuasive speaking?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

CLAIM PRACTICE

Write one claim of fact, one claim of value, and one claim of policy for the same broad topic.

Broad topic options:

College costs

Social media

Public speaking

Artificial intelligence

Exercise

Fast food

Mental health

Transportation

Climate

Theater

For each claim, answer:

1. What kind of evidence would support this claim?

2. What might an opposing argument be?

3. What audience would be most interested in this claim?

FALLACY PRACTICE

Read the following statements and identify the fallacy.

1. Everyone in my group likes this idea, so it must be the best option.

2. If we let students revise one assignment, soon they will expect to revise every assignment forever.

3. My roommate tried meditation once and hated it, so meditation does not work.

4. We should ignore her argument about parking because she is always complaining.

5. This policy has been around for years, so there is no reason to change it.

After identifying the fallacy, revise each statement into a stronger argument.

PERSUASIVE OUTLINE PRACTICE

Choose one persuasive topic and create a basic outline using one of the following patterns:

Problem-cause-solution

Monroe's Motivated Sequence

Comparative advantage

Refutation

Your outline should include:

1. Specific purpose.

2. Thesis statement.

3. Three main points.

4. One piece of evidence for each main point.

5. One counterargument.

6. One call to action.

Chapter 23

SPEAKING ON SPECIAL OCCASIONS

Learning Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

1. Explain the purpose of special occasion speaking.
2. Identify common types of special occasion speeches.
3. Prepare an effective speech of introduction.
4. Prepare an effective speech of acceptance.
5. Prepare an effective toast or roast.
6. Prepare an effective eulogy or memorial tribute.
7. Use language, tone, and delivery that fit the occasion.
8. Balance preparation, sincerity, brevity, and audience awareness.

A special occasion speech is a speech prepared for a specific event, ceremony, celebration, or moment of recognition. Unlike informative speeches, which primarily aim to explain, or persuasive speeches, which aim to influence, special occasion speeches are shaped by the event itself.

The purpose of a special occasion speech may be to entertain, celebrate, commemorate, inspire, honor, introduce, accept, or pay tribute. These speeches are common at weddings, funerals, award ceremonies, graduations, banquets, retirements, conferences, community events, performances, and public ceremonies.

Special occasion speeches may be brief, but that does not make them easy. A two-minute toast can succeed or fail quickly. A eulogy can carry emotional weight. An introduction can set the tone for an entire event. An acceptance speech can reveal humility or ego. Because these speeches often happen during meaningful moments, the speaker should prepare carefully.

THE OCCASION SHAPES THE SPEECH

The first rule of special occasion speaking is to understand the occasion. A speech at a wedding should not sound like a lecture. A eulogy should not sound like a stand-up routine. An award introduction should not become the speaker's autobiography. The event tells the speaker what kind of tone, length, language, and purpose are appropriate.

Before preparing a special occasion speech, ask:

What is the purpose of the event?

Who is being honored or remembered?

What does the audience expect?

What tone fits the moment?

How formal or informal should the speech be?

How much time do I have?

What should the audience feel by the end?

What should the focus be?

Special occasion speaking is not about showing off. It is about serving the moment.

USE CEREMONIAL LANGUAGE

Special occasion speeches often use ceremonial language. Ceremonial language is language that marks the significance of an event. It may be more polished, emotional, reflective, humorous, or elevated than everyday speech.

This does not mean the speech should sound fake or overdramatic. It should still sound like the speaker. But the language should fit the importance of the occasion.

For example, instead of saying:

She was a really good teacher and everyone liked her.

A ceremonial version might say:

She made students feel seen, challenged, and capable of more than they believed they could do.

Ceremonial language gives shape to the meaning of the moment.

SPEECHES OF INTRODUCTION

The purpose of a speech of introduction is to prepare the audience for the main speaker. A good introduction speech warms up the audience, establishes the speaker's credibility, previews the topic, and creates anticipation.

The focus should be on the person being introduced, not on the person giving the introduction.

A strong speech of introduction should:

Be brief.

Name the speaker clearly.

Establish the speaker's qualifications.

Connect the speaker to the occasion.

Preview the speaker's topic or purpose.

Build audience interest.

Invite the audience to welcome the speaker.

For example:

Tonight's speaker is Dr. Maya Rodriguez, a public health researcher whose work focuses on community access to mental health care. For the past fifteen years, she has worked with schools, clinics, and nonprofit organizations to expand support for underserved communities. Tonight, she will speak about how public health begins long before someone enters a doctor's office. Please join me in welcoming Dr. Maya Rodriguez.

A speech of introduction should usually be short. In many situations, one to three minutes is enough. If the introduction is longer than the speaker's first main point, something has gone wrong.

AVOID THESE INTRODUCTION MISTAKES

Common mistakes in speeches of introduction include:

Talking too much about yourself.

Mispronouncing the speaker's name.

Giving away the speaker's entire speech.

Exaggerating the speaker's accomplishments.

Making jokes that embarrass the speaker.

Reading a long biography without energy.

Forgetting to ask the audience to welcome the speaker.

Always confirm the pronunciation of the speaker's name. A name is not a place to improvise.

SPEECHES OF PRESENTATION

A speech of presentation is given when presenting an award, honor, gift, or recognition. The purpose is to explain why the recognition is being given and to honor the recipient.

A strong presentation speech should:

Name the award or recognition.

Explain what the award represents.

Describe why the recipient deserves it.

Mention specific accomplishments or qualities.

Keep the focus on the recipient.

Invite the recipient forward to accept the honor.

For example:

The Excellence in Teaching Award recognizes an instructor who demonstrates dedication, creativity, and deep commitment to student success. This year's recipient has not only challenged students to think critically, but has also created a classroom where students feel supported, capable, and heard. Please join me in congratulating Professor Elena Martinez.

A presentation speech should feel sincere, specific, and concise. Avoid generic praise that could apply to anyone. Specific details make the honor meaningful.

ACCEPTANCE SPEECHES

An acceptance speech is a response to receiving an award, honor, gift, or recognition. The purpose is to accept graciously, express appreciation, recognize others, and reflect briefly on the meaning of the honor.

A strong acceptance speech should:

Thank the organization or people giving the award.

Acknowledge those who helped you.

Show humility and gratitude.

Share briefly what the honor means to you.

Avoid bragging.

Avoid going too long.

End with appreciation.

If you think you might receive an award, prepare a few remarks ahead of time. Waiting until you are already walking to the microphone is not a strategy. It is a public experiment.

A basic acceptance speech might include:

Thank you for this honor.

I am grateful to the people or organization presenting it.

This award matters to me because…

I want to recognize the people who helped me.

I am honored to accept it.

Example:

Thank you for this recognition. I am deeply grateful to the committee and to everyone who made this event possible. This award means a great deal to me be-

cause it reflects work that has never been done alone. I have been supported by colleagues, students, friends, and family who pushed me, challenged me, and believed in the work even when it was difficult. I accept this honor with gratitude and with renewed commitment to keep doing the work it represents.

A good acceptance speech should be gracious. It should not become a complete autobiography with lighting cues.

TOASTS

A toast is a brief speech that honors a person, group, event, or occasion. Toasts are common at weddings, anniversaries, birthdays, retirements, celebrations, and banquets.

A strong toast should be:

Brief.

Warm.

Specific.

Appropriate.

Focused on the honoree or occasion.

Positive in tone.

Easy for the audience to follow.

A toast often includes a short story, a meaningful quality about the person being honored, and a final line inviting the audience to raise a glass or join in celebration.

Example:

I have known Marcus for ten years, and one thing has always been true: he shows up for the people he loves. Whether it is helping a friend move, answering a call late at night, or making everyone laugh when the room feels heavy, Marcus reminds us what loyalty looks like. Tonight, we celebrate not only his birthday, but the kindness, humor, and generosity he brings into every room. Please raise a glass to Marcus.

A toast does not need to be perfect. It needs to be sincere, focused, and appropriate.

ROASTS

A roast is a humorous tribute in which speakers jokingly tease or poke fun at the honoree. The key word is tribute. The goal is to celebrate the person, not humiliate them.

Roasts require strong judgment. Humor should be playful, not cruel. The audience should feel that the teasing comes from affection and respect.

A strong roast should:

Keep the honoree's dignity intact.

Use humor the honoree can handle.

Avoid sensitive or private topics.

Avoid jokes about trauma, appearance, identity, or serious personal struggles.

Balance teasing with sincere appreciation.

Stay brief.

End warmly.

Before including a joke, ask:

Would I say this if the person's family were in the room?

Will the honoree actually laugh?

Is this joke affectionate or mean?

Does this reveal something private?

Could this damage the relationship?

Is the joke worth the risk?

If the answer is uncertain, cut the joke. Comedy is not improved by panic.

A good roast makes the honoree feel seen and celebrated. A bad roast makes everyone quietly stare at the table centerpiece.

EULOGIES AND MEMORIAL TRIBUTES

A eulogy is a speech given to honor someone who has died. A memorial tribute may serve a similar purpose at a funeral, memorial service, celebration of life, or private gathering.

The purpose of a eulogy is not only to express grief. It is also to remember the person, honor their life, and offer comfort to those who are mourning.

A strong eulogy may include:

A brief introduction of your relationship to the person.

A few meaningful qualities of the person.

One or two specific stories.

A reflection on what the person meant to others.

A message of comfort.

A closing thought that honors their memory.

It is natural to feel emotional during a eulogy. The goal is not to pretend you are untouched by grief. The goal is to prepare enough that you can continue with care.

If you become emotional, pause. Take a breath. Look down at your notes. Continue when you are able. Most audiences will understand.

Use humor carefully. A gentle, loving story may bring warmth to the room. But avoid humor that could feel insensitive, private, or disrespectful. When in doubt, choose tenderness over cleverness.

Avoid exaggerating the person into perfection. A eulogy does not need to pretend the person had no flaws. It should focus on the qualities, memories, and impact that deserve to be honored.

Example:

My grandmother had a way of making ordinary moments feel like family traditions. Sunday dinner was never just dinner. It was a table full of stories, too much food, and the feeling that everyone had a place. She taught us that love was not always dramatic. Sometimes love was a plate wrapped in foil, a phone call at the right time, or a chair saved for you before you arrived.

That kind of specific memory can say more than a list of general compliments.

SPEECHES OF TRIBUTE

A speech of tribute honors a person, group, institution, or idea. Tribute speeches may occur at retirements, anniversaries, award ceremonies, memorials, community events, or celebrations.

A tribute speech should focus on why the person or subject deserves recognition. It may celebrate achievements, character, service, sacrifice, creativity, leadership, or lasting impact.

A strong tribute speech should:

Identify who or what is being honored.

Explain why the tribute is deserved.

Use specific examples.

Connect the tribute to shared values.

Use sincere and appropriate language.

Avoid empty praise.

End with a memorable closing thought.

Weak tribute:

She is amazing, kind, wonderful, and inspiring.

Stronger tribute:

She stayed after class with students who felt lost, answered emails long after office hours, and made every person believe they were capable of finishing what they started.

Specific praise is stronger than generic praise.

COMMEMORATIVE SPEECHES

A commemorative speech honors a person, event, place, idea, or group by focusing on meaning and shared values. These speeches often appear at graduations, memorials, anniversaries, dedications, and public ceremonies.

The purpose is not simply to inform the audience about what happened. The purpose is to help the audience reflect on why it matters.

Commemorative speeches often focus on values such as:

Courage.

Service.

Sacrifice.

Hope.

Community.

Justice.

Creativity.

Perseverance.

Leadership.

Love.

Memory.

A commemorative speech should use vivid language, strong examples, and a tone appropriate to the occasion. It should help the audience feel the significance of the moment.

INSPIRATIONAL SPEECHES

An inspirational speech encourages the audience by focusing on hope, resilience, purpose, possibility, or shared commitment. These speeches may occur at graduations, team events, ceremonies, leadership gatherings, or community meetings.

Inspirational speeches should be grounded. Empty motivational language can sound fake. Telling people to “believe in themselves” is not enough unless the speaker connects that idea to real experiences, obstacles, and action.

A strong inspirational speech should:

Recognize the reality of challenges.

Connect to shared values.

Use vivid examples or stories.

Offer hope without pretending everything is easy.

Encourage the audience toward a meaningful action or mindset.

End with a strong final image or line.

Inspiration works best when it feels earned.

BE BRIEF

Special occasion speeches often happen as part of a larger event. The speaker should respect the schedule, the audience, and the other people involved.

A short, strong speech is usually better than a long, wandering one. Brevity shows preparation. It also shows respect.

Ask:

How much time was I given?

What does the audience need from me?

What is the one main feeling or idea I want to leave behind?

What can I cut?

Am I repeating myself?

Is this story necessary?

If you are not the main event, do not become the main event by refusing to stop talking.

MATCH TONE TO THE OCCASION

Tone is especially important in special occasion speaking. Tone refers to the speaker's attitude toward the subject, audience, and occasion.

A tone may be:

Celebratory.

Respectful.

Warm.

Humorous.

Reflective.

Solemn.

Grateful.

Hopeful.

Inspirational.

Playful.

Formal.

Informal.

The wrong tone can make a speech feel uncomfortable. A wedding toast that becomes bitter, an acceptance speech that becomes arrogant, or a eulogy that becomes careless can damage the moment.

Before speaking, ask: What does this occasion need from me?

PRACTICE THE EMOTIONAL PARTS

Special occasion speeches often involve emotion. The speaker may feel nervous, proud, grateful, excited, sad, or overwhelmed. That is normal.

Practice helps you manage those emotions. If a line is likely to make you emotional, practice it out loud. Decide where you might pause. Keep notes available. Mark the names you must remember. If the moment is serious, avoid improvising too much.

Practicing does not make the speech less sincere. It makes the sincerity easier to deliver.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Special occasion speeches are shaped by the event, ceremony, celebration, or moment of recognition. Their purpose may be to entertain, celebrate, commemorate, inspire, honor, introduce, accept, or pay tribute.

Common special occasion speeches include speeches of introduction, speeches of presentation, acceptance speeches, toasts, roasts, eulogies, memorial tributes, tribute speeches, commemorative speeches, and inspirational speeches.

Special occasion speakers should understand the occasion, match the tone, use ceremonial language when appropriate, remain brief, and keep the focus where it belongs. These speeches often require a balance of preparation and sincerity.

Strong special occasion speeches do not simply fill time. They help the audience recognize the meaning of the moment.

KEY TERMS

Special occasion speech

Ceremonial language

Speech of introduction

Speech of presentation

Acceptance speech

Toast

Roast

Eulogy

Memorial tribute

Tribute speech

Commemorative speech

Inspirational speech

Brevity

Tone

Occasion

Honoree

Audience expectations

Sincerity

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How is a special occasion speech different from an informative or persuasive speech?

2. Why should the occasion shape the speech?

3. What makes a speech of introduction effective?

4. Why is humility important in an acceptance speech?

5. What is the difference between a toast and a roast?

6. What should a speaker keep in mind when preparing a eulogy?

7. Why is specific praise stronger than general praise?

8. How can a speaker match tone to the occasion?

APPLICATION ACTIVITY

SPEECH OF INTRODUCTION PRACTICE

Choose a real or fictional speaker to introduce. Write a one-minute introduction that includes:

1. The speaker’s name.

2. The speaker’s qualifications.

3. The topic or purpose of the speech.

4. A reason the audience should listen.

5. A final line inviting the audience to welcome the speaker.

TOAST PRACTICE

Write a brief toast for one of the following occasions:

Birthday.

Wedding.

Retirement.

Graduation.

Team celebration.

Opening night performance.

Family gathering.

Your toast should include:

1. The person or occasion being honored.

2. One specific story or quality.

3. A warm closing line.

EULOGY OR TRIBUTE REFLECTION

Choose a person, group, or place you would like to honor. This does not have to be someone who has died. Write a short tribute that includes:

1. Who or what is being honored.

2. Why they deserve recognition.

3. One specific memory, example, or contribution.

4. A closing line that captures their meaning or impact.

RESTRICTED OR OVERUSED TOPICS

The following topics require instructor approval before being used for a speech. These topics are not automatically bad, unimportant, or inappropriate. Many of them matter a great deal. However, they are frequently overused in public speaking courses, too broad for a short speech, or likely to produce repetitive arguments that audiences have heard many times before.

If you are interested in one of these topics, you must narrow it into a specific, fresh, researchable angle and receive approval before moving forward.

Restricted or overused topics include:

Abortion

Cloning

Death penalty

Drunk driving

Euthanasia

Exercise and general health benefits

Climate change or global warming

Gun control

Joining a political party

Joining a religion

Legalizing or decriminalizing marijuana

Lowering the drinking age

Obesity

Democratic Party vs. Republican Party speeches

Power bracelets

Puppy mills

Steroids

Same-sex marriage

Why college athletes should be paid

Eating breakfast

Caffeine

Bitcoin

Serial killers

Mental health awareness

Mindfulness

Social media is bad

Social media detox

Digital addiction

AI in education

AI will take over the world

Technology is hurting children

Video games are good or bad

Fast fashion

Unpaid internships

Tipping and fair wages

Financial literacy

Student debt

College should be free

Public speaking should be required

College athletes and NIL

Professional athletes are paid too much

Fitness trackers

Gut health or the gut microbiome

Sex education

Veterans transitioning to civilian life

Harassment as harmless teasing

Female coaches in sports

Luxury brands and logos

Positive thinking

Procrastination

Fear of failure

Cryptocurrency scams

Autonomous vehicles, Waymo, Uber, or Lyft

True crime

Illuminati or secret society theories

Celebrity biographies or personal scandals

POLITICS AND POLITICAL TOPICS

Political topics are not automatically forbidden. However, speeches that simply promote or attack a political party, candidate, elected official, or broad ideology are

restricted. These speeches often become repetitive, partisan, and difficult to support in a balanced way.

Avoid broad political speeches such as:

Democrats are better than Republicans.

Republicans are better than Democrats.

Everyone should join my political party.

This candidate is terrible.

This candidate will save the country.

Liberals are ruining America.

Conservatives are ruining America.

Young people should vote for one party.

Religious people should vote a certain way.

People with my identity should vote a certain way.

A political topic may be approved if it focuses on a specific policy, civic issue, public problem, historical development, or government process.

Stronger political topic examples include:

How ranked-choice voting works.

Whether election day should be a federal holiday.

How campaign advertising affects voter perception.

How misinformation spreads during election seasons.

Whether campuses should provide nonpartisan voting resources.

How local governments fund public transportation.

How public policy affects college affordability.

Whether cities should expand cooling centers during extreme heat.

How voter registration rules affect college students.

How school boards influence local education policy.

HOW TO REVISE A RESTRICTED TOPIC

A restricted topic may still work if it is narrowed into a specific angle.

Instead of:

Social media is bad.

Try:

How infinite scroll is designed to keep users watching longer.

Instead of:

Mental health awareness.

Try:

How college students can recognize the difference between everyday stress and burnout.

Instead of:

Climate change.

Try:

How extreme heat affects students who commute by bus.

Instead of:

Student debt.

Try:

How interest accumulation affects borrowers after graduation.

Instead of:

Fast fashion.

Try:

How clothing overproduction contributes to textile waste.

Instead of:

AI in education.

Try:

How students can use AI brainstorming tools ethically during early speech preparation.

Instead of:

True crime.

Try:

How true crime media can distort public understanding of crime rates.

Instead of:

Exercise is good for you.

Try:

How ten-minute walking breaks can improve focus during long study sessions.

APPROVAL STANDARD

A restricted topic may be approved if it meets the following standards:

The topic is specific.

The topic offers a fresh angle.

The topic is appropriate for the audience and occasion.

The speech has a clear informative or persuasive purpose.

The speaker can use credible and current sources.

The speech is not designed merely to shock, provoke, or offend.

The speaker can address the issue respectfully and ethically.

The topic does not simply repeat a familiar argument the audience has heard many times before.

The goal is not to avoid serious issues. The goal is to avoid lazy, recycled, overly broad speeches. Strong speakers take familiar topics and find focused, original, well-supported ways to discuss them.

Acceptance speech

An acceptance speech is responding to getting an award.

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Chapter 23 - Speaking on Special Occasions

Active listening

Is focused and purposeful

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 5 - Listeners and Speakers

Ad Hominem argument

An argument that targets a person instead of the issue at hand in an attempt to incite an audiences dislike of that person.

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Alliteration

The occurrence of the same letter or sound at the beginning of adjacent or closely connected words.

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Chapter 16 - Language

Analogy

An **analogy** is a comparison that illustrates the similarities between things.

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Chapter 21 - Informative Speaking

Anaphora

The use of a word referring to or replacing a word used earlier in a sentence, to avoid repetition, such as do in I like it and so do they.

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Chapter 16 - Language

Appeal to Tradition

An argument suggesting that audience members should agree with a claim because that is the way it has always been done.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Argument

An argument makes a claim and backs it up with reasoning.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Arrangement

Is the process of arranging and organizing your arguments for maximum impact.

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Audience analysis

The process of gathering and understanding what motivates your audience with the purpose of preparing your speech in ways that will be meaningful to them

---

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 6 - Analyzing the Audience

Balance

Balance means that each one of your points are about equal to one another.

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 12 - Organization

Bandwagon Fallacy

An argument that uses unsubstantiated general opinion as its false bias.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Bar graph

A bar graph is best when comparing variables quantitatively.

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Chapter 20 - Presentation Aids

Brief example

Will offer a single illustration of a point

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Causal Fallacy

Involves making a faulty causal connection.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Channel

The medium through which the speaker sends the message

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Chronological pattern

A chronological pattern of organization means laying out information in terms of how it occurred or will occur over time.

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Chapter 13 - Organizational Patterns

Claims of fact

Claims of fact address whether or not something is true or not true or whether something did or did not happen.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Claims of policy

Claims of policy advocate for a specific action to be taken or approved of.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Claims of value

Claims of value address issues of judgment by trying to show that something is right or wrong, good or bad, moral or immoral.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Coherence

Coherence means that your ideas are well organized and logical.

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Chapter 12 - Organization

Context

Anything that influences the speaker, the audience, the occasion and then ultimately the speech

---

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Coordinate points

Are of equal importance and are indicated by their parallel alignment

---

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Coordination and subordination

The logical placement of ideas in relation to their importance to one another

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Copyright

Legal protection afforded by the original creators of literary and artistic works

---

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 4 - Ethical Public Speaking

Decoding

The process of interpreting the message

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Defensive listening

When we decide ahead of time that we are not going to like the speaker or that we know better

---

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Chapter 5 - Listeners and Speakers

Demographics

The statistical characteristics of a given population

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Chapter 6 - Analyzing the Audience

Dyadic Communication

Happens between two people.

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Either or Fallacy

Also called a false dilemma, is an argument stating that there are a limited number of solutions to the problem, usually two.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Encoding

Process of converting thoughts into words

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Enthymeme

A syllogism with a missing part.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Ethos

Moral character

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Chapter 4 - Ethical Public Speaking

Etymology

Illustrates the root meaning of the term

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Chapter 21 - Informative Speaking

Eulogy

A eulogy is usually delivered by close friends or family members of the deceased.

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Chapter 23 - Speaking on Special Occasions

Examples

Help an audience understand ideas by making them more concrete

---

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Expert testimony

The opinions of professionals who are trained in the area of expertise

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Extemporaneously

Speaking extemporaneously is the combination of a memorized speech and an improvised one.

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Chapter 17 - Methods of Delivery

Extended examples

A narrative or anecdote

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

False analogy

A fallacy where an argument is based on misleading or superficial comparisons.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Feedback

Decode the meaning of the message

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First Amendment

Guarantees freedom of speech

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Chapter 4 - Ethical Public Speaking

Hasty generalization

Where one reaches a conclusion based on little evidence or nonexistent evidence.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Hate speech

Any offensive communication, verbal or nonverbal, that is directed against a person's racial, ethnic, religious, identified gender, or other related characteristics

---

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Chapter 4 - Ethical Public Speaking

Hypothetical example

A fictional example that you or someone else has created to Illustrate your point

---

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Impromptu

Impromptu speaking is improvised, spontaneous, or off the cuff - and often involves speaking with relatively short notice.

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Chapter 17 - Methods of Delivery

Informative speech

Provides an audience with new information - insights and innovative ways of thinking about a topic. The general purpose is to increase audiences awareness by imparting knowledge.

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Invention

Refers to the process of developing and refining your arguments.

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Key-word outlines

Key-word outlines are the simplest form of a delivery outline by utilizing the bare minimum - the simplest units of understanding to highlight the main and supporting points.

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Chapter 14 - Outlining the Speech

Lay testimony

Testimony by non-experts, gives first hand, eyewitness accounts and may reveal information that's unavailable to others

---

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Line graph

The line graph is good at depicting trends overtime or how things grow, change or evolve over time.

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Chapter 20 - Presentation Aids

Logical fallacy

A logical fallacy is an illogical way of reasoning.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Logos

Appealing to logic, or what Aristotle termed logos, is important especially when asking listeners to reach a conclusion based on a complicated issue.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Manuscript

Speaking from a manuscript means reading a speech verbatim from a prepared text that contains the entire speech word for word.

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Chapter 17 - Methods of Delivery

Mass communication

Occurs between a speaker and a large audience who are usually not present with the speaker or who are part of such an immense crowd that there can be little or no interaction between speaker and listener

---

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Memory

The process of learning and memorizing your speech so you can deliver it without the use of notes

---

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Message

The content of the communication process

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Metaphor

A metaphor also compares things, but it describes them as being the same.

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Chapter 16 - Language

Narrative

A story

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Noise

Any interference that occurs during the delivery of a message

---

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Oratory

Oratory is reciting a speech completely from memory.

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Chapter 17 - Methods of Delivery

Pathos

Appeal to emotions

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Peer-reviewed

Are evaluated by experts before they are published and supply the sources for the information they obtained

---

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Chapter 9 - Locating Supporting Material

Periodical

Anything that is regularly published like a magazine, newsletter or journal

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Chapter 9 - Locating Supporting Material

Persuasive speech

Intends to influence the attitudes, beliefs, values or actions of others

---

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Phrase outline

A phrase outline will use parts of what you wrote on the working outline to form each main point.

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Chapter 14 - Outlining the Speech

Pie chart

A **pie** or **circle** chart helps the audience compare portions of a whole.

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Chapter 20 - Presentation Aids

Pitch

Pitch has to do with how high or low you speak.

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Chapter 18 - The Voice

Plagiarism

Passing off another person's information as one's own

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Chapter 4 - Ethical Public Speaking

Preview statement

A summary of your main points of the speech

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Chapter 12 - Organization

Primary research

Any original or first-hand interviews or surveys

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Chapter 9 - Locating Supporting Material

Public speaking

Where a speaker delivers a message with a specific purpose to an audience of people who are present during the delivery of the speech

---

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Rate

Speaking **rate** is the pace or how fast or slow you are speaking.

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Chapter 18 - The Voice

Receiver

The recipient of the message

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Red Herring

This fallacy is used when someone attacks an issue by using irrelevant facts or arguments as distractions.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Review statement

Your review statement will review your three main points.

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Chapter 15 - Introducing and Concluding the Speech

Secondary research

Information produced by others

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Chapter 9 - Locating Supporting Material

Selective listening

When we selectively listen, we pay attention to what we want to hear and tune out the rest

---

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Chapter 5 - Listeners and Speakers

Shared meaning

The mutual understanding of a message and speaker.

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Simile

Compares things to another by using words such as like or as

Related Glossary Terms

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Chapter 16 - Language

Slippery Slope

The assumption that one case will lead to a series of events of or actions.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Small group communication

Involves a small number of people who can see and speak directly with one another.

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Source

The person who creates the message.

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Source credibility

Refers to the audience's level of trust in a source's track record for providing accurate information

---

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Chapter 11 - Citing Sources in your Speech

Speaker Credibility

Without credibility, your audience will not trust what you have to say. The audience needs to believe that you are a competent speaker, who can create logical arguments with convincing evidence. You can begin by mentioning how long you have studied the subject matter. If you are an expert on the topic, then that can help establish credibility. Your credibility also has to do with your reputation. If you have a bad reputation then an audience will be less inclined to listen. Monitor your behavior before and after you speak. If you are rude to an audience member, you will likely lose credibility with the entire crowd.

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Chapter 15 - Introducing and Concluding the Speech

Speaking outline

Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipisicing elit, sed do eiusmod tempor incididunt ut labore et dolore magna aliqua. Ut enim ad minim veniam, quis nostrud exercitation ullamco laboris nisi ut aliquip ex ea commodo consequat.

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Chapter 14 - Outlining the Speech

Special occasion speech

Marks a special event such as a wedding, funeral, commencement or banquet

---

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Style

The way the speaker uses language to express the speech ideas.

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Subordinate points

Given less weight than the main points they support.

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Supporting material

Examples, stories, testimony, facts, and statistics

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Syllogism

A true statement that relies on evidence which must be tested in order to form a conclusion.

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Chapter 22 - Persuasion

Testimony

Firsthand findings - eyewitness accounts and opinions

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Chapter 8 - Developing Supporting Material

Thematic statement

The thematic statement should be simple - preferably one concise sentence letting the audience know what the speech is about.

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Chapter 15 - Introducing and Concluding the Speech

Thesis statement

A thesis statement is a single declarative sentence which briefly explains what you will attempt to demonstrate or prove in your speech.

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Chapter 7 - Selecting a Topic and Purpose

Toast

A toast is a tribute to a specific person or towards an event being celebrated.

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Chapter 23 - Speaking on Special Occasions

Unity

A speech contains **unity** when it mentions points implied by the purpose and thesis statement

---

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Chapter 12 - Organization

Volume

Volume has to do with how loud or how soft you speak.

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Chapter 18 - The Voice

Working outline

The purpose of the working outline is to show how you are organizing your main points and how you use the evidence you have collected to develop supporting material that substantiates your claims.

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Chapter 14 - Outlining the Speech